

The Ashen Chronicles, Volume III: A Crown of Cinders

Chapter 1

The blood on Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed's hands had dried black by the time the bells began.

They rang from the dark beyond the walls, slow and hollow, each note passing through the stone like a fist through rotten cloth. He sat beneath a broken arch with his back against the cold, listening to the sound descend into him.

A bell meant surrender once.

A bell meant warning after.

Tonight it meant nothing that could save anyone.

"Captain."

The voice came from the stairwell. A figure climbed into the ruined chamber, carrying a hooded lamp and a leather case beneath one arm. The flame trembled across the iron fittings of the walls, across the blackened dust, across Brannoc's hands.

The stranger stopped when he saw them.

Brannoc looked down at his fingers. The blood had gathered in the creases and beneath the nails. It was not all his.

"Say what you came to say," Brannoc told him.

The stranger swallowed. "You were not meant to be here."

"I have been told worse by men with better knives."

Below them, something collapsed. Stone grated against stone. A gust of ash rose through the stairwell, carrying the bitter reek of burned grain and old smoke. Brannoc breathed it in. Hollowvale had smelled like that before the Accord came to it. Not smoke then. Wet earth. Horse dung. Boiled onions from the market vats.

The Accord of Mournthrone had devastated Hollowvale in 301 AS.

The sentence had been written in the leather case before the ink was dry.

The stranger opened it now and removed a folded sheet. His hands shook as he unfolded it.

Brannoc watched the paper rather than the man. "Who wrote that?"

"No name."

"Then it was written by a coward."

"It bears the seal of the recorders."

"There are no recorders left."

The stranger's mouth tightened. "There are always recorders."

Brannoc gave a low laugh. It hurt beneath his ribs. Pain had become a patient animal, lying curled inside him, opening one eye whenever he moved. He had been born in 255 AS, when the realm still pretended its ruins were foundations. He had spent his life learning the price of that pretense.

The stranger held out the sheet.

Brannoc did not take it.

“Read.”

“The Accord of Mournthron began in 297 AS and ended in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.”

The bells continued below.

“Again,” Brannoc said.

The stranger’s eyes flicked toward the stairwell. “Why?”

“Because you read it like a prayer.”

“It is a record.”

“Records are prayers for men who expect the dead to answer.”

The stranger read it again. His voice grew flatter the second time, and the words lost their shape in the chamber.

Brannoc closed his eyes.

He saw Mournthron without seeing it: its shadow over the war, its weight in every bargain, its name carried from mouth to mouth by men who had never stood beneath its walls. The Accord had begun as all such things began, with wax, knives hidden in sleeves, and promises poured into cups. It had become mud, famine, and the sound of gates giving way.

“What else?” he asked.

“The Accord’s collapse unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals.”

“A decade,” Brannoc murmured. “The realm has grown fond of long punishments.”

The stranger lowered the sheet.

“There is more.”

“There is always more.”

“The losing commander was bribed to withdraw.”

For a moment, Brannoc heard only the rain ticking against the broken roof.

Then he smiled.

The stranger stared at him. “You knew?”

“I suspected.”

“You said the retreat was madness.”

“I have called many sane men mad. It is one of the privileges of being a Sellsword Captain.”

The phrase sounded too formal in the ruined chamber. Major Sellsword Captain, the ledgers called him. As though a title could make a wall around a man. As though a rank could keep a blade from finding the seam in his armor.

The stranger glanced at Brannoc's hands again.

"Is it true," he asked, "what they say about you?"

"Which lie?"

"That you are the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown."

The blood on Brannoc's right hand cracked when he flexed it.

Somewhere beneath the rubble, a wounded man began to moan. The sound rose and fell with the bells.

Brannoc had heard the claim in taverns, under banners, beside graves. He had heard it spoken with contempt, with fear, with the hungry softness of men measuring a future throne. The Bleeding Crown had never acknowledged him. That was the word that mattered. Not denied. Not named. Unacknowledged.

A door left closed could still have someone standing behind it.

"Does the Crown know?" the stranger asked.

"The Crown knows what crowns always know."

"Which is?"

"That a head is beneath them."

The stranger's fingers tightened around the sheet. He had come expecting confession, perhaps. A dying man made useful by the nearness of death. Brannoc knew the look. Men believed a final hour stripped the lies from a tongue. They did not understand that death gave a man fewer reasons to be kind.

"What do you want?" Brannoc asked.

"Safe passage."

"For whom?"

The stranger looked toward the stairwell.

A soft scrape answered him from below.

Brannoc's hand went to the sword at his side. The motion pulled hot fire through his ribs, but the weapon came free a finger's breadth. Steel whispered.

The stranger went pale.

"Korvath Nightbrook," he said.

The name passed through the chamber like a rat slipping beneath a door.

Korvath Nightbrook emerged from the stairwell without a lamp. He wore the unobtrusive shape of a man accustomed to concealed trade: hood, dull cloth, boots darkened by mud. His face remained half-hidden, but his eyes held the wary patience of a smuggler who had survived by noticing what others missed.

"You brought him here?" Brannoc asked.

"I brought the case," said the stranger.

"Korvath brought himself."

"That is why he is alive," Korvath said.

His voice had the quiet scrape of a whetstone. He looked at Brannoc, then at the blood, then at the sword.

“Are you dying?”

“Not quickly enough to satisfy you.”

Korvath moved nearer. “Then listen quickly.”

Brannoc sheathed the sword. The bells had ceased. Their silence seemed louder than the ringing.

Korvath reached inside his coat and drew out a narrow bundle wrapped in grey cloth.

The stranger took one step back. “That was not part of the bargain.”

“No,” Korvath said. “It was part of the danger.”

He laid the bundle on a slab of fallen masonry and unwrapped it.

The object beneath was a grimoire bound in dark material that seemed to drink the lamp’s light. Its cover bore the name *Edge of Gloamreach*. The letters were shallow and precise, like wounds made by a careful hand.

Brannoc felt the air tighten around it.

“Attunement cost?” he asked.

“Forty-six,” said Korvath.

The stranger whispered something that might have been a curse.

Brannoc did not touch the grimoire. He had learned that some things demanded skin before they demanded blood.

“And the other?”

Korvath’s gaze shifted to the leather case.

The stranger flinched. “There is no other.”

Brannoc saw the lie arrive before the words finished leaving him.

“Open it,” he said.

“I already did.”

“Open it properly.”

The stranger looked at Korvath. Korvath gave no answer. After a moment, the stranger set down the paper and reached into the case’s inner lining. His fingers found a hidden catch. The leather gave with a small, damp click.

Inside lay a blade in a sheath of tarnished metal.

Even wrapped in darkness, it seemed bound by something more than leather. Thin cords crossed its hilt and vanished beneath the guard, three times knotted, each knot blackened as if by ancient fire.

“The Thrice-Bound Edge,” Korvath said.

Brannoc stared at it.

“Regalia,” the stranger murmured. “Forged in 123 AS.”

“No attunement cost is recorded,” Korvath said.

The stranger looked offended by the omission, as though the absence itself were a threat. “That does not mean there is none.”

“No,” Brannoc said. “It means whoever made it did not care to warn us.”

His hand hovered over the sheath.

For an instant, the chamber changed. The ash became snow. The broken arch became a hall of black pillars. He saw banners hanging without wind, and beneath them the five powers that had fed upon the Ashen Era: the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the Bleeding Crown.

No faces. No promises.

Only the understanding that every power in the realm wanted the same thing from a crown.

A throat beneath it.

Brannoc withdrew his hand.

Korvath watched him closely. “You cannot carry both.”

“I carry what I choose.”

“You carry a wound.”

“And you carry contraband. We all have burdens.”

“The Ashen Vanguard will be named victor,” the stranger said, almost pleading now. “The record says so. The Accord will end. The reprisals will follow. If you take that blade, they will say you sought the Crown.”

“They already say it.”

“They will believe it.”

Brannoc turned toward the broken wall.

Far beyond the ruin, the road ran toward the high country. Crookvale had been founded in 295 AS in The High Spires. It had been rebuilt, though rebuilding was a word used by men who did not sleep beneath roofs that might fall. Its garrison was 1004, and still it remained outside the core holdings. Brannoc had seen its crooked defenses, its hard-edged towers gripping the mountain like clenched teeth. A wary place. A resilient place. The kind that survived by expecting betrayal from the weather as well as from men.

Further still lay Fenspire, standing in the Gloaming Reach. Founded in 57 AS, it was a core location, garrisoned and disciplined, with a garrison of 3,742 beneath its stark spire. A fortress pretending to be a city. A city pretending it had not become a fortress.

Every road led somewhere armed.

Every gate had learned the shape of hunger.

“Captain,” the stranger said.

Brannoc looked back.

The man had drawn a knife. It was a small thing, made for letters or throats. His hand shook around it.

Brannoc felt the old danger gather in the room—not anger, not fear, but the cold arithmetic beneath both. He had been called the Red-Handed because blood found him wherever men gathered in numbers. The name had outlived the battles that earned it. It would outlive him.

He wondered whether the ledgers would record that.

He wondered whether they would record his death in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone, or merely mark the place where a name stopped being useful.

“Put it down,” Brannoc said.

The stranger’s eyes filled with tears. “You cannot let him leave.”

“Who?”

“Korvath.”

Korvath’s hand disappeared beneath his coat.

Brannoc rose.

The wound beneath his ribs opened. Warmth spread beneath his clothes. The stranger made a frightened sound and backed into the wall. Korvath moved at the same time, swift and silent, but Brannoc’s sword was already in his hand.

Below them, the bells began again.

Not slow now.

Not hollow.

A frantic peal burst through the ruin as flames climbed somewhere in the dark, and from the stairwell came the heavy tread of men ascending—closer, closer, while Brannoc stood between the grimoire, the bound regalia, and the two living men who had mistaken his last hour for an opportunity.

The first man broke the stairwell’s darkness with a shield raised before him. Firelight crawled over its rim. Behind him came another, then another, their boots striking the stone with the blunt certainty of men who believed the room already belonged to them.

Brannoc shifted his weight.

Pain opened under his ribs, wet and intimate. He felt it travel through him in a slow red thread, as though some patient hand were pulling him apart from within. His sword remained level. The point hovered between Korvath Nightbrook and the stranger pressed against the wall.

“Move,” Brannoc said.

The stranger stared at him.

“Not you,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s hand emerged from beneath his coat. Empty.

That was almost worse.

The smuggler's face had gone still. He wore concealment like another man wore a cloak: not to vanish, but to make every eye slide elsewhere. Now the mask had cracked. Fear showed through it, narrow and bright.

"You heard him," Korvath said to the stranger. "Go."

The stranger looked toward the stairwell. The ascending men were close enough that Brannoc could hear the leather creak of their harness and the drag of breath behind metal. Somewhere below, flame consumed timber with a hungry, snapping roar.

"I can't," the stranger whispered.

"You can," Brannoc said.

A blade appeared above the stair's broken lip.

Brannoc moved.

His sword struck the man's wrist before the shield could clear the opening. The blade rang against a vambrace. The man cried out, and the shield fell sideways, wedging itself across the narrow stair. The second man crashed into him. The third cursed. Their formation became a knot of iron, cloth, and flesh.

Brannoc kicked the fallen shield.

It struck the first man in the throat.

The sound he made was small. He folded backward into the men behind him, and for one precious breath the stairwell was blocked.

"Now," Brannoc said.

Korvath did not run.

His eyes had gone to the table.

To the grimoire.

To the regalia bound in black cord.

Brannoc saw the calculation enter him and despised the clarity of it. Korvath was measuring weight, value, escape. A smuggler's arithmetic. Not courage. Not loyalty. Only what could be carried through a closing door.

Brannoc seized him by the front of his coat and slammed him against the wall.

The wound beneath his ribs flared. His vision whitened at the edges.

"Take one," Brannoc said.

Korvath's gaze flicked toward the grimoire.

"No."

"The book or the blade. Not both."

"The Edge of Gloamreach is worth—"

"I did not ask what it was worth."

The men on the stairs began to wrench the shield free. Wood groaned. Iron scraped stone.

Korvath's mouth tightened. "You know what the thing is?"

"I know enough."

"You know nothing."

"That is why you are still breathing."

Korvath glanced at the sword between them. "And the stranger?"

The stranger had not moved. He stood beneath the blackened archway, one hand clamped over his mouth, staring at the gore beginning to shine on Brannoc's blade. His face seemed bloodless in the furnace-glow. He looked less like a conspirator now than a man who had walked into a room and found the world's teeth waiting.

Brannoc kept his eyes on Korvath.

"Take the Edge of Gloamreach," he said. "Leave him."

A tremor went through the smuggler—not fear this time. Anger.

There it was. The thing beneath the caution.

"You don't get to decide that."

"I command Blackford."

The words came out harder than he intended, and the room seemed to hear them. Even the bells, shrilling above the ruin, could not drown the old authority in his voice.

"Since 285 AS, Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed has commanded Blackford."

Korvath stared at him.

Brannoc had said the words to men who needed a banner before they needed a name. He had said them in rain, in ash, in halls where the floor had been scrubbed clean and the walls had not. Command was not a title. It was the space that opened when other men decided their lives were safer inside your shadow.

The stairs buckled under another impact.

Korvath's expression altered. Not submission. Recognition.

Then he laughed once, without humor.

"Blackford," he said. "You drag that old claim behind you like a chain."

"It is not a claim."

"No?" Korvath glanced at the bound regalia. "Then why are you bleeding for it?"

Brannoc looked down.

Blood had reached his glove. It shone dark across the knuckles, gathered in the creases, and made the old epithet seem freshly earned. The Red-Handed. Men had given him that name for reasons that no longer mattered. Names survived their causes. They clung like burrs.

"Because men who come for it usually mean to use it."

“And you don’t?”

“I mean to keep it from them.”

“That is not the same.”

“No,” Brannoc said. “It is worse.”

The shield tore loose.

The first man surged into the chamber on one knee, one hand at his throat. Brannoc turned and drove his sword down through the gap beneath the raised arm. The blade passed into the shoulder with a thick resistance. He wrenched it free before the man fell fully, using the collapsing body to foul the next advance.

The second man tried to step over him.

Brannoc caught the descending sword on his own. The impact jarred his wound. His knees nearly gave. Steel grated against steel. The other man leaned into him, visor dark, breath harsh within the helm.

Brannoc smelled hot iron and old smoke.

He smelled his own blood.

The stranger made a broken noise and fled toward the far side of the room.

Not toward the door.

Toward the table.

Brannoc saw him reach for the cord around The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The regalia did not move.

The stranger’s fingers closed over it. His face twisted. He made no sound this time, but his arm sagged as if the object had become heavier than stone. The black cord drew taut beneath his hand.

“Leave it!” Brannoc roared.

The man looked up.

Something in his eyes had changed. Not wonder. Not greed. An awful pleading, as though he had touched a buried thing and found it awake beneath the earth.

Korvath saw it too.

He drove his shoulder into Brannoc’s back.

The swordsman staggered. The armored man’s blade slid from his guard and opened a line along Brannoc’s sleeve. Heat followed. Brannoc turned with the stumble, let the pain carry him, and struck low.

The armored man’s knee gave.

Brannoc seized the back of his neck and brought his forehead down against the broken stone. Once. The helm rang. Again. The man collapsed, sword slipping from his hand.

A third man entered behind him.

Brannoc kicked the fallen blade across the floor. It struck the stranger's ankle. The stranger cried out and fell beside the table, releasing The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The cord lay still.

The grimoire lay beside it, its cover dark beneath a skin of dust and ash.

Korvath had reached the table.

His fingers closed around the Edge of Gloamreach.

"Don't," Brannoc said.

Korvath lifted it.

The room seemed to draw inward.

No wind moved. No flame guttered. Yet the darkness beneath the table deepened, gathering around the smuggler's wrist. The grimoire's pages stirred beneath its cover, one after another, though no hand touched them. A smell rose from it: damp stone, extinguished candles, something bitter enough to taste.

Korvath's face tightened.

"What did you do?" the stranger whispered.

"Nothing," Korvath said.

That was a lie. Brannoc knew the shape of lies. This one had been spoken before the question.

The armored man behind Brannoc raised his sword.

Brannoc turned too slowly.

The blade descended.

Korvath thrust the grimoire between them.

Steel struck its cover.

A sound moved through the chamber—not a crack, not a cry, but the distant murmur of countless voices speaking from behind a closed door. The impact threw the armored man backward. His sword spun away. He struck the stairwell wall and slid down among the bodies.

Korvath stared at the grimoire in his hands.

The Edge of Gloamreach had opened.

Its pages were blank.

Then ink began to spread across them.

Black veins crawled from the binding, branching over the pale paper in crooked strokes. Brannoc watched the marks gather into shapes he could not read and understood, with the instinctive certainty of a man recognizing a drawn bow, that the book was not waiting for a reader.

It was waiting for an answer.

The bells faltered above them.

One peal.

Silence.

Then another, lower and slower, traveling through the foundations.

The stranger crawled backward. "Put it down."

Korvath's knuckles had gone white around the cover.

"Put it down," the stranger said again.

"What is it writing?"

"I don't know."

"You brought me here."

"I brought you to the room."

"And you knew."

"I knew enough to be afraid."

Brannoc stepped toward them. His sword felt heavier now, not from the blood on it but from the weight gathering in the air. The room had become a held breath. The grimoire's pages turned faster. Ink spilled in thin rivers, running over the edges and dripping onto Korvath's coat.

Brannoc reached for the book.

Korvath jerked away.

Behind him, the stranger whispered, "It remembers the hand."

Brannoc stopped.

The phrase found some locked chamber in him. Not memory. Something older than memory, a pressure behind the eyes. He looked at his own hand—the red-streaked glove, the fingers curled around the hilt—and saw the ink on the page arrange itself.

A single word.

Not a name.

A command.

The stone beneath them trembled.

From below came the muffled crash of a door breaking open.

More men were coming.

Korvath shut the grimoire.

The darkness vanished.

For an instant, nothing moved except the blood slipping from Brannoc's wound and pattering softly onto the floor.

Then the stranger lunged for The Thrice-Bound Edge.

Brannoc caught him by the throat.

He lifted him just enough to take his feet from the ground. The man clawed at Brannoc's wrist, eyes bulging, while Korvath backed away with the grimoire clutched to his chest.

"You have one breath," Brannoc said.

The stranger's hands beat against him.

"One."

The stairwell filled with voices.

"Two."

Korvath looked toward the rear passage, where the ruin had split open into a narrow black cleft.

The stranger's face purpled.

"Three."

Brannoc threw him aside.

He struck the floor beside the regalia and lay there gasping. Korvath moved at once, not toward the passage but toward him, and that choice—small, involuntary, revealing—cost them both the moment they had left.

Brannoc stepped between them.

The first of the new men appeared at the stair.

And from the darkness beyond the table, something answered the bells.

The answer came again, closer.

Not a voice. Not an animal. The stone itself seemed to draw breath, and the cleft behind the table narrowed as though some vast throat had begun to swallow the ruin.

The first man on the stair raised a hooded lantern. Its light slid over a hooked blade, a mailed shoulder, the pale gleam of teeth.

Brannoc struck him before the man could descend.

His fist met the lantern. Glass burst. Oil sheeted over the stranger's arm, and the darkness took fire in a sudden blue flare. The man screamed, but the stair behind him was already crowded. Bodies pressed forward. Steel rasped against stone.

Brannoc caught the burning sleeve and dragged its owner down three steps. The man's skull struck the edge of one. The blue fire went out.

"Move," Brannoc said.

Korvath did not move. He knelt beside the fallen stranger, one hand still clamped around the Edge of Gloamreach. The grimoire's black cover drank the firelight that remained. Its clasps trembled beneath Korvath's fingers.

"The passage," Korvath said.

"I saw it."

"Then use it."

Brannoc looked past him. The rear cleft had become a seam of absolute dark. No rubble had fallen into it. No dust drifted from its mouth. Darkness gathered there with intention.

The bells began again.

One note from beneath the floor.

One from inside the walls.

One from the grimoire.

Korvath flinched at the third. Brannoc saw it and understood that the smuggler had not stolen the book. He had been carrying it because the book had chosen a pair of hands, and those hands had belonged to a coward until Brannoc had made the coward desperate.

The stair disgorged another man. Then another.

“Who sent you?” Brannoc demanded.

The nearest attacker came at him with a short sword.

Brannoc turned aside, caught the man’s wrist, and drove an elbow into his throat. The man folded. A second blade cut the air where Brannoc’s neck had been. He seized the fallen sword and flung it backward. It struck the third man in the chest with a wet, muffled sound.

“Who sent you?”

No answer. Only boots. Too many boots.

Korvath rose at last. The Edge of Gloamreach hung from his hand, its spine flexing like something alive.

“Those are not cartel men,” he whispered.

Brannoc shoved him toward the cleft. “You know every lawful channel in this district?”

“I know the unlawful ones.”

“Then name them.”

“Not while they are trying to kill us.”

A blade glanced from Brannoc’s forearm. Pain opened bright and clean. He answered with the pommel, crushing the attacker’s mouth. Blood painted his knuckles. The sight steadied him. Men called him the Red-Handed for reasons that had once been useful and later become inconvenient. He had never cared which version of the truth frightened them most.

The stairwell filled with smoke and the smell of hot oil. Somewhere above, someone shouted for the doors to be barred.

The ruin had become a trap. The men below were driving them toward the dark, while whatever waited in the cleft had begun its patient reply.

Korvath backed toward it.

Brannoc caught his collar.

“Do not go in blind.”

“I have gone in blind all my life.”

“You have gone in paid.”

Korvath’s eyes flicked to the regalia lying near the table. The Thrice-Bound Edge rested where it had fallen, its surface dull beneath the smoke. It had been forged in 123 AS, long before either of them had been born, long before the realm had learned to mistake surviving ruins for ruling them.

The stranger Brannoc had thrown aside stirred on the floor.

“Do you know what you’re holding?” Brannoc asked him.

The stranger’s gaze fixed on the regalia.

“The price,” he said.

“For what?”

The man smiled through split lips. “For the crown.”

The word passed through Brannoc like a hand laid upon an old wound.

He had heard it whispered in rooms where the lamps were low and the doors watched. He had seen men kneel to an empty chair. He had learned early that blood could be a chain even when no one acknowledged the shackle.

He was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

The knowledge had never made him feel chosen. It had made every oath taste rotten.

A spear thrust down the stair. Brannoc caught the shaft under his arm, wrenched it sideways, and hauled the spearman over the steps. The man came down hard. Brannoc drove his heel into the man’s ribs and felt something give.

“Korvath,” he said.

The smuggler was staring into the cleft.

Within that darkness, shapes moved without making space for themselves. A shoulder. A hand. The suggestion of a face turned toward them, though no features held long enough to be seen.

“The Edge of Gloamreach has an attunement cost of 46,” Korvath said.

Brannoc looked at him.

“What?”

“It is written inside. Forty-six.” Korvath’s voice had gone thin. “I thought it meant coin. I thought—”

“You thought a grimoire was merchandise.”

“I am a Smuggler.”

The admission came without shame. It was almost a prayer.

The men on the stair surged together. Brannoc seized the fallen spear and swept it low. Ankles broke. Bodies tumbled. One attacker fell headfirst and took another with him. The stair became a knot of armor, limbs, and curses.

“Read the rest,” Brannoc said.

Korvath opened the book.

The pages turned by themselves.

A cold wind rushed from the cleft. The flames guttered toward it. Brannoc felt the temperature leave his skin, felt the old ache in his joints sharpen as though winter had found the marrow.

Letters surfaced on the page, black at first, then red.

Korvath bent over them.

“‘The bound hand opens the way.’”

“Whose hand?”

The bells stopped.

Every man on the stair froze.

The silence afterward was worse than the sound. Brannoc heard the drip of oil. Heard Korvath swallow. Heard, beneath the floor, a slow pressure gathering against the stones.

The stranger on the floor began to laugh.

Brannoc turned and stamped on his wrist. Bone cracked.

“Speak.”

The stranger’s laugh broke into a sob.

“You cannot outrun the accord.”

“What accord?”

But Korvath had found another line.

“The Accord of Mournthrone,” he murmured.

The name seemed to darken the ruin. It belonged to a conflict that had begun in 297 AS and would end in 301 AS, with the Ashen Vanguard named victor. Brannoc had heard the declaration in advance, as men heard all victories before they were won: through paid tongues, sealed letters, and the trembling confidence of those who had already sold their allegiance.

The stranger whispered, “When it collapses, the roads will burn.”

Korvath read on. “‘A decade of guerrilla reprisals follows the broken accord.’”

The page shuddered beneath his hand.

Brannoc saw it then—not as a vision, but as a certainty lodged behind the eyes. Blackford’s walls under moonless rain. A crown split by a sword. Men who had fought beneath one banner turning their blades upon every village that had fed them. The Ashen Vanguard’s victory reduced to another word for occupation.

And behind it all, a losing commander accepting a bribe to withdraw.

Not defeated. Purchased.

The truth had the coldness of a knife held against the throat.

“Who was paid?” Brannoc asked.

The stranger’s face had gone slack.

Korvath’s finger stopped on the page. “It doesn’t say.”

“It says enough.”

“No. It says someone will withdraw. It says the Accord of Mournthrone collapses. It says—”

A hand emerged from the cleft.

It was not flesh. It resembled a hand only because the darkness had learned the shape and was practicing it. Long fingers pressed against the edge of the passage. The stone groaned.

Korvath shut the grimoire.

The hand withdrew.

The men on the stair began to retreat.

That frightened Brannoc more than their assault. They had come expecting prey. Now they were looking over their shoulders at something that had not yet entered the room.

“Hold the stair,” Brannoc said.

No one obeyed.

He stepped into the narrow throat of it himself.

The first fleeing man collided with him. Brannoc caught him by the jaw and slammed him against the wall.

“Who sent you?”

The man stared at Brannoc’s bloodied hand.

“The Crown.”

“Which?”

The man’s mouth worked.

The name would not come.

Brannoc tightened his grip until the man’s boots scraped stone. The phrase rose in him again, bitter as bile: unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown. A hidden son for hidden wars. A claim preserved by those who needed a knife and denied by those who feared the hand holding it.

“The Bleeding Crown?” he asked.

The man’s eyes filled with terror.

“Not yours,” he said.

Behind Brannoc, Korvath whispered a word from the book.

The cleft opened.

Not widened. Opened.

The darkness peeled apart from floor to ceiling, revealing no passage beyond, no buried chamber, no foundation stones. It revealed a depth filled with pale drifting ash. Within that ash stood distant silhouettes, each crowned, each bound, each facing away.

The Thrice-Bound Edge lifted from the floor.

It did not fly. It rose with the solemn reluctance of something remembering an order. Its regalia gleamed once, and three bands of dull metal wound around its length like restraints.

Korvath dropped the Edge of Gloamreach.

The grimoire struck the floor and opened.

The pages showed a line of writing neither man had read before.

Brannoc saw his own name.

BRANNOC IRONMERE THE RED-HANDED.

Beneath it:

BORN IN 255 AS.

Beneath that, written in a hand so dark it seemed cut into the world:

DIED IN 300 AS DURING THE ACCORD OF MOURNTHRONE.

His breath stopped.

For the first time that night, he forgot the men on the stair.

He forgot the crown, the regalia, the ruin, the thing waiting beyond the cleft.

Korvath made a sound behind him. "Brannoc."

The letters began to bleed.

The hand of darkness reached through the opening.

And somewhere beyond the ash, something wearing a crown turned its head.

Chapter 2

Rain worried the shutters like a beggar with a knife.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed sat alone beneath the unlit brazier, listening to the weather spend itself against the stone. The chamber smelled of wet wool, lamp oil, and the iron tang that clung to every place where men had argued too long. A single candle guttered on the table before him. Its flame leaned whenever the wind found a crack in the walls, as if even fire wished to escape.

He had removed his gloves.

That was the first mistake.

His hands rested flat upon the table, broad and scarred, their knuckles darkened by old blood beneath the skin. The epithet had followed him across ruined roads and salt-black fields, but names were only chains made of sound. Men called him the Red-Handed because they needed a shape for the violence they feared. They called him a Sellsword Captain because a title was easier to stomach than a man who could be hired to decide the fate of a province.

They did not call him heir.

Not aloud.

Across from him, the door remained shut. Behind it waited the soft scrape of boots, the mutter of guards, the careful silence of men paid to hear nothing. He knew that silence. It belonged to courts, camps, and graves.

On the table lay a strip of black cloth, folded around a shard of bone.

Brannoc had not touched it since it arrived.

He had received messages sealed with blood, wax, ash, and once with a child's milk tooth. He had learned to distrust every seal. The more elaborate the warning, the cheaper the lie beneath it. But this cloth bore no crest, and the bone had been cut cleanly enough to suggest a hand without tremor.

That troubled him.

A knock sounded.

Two taps. A pause. One tap.

Brannoc reached for the knife at his belt. The familiar weight settled his thoughts, though the hilt was slick from the damp in the room. He did not draw it.

"Enter."

The door opened only as far as necessary. A figure slipped through and closed it with care.

Korvath Nightbrook wore the plain, forgettable clothes of a man who wished to become part of a wall. Rain shone along his sleeves. His hood remained raised, though there was no one in the chamber to deceive but Brannoc, and Brannoc had never mistaken concealment for invisibility.

Korvath glanced at the candle.

"Extinguish it," he said.

Brannoc did not move. "You came through a guarded corridor to give orders about a candle?"

“Not orders.”

“No?”

“Advice.”

“Then it is worth less.”

Korvath’s mouth tightened. He carried himself like a smuggler: shoulders turned inward, gaze forever measuring the space between exits. Nothing about him invited trust. That, at least, made him useful.

Brannoc leaned back. “You’re late.”

“I was watched.”

“By whom?”

Korvath looked toward the shutters. “Everyone who matters.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one that survives the night.”

The rain thickened. For a moment the chamber became a sealed vessel, the two men listening to the roof endure.

Brannoc tapped the bone with one finger. “You sent this.”

“I carried it.”

“From whom?”

Korvath’s eyes moved to the knife, then to Brannoc’s hands. He had heard the stories. Most men had. They expected some visible deformity from an epithet such as the Red-Handed—a claw, perhaps, or a stain that no washing could lift. Brannoc offered them nothing. His hands were only hands. That disappointed them more than blood would have.

“From a man who will not be alive by dawn,” Korvath said.

“Then he should have spoken before now.”

“He did.”

“And?”

“And he spoke to the wrong people.”

Brannoc picked up the cloth. It was cold and wet, though Korvath had not seemed to touch the rain for long. The bone inside was narrow, pale, and ridged.

“Whose?”

“Not a finger.”

“That was not my question.”

Korvath’s gaze dropped.

Brannoc unfolded the cloth. A sliver of dark metal lay against the bone, thin as a fish spine. Marks had been scratched into it. Not letters. A pattern of three angled cuts bound by a fourth.

His breath slowed.

The mark was familiar, but familiarity could be bait. He had seen the sign pressed into wax on orders that sent men into ravines, painted beneath bridges, carved into the underside of a captain's chair. It belonged to a language that had outlived those who claimed to speak it.

Korvath said, "The account is true."

"What account?"

"The one that says the Accord of Mournthrone was never decided in the field."

Brannoc's thumb stopped upon the metal.

Outside, something struck the shutters. A branch, perhaps. Or a thrown stone. Neither man looked toward the sound.

"Careful," Brannoc said.

"I have been careful since birth."

"And yet you are here."

"Yes."

"Which proves the gods are either blind or amused."

Korvath gave no sign that he heard the bitterness. "The Accord of Mournthrone has been fed to armies as a victory, to nobles as a negotiation, and to the desperate as proof that men can still bind themselves to words. It was none of those things."

"Every accord is a bargain."

"This one had a price concealed inside it."

Brannoc rose.

The chamber seemed to contract around him. He did not need to threaten Korvath. Threats were for men uncertain of their strength. He crossed to the shutters and placed one hand against the wood. The rain trembled through it. Beyond lay the dark bulk of the stronghold, its roofs and towers erased by weather. Somewhere below, soldiers were sleeping in their armor. Somewhere beyond them, envoys waited beneath banners they believed still possessed meaning.

"Say it," Brannoc said.

Korvath remained by the table. "The losing commander was bribed to withdraw."

The words did not echo. They sank.

Brannoc stared into the black seam between the shutters. The losing commander was bribed to withdraw.

Not defeated.

Not outmaneuvered.

Bought.

He had watched men die for that retreat. He remembered the sound of it: iron dragged over stone, horses screaming in the rain, a line breaking where no line should have broken. He remembered orders passed

from mouth to mouth until they became nonsense. He remembered commanders standing beneath covered lanterns, their faces hollow with disbelief.

He had believed in the wrong thing.

That was the wound. Not the dead. The dead were clean of it.

“What was the price?” he asked.

Korvath’s answer came softly. “A promise of safety. Gold. Passage. Perhaps a title.”

“Perhaps?”

“The ledger does not say.”

“Then it is not a ledger. It is a rumor dressed for court.”

“It names the payment.”

“Names what?”

Korvath reached inside his coat and produced a folded square of oilskin. He placed it on the table, beside the strip of cloth.

Brannoc did not return. “You said the man who carried it would not live by dawn.”

“He was not the man who wrote it.”

“Who was he?”

“A clerk.”

“Whose clerk?”

“The sort who belongs to whoever is holding his throat.”

Brannoc turned. “You are wasting my patience.”

Korvath’s expression hardened. “Your patience is a blade you keep pointing at the wrong throat.”

The candle flame bent low.

For an instant Brannoc saw the table as a battlefield map. The oilskin became a standard. The bone became a marker. The thin shard of metal became a road leading somewhere no army could safely march. He had spent years learning how men moved when they believed themselves free. He knew the twitch before a charge, the pause before betrayal, the moment a hired sword realized the purse had been emptied.

The accord had felt wrong from the beginning.

Too many solemn faces. Too much reverence for ink. Men who had butchered villages speaking of restraint as though restraint were a garment they could put on for witnesses and remove after dark.

He thought of the Bleeding Crown.

The words rose unbidden, dangerous as smoke beneath a door. His claim to it had never been acknowledged. That was the shape of his life: a truth kept beneath the tongue until it tasted like metal. He had been born in 255 AS, into a world that had no use for the child he was and too much use for the weapon he became.

No crown had ever been placed upon his head.

Still, crowns cast shadows.

“What do they want from you?” Brannoc asked.

Korvath blinked. “Who?”

“The people who gave you this.”

“They want it carried.”

“By you?”

“By someone not yet dead.”

“That is not the same as being trusted.”

“No one trusts me.”

“Then why give you the message?”

“Because I can cross a border without belonging to it.”

Brannoc returned to the table. He unfolded the oilskin.

Inside was a page of cramped writing, the ink blurred in places by damp. He read the first line, then the second. The handwriting was disciplined, almost elegant. It listed provisions, withdrawals, sealed instructions, and a transfer of coin described without sentiment. The sum was written clearly.

He did not say it aloud.

Numbers were hooks. Speak them and they lodged in memory.

At the bottom, beneath a smear of black, appeared the mark cut into the metal.

Three angled strokes bound by a fourth.

Brannoc read the page again.

“Where did you get this?”

Korvath lowered his hood. His hair was plastered to his brow. “From a room beneath the eastern quarter.”

“That place is watched.”

“It was.”

“By whom?”

“Men who are now dead.”

“Yours?”

“Some.”

Brannoc folded the page. “You killed them.”

“I moved past them.”

“Do not mistake my contempt for ignorance.”

Korvath's eyes sharpened. "You think this changes the accord?"

"It changes what men believe it was."

"Belief is all that keeps most fortresses standing."

"Stone keeps them standing."

"Until men decide to open the gates."

The words settled between them.

Beyond the door, boots passed. Slow. Then slower. The guards were listening, or pretending not to. Brannoc imagined the corridor: damp flagstones, hooded lamps, hands near sword hilts. He imagined the message leaving this chamber in another man's pocket, then another's, until the truth became a weapon with no owner.

Korvath said, "There is more."

"There is always more when a smuggler begins with a warning."

"The withdrawal was not the end of the payment."

Brannoc looked up.

Korvath placed both hands upon the table, mirroring Brannoc's earlier posture. "The losing commander was bribed to withdraw. That was the first bargain. The second was made afterward."

"With whom?"

"I do not know."

"Who does?"

Korvath swallowed. "The man who keeps the names."

"And where is he?"

A shape moved beneath the door.

Not a shadow. A pause.

Brannoc's hand closed around the knife.

Korvath saw it and stepped back, but too late to hide his fear. The candle shuddered. The rain pressed its many fingers against the shutters. Somewhere in the dark beyond the chamber, metal whispered free of a sheath.

Brannoc lifted the strip of cloth and slipped the bone into his palm.

"Stand behind me," he said.

Korvath gave a humorless smile. "I have survived this long without standing behind anyone."

"Then tonight will be an education."

The latch began to turn.

The latch rose.

Brannoc moved before the door opened. He caught Korvath by the collar and drove him behind the bedstead, where the darkness was thickest and the damp straw gave no room for protest. The smuggler's breath struck his knuckles, hot and sour with fear.

"Quiet," Brannoc said.

"I was not—"

"Quiet."

The door eased inward.

Rain breathed through the gap. A figure stood beyond it, wrapped in a cloak that had drunk the weather black. No face showed beneath the hood. One hand remained outside, hidden by the fold of the garment. The other held a narrow blade with no shine upon it.

Brannoc kept the knife low beside his thigh. The bone lay concealed in his palm, its edges biting into the old scars there. He had expected an assassin. He had not expected the room to feel as if the assassin had been expected by the room itself.

The stranger stepped inside.

Water fell from the cloak in patient drops. The candle flame bent away.

"Brannoc Ironmere," the figure said.

The voice was neither young nor old. It had been scraped clean of every quality that might later be remembered.

Brannoc's thumb passed over the knife's hilt. "You know my name."

"I know several names."

"Then you are the man who keeps them."

Behind him, Korvath stopped breathing.

The stranger shut the door. The latch settled with a soft click, as final as a stone placed over a grave.

"Who sent you?" Brannoc asked.

"Does the question matter?"

"It matters to the man deciding whether to kill you."

"Then I was sent by the man who understands that decision."

A small answer, shaped to waste time. Brannoc had heard its like in war tents, at gates before dawn, in the mouths of captains who had mistaken delay for command. He shifted his weight. The floorboards creaked beneath his boot.

The stranger's blade angled toward the sound.

Fast, then. Not merely careful.

Brannoc glanced at the hood. No ornament. No seal. A strip of gray cloth had been wound twice around the stranger's wrist, its end stiff with wax. The Silent Choir favored silence as other powers favored iron or blood, but silence alone proved nothing. The Iron-Ring Cartel bought disguises by the cartload. House

Morvain had servants who could enter a room as if they had been born there. The Ashen Vanguard called secrecy a vice until secrecy became useful. And the Bleeding Crown—if the crown still possessed anything worth concealing—had made a religion of hidden knives.

“Take off the hood,” Brannoc said.

The stranger did not move.

“Or I take it off for you.”

“Your hand is already occupied.”

Brannoc felt the bone against his palm.

Korvath made a noise behind the bedstead. Not a word. Not quite a sob.

The stranger’s head turned toward it.

Brannoc crossed the room in one step.

His knife struck the stranger’s wrist. Not deep. Deep enough. The narrow blade clattered across the floor as the cloaked figure recoiled, and Brannoc seized the front of the garment with his free hand. He drove the stranger backward into the door. Wood shuddered. The candle gave a weak flare.

The hood fell.

The face beneath it was pale and ordinary. That was its first horror. Brannoc had killed men with faces made for songs, men whose scars proclaimed whole campaigns, men whose eyes burned with the private madness of those who believed the gods had chosen them. This face offered nothing. It could have belonged to a clerk, a pilgrim, a grave-robber, a servant carrying ash from one hearth to another.

Blood threaded from the cut at the wrist.

“Who sent you?” Brannoc said again.

The stranger smiled with only one side of the mouth.

“Not sent.”

Brannoc tightened his grip.

“Then what are you?”

“Late.”

Something struck the shutters from outside.

Korvath surged up. “They’ve found us.”

Brannoc shoved the stranger aside and seized the fallen blade. Its metal was cold enough to numb his fingers. He crossed to the window and lifted the shutter a finger’s width.

The street below was a wash of rain and black stone. No lanterns. No figures. Beyond the crooked roofs, the highland night descended in layers, each darker than the last. He saw movement near the alley mouth: a shape passing between walls, then another. They did not hurry. Hurrying belonged to fear.

Korvath stood beside the bed, clutching the bone as if it had grown there.

“How many?” Brannoc asked.

“I do not know.”

“Who does?”

“The man who keeps the names.”

Brannoc turned. “You said you did not know where he was.”

“I said I did not know who did.”

The stranger had recovered the knife. Blood ran down the hand, but the fingers held steady.

“Put it down,” Brannoc said.

“You have one already.”

“I have yours.”

“You have what you think is mine.”

The stranger looked at the bone in Korvath’s grip. For the first time, something altered in that empty face. Not fear. Recognition, perhaps. Or hunger.

Brannoc saw it and understood that the piece of bone was not a token, not a message, not merely proof of an old bargain. It was a door that could be carried.

“Give it to me,” he said to Korvath.

The smuggler stared.

“Now.”

“You said—”

“I have changed my mind.”

Korvath’s hand closed around it. “That is a dangerous habit.”

“So is surviving.”

A second impact struck the shutters. This time the iron latch jumped.

The stranger moved toward the room’s only other exit.

Brannoc barred the way.

The stranger’s eyes flicked to him. “If they enter, they will not ask questions.”

“Neither will I.”

“That is why you are useful.”

“I am not useful to anyone.”

The words came harder than he intended. They hung between them, larger than the room. Brannoc had spent years making himself into a weapon without a maker, a blade with no crest upon the hilt. Men called him the Red-Handed because they preferred an epithet to an explanation. They saw the blood and invented the rest.

The stranger studied him as though reading a line written beneath the skin.

“You were born for a throne,” they said.

Korvath’s face changed.

Brannoc felt the old wound open—not in flesh, but somewhere behind the ribs where no surgeon could reach. The Bleeding Crown had never spoken his name. It had not needed to. Crowns had ways of denying their own blood while profiting from it.

“Careful,” Brannoc said.

“You are the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.”

The rain seemed to retreat from the shutters.

Korvath whispered, “Brannoc.”

Brannoc struck the stranger across the mouth.

The blow snapped the head aside. A red line appeared at the lip. The stranger laughed once, softly, without pleasure.

“Say it again,” Brannoc said.

“You will have to kill me.”

“That was not the question.”

The door trembled beneath a fist from the other side.

Korvath backed toward the wall. “We need to leave.”

Brannoc did not look at him. “There is nowhere to go.”

“There is always somewhere.”

“That is a smuggler’s prayer.”

“It has kept me alive.”

“For how long?”

Korvath’s gaze slid to the stranger. “Long enough to know when a room is already buried.”

The fist struck again. A splinter jumped from the door.

The stranger wiped blood from their mouth and touched it to the strip of gray cloth around the wrist. Wax softened beneath the warmth. A seal emerged, not pressed into the cloth but hidden within it: a mark of three lines bound together, each line broken before it reached the next.

Brannoc had seen the sign before, scratched into crates that carried grain through Crookvale, carved beneath a table in Fenspire, burned into the dead eyes of a courier found in a ditch. It belonged to no single power. That was what made it feared.

“The names are not kept in a book,” the stranger said.

Brannoc raised the blade.

“Where, then?”

“In the Edge of Gloamreach.”

The title entered the chamber like a breath from a crypt. Korvath flinched.

Brannoc had heard of the grimoire in the mouths of men who wished to sound wiser than death. A book for twilight bargains. A book that demanded an attunement cost of 46. A book whose pages were said to remember what the living had paid to forget.

“You expect me to believe that?”

“No.”

“Then why tell me?”

“Because belief is not required.”

The door cracked.

A blade came through the split, searching blindly.

Korvath cried out and threw himself aside. Brannoc caught the stranger by the throat and hauled them toward the window. The blade in his hand remained poised beneath the jaw.

“Open it,” he said.

“To the rain?”

“To the drop.”

The stranger looked down. The ground waited below in darkness.

“Your grip is not strong enough.”

Brannoc pressed harder.

The stranger’s smile returned. “Not yet.”

The door burst inward.

Rain blew across the room. A shape entered low, armored in dark leather, followed by another behind it. Brannoc saw only fragments: a wet sleeve, a hooked weapon, the pale glimmer of teeth. Korvath shouted something lost beneath the thunder.

Brannoc shoved the stranger through the window.

For an instant the hooded figure hung outside, one hand gripping the sill. The other caught Brannoc’s wrist.

The touch was cold.

“Come to the place where the Thrice-Bound Edge was forged,” the stranger said.

Brannoc looked into that empty face.

“Where?”

But the fingers released him.

The stranger fell.

Brannoc turned as the first intruder crossed the room. He cut upward, felt the blade bite cloth and flesh, and stepped inside the attacker’s reach. The second came at him from the side. Korvath seized a stool and

smashed it against the figure's knees. Wood broke. The attacker buckled.

Brannoc drove his elbow into the first assailant's throat.

Someone screamed.

The candle went out.

In the dark, hands found him. One closed around his coat. Another scraped across his back. Brannoc fought by pressure and breath, by the wet sound of bodies colliding, by the old arithmetic of violence. He felt the bone slip from Korvath's grasp. It struck the floor and rolled beneath the bedstead.

"Brannoc!" Korvath shouted.

A new voice answered from the doorway.

"Give us the heir."

Brannoc stood amid the dark with blood warm on his knuckles and the stolen blade rising in his hand.

"No," he said.

Then the voice outside spoke his secret name.

The word entered him more cleanly than the blade.

For one breath Brannoc forgot the room, the men crouched within it, the open door breathing cold upon his face. The secret name belonged to a place of ash and locked doors, to a voice that had never risen above a whisper. It had been spoken over him before he could understand speech. Spoken again when he learned that some bloodlines were knives best kept sheathed.

No living tongue had used it since.

Korvath made a sound behind him—not fear. Recognition.

Brannoc turned his head by a fraction. "You knew?"

"I knew a name," Korvath said. His voice had gone thin. "Not who carried it."

The man in the doorway stepped through the dark. A shutter shifted somewhere beyond him, admitting a blade of moonless grey. It touched the edge of his face, then failed to reveal anything useful: a hood, a scarf, hands hidden in dark gloves. There were others behind him. Brannoc heard their breathing, disciplined and patient.

The men on the floor began to move.

He stamped on one wrist. Bone cracked beneath his heel.

The man did not cry out. That frightened Brannoc more than any scream.

"Leave Korvath," said the hooded stranger. "He is not the purpose of this."

Korvath laughed once, without humor. "A comforting distinction."

Brannoc kept the stolen blade angled toward the doorway. Its edge trembled—not from fear, but because his hand had taken too many blows in too little time. Blood ran from his knuckles and darkened the hilt.

"Who sent you?"

“The question is already answered.”

“House Morvain?”

The hood gave no sign.

“The Ashen Vanguard?”

Nothing.

“The Silent Choir?”

At that, one of the hidden men shifted. Cloth brushed leather. A small sound, but the dark was full of small betrayals.

Brannoc saw the movement and filed it away.

“Or the Iron-Ring Cartel,” he said. “They buy quieter men than you.”

“Names are a luxury for those with time.”

“Then you’ve come poorly supplied.”

The stranger tilted his head. “You have the temper of the Bleeding Crown.”

The words did not strike as the secret name had struck. They sank deeper.

Korvath swore under his breath.

Brannoc felt the old pressure in his chest, the one he had spent his life mistaking for anger. It was the body’s memory of a door barred from the inside. A cradle emptied before anyone could ask whose child had slept there. A hand withdrawing from his hair. A woman’s voice saying, Never let them see what you are.

The Bleeding Crown had been a story told by enemies and courtiers, by drunk soldiers and dying men. It was a power, a wound, a thing that wore gold only when gold could not be refused. Brannoc had carried its shadow without ever touching its throne.

“I have the temper of a starving dog,” he said. “You should not confuse the two.”

The stranger looked past him toward Korvath. “The heir must come with us.”

“Which heir?” Korvath asked.

The hooded face turned slightly.

Korvath’s courage had always possessed the brittle quality of glass. It shone until pressure found it. Now the smuggler stood among overturned furniture and broken bodies, his hands raised, his mouth wet with blood, and tried to make a shield of mockery.

“You’ve entered a rented room,” he said. “You’ve broken half the furniture. You’ve failed to kill the captain you came for. If you mean to conduct a kidnapping, perhaps begin by identifying the merchandise.”

The stranger lifted one gloved hand.

The men on the floor rose.

The first came at Brannoc low. He caught the man by the collar and drove him into the bedstead. The frame groaned. The second struck from the side. Brannoc turned, took the blow along his ribs, and answered with the hilt of the stolen blade.

The man's teeth clicked together.

A third entered through the doorway.

Too many.

Brannoc felt the room narrowing around him. He had fought in alleys, stairwells, courtyards slick with rain and courtyards slick with worse. A room could be conquered if it had corners. This one had only bodies, shadows, and Korvath breathing behind him like a man trying not to drown.

"Get the bone," Korvath said.

Brannoc did not look at him.

"It's under the bed."

"I heard you."

"It may be useful."

"Then fetch it."

"I am occupied."

The third attacker swung. Brannoc ducked, seized the wrist, and twisted until the shoulder came loose with a soft, hideous pop. He shoved the man backward into another. They fell together, snarling.

Korvath lunged for the bed.

The hooded stranger crossed the room with impossible calm.

Brannoc saw him only at the edge of sight: a dark shape passing through violence as if violence had agreed to make way. He moved toward Korvath, not quickly, but without hesitation. That was the mark of a trained killer—not speed, but the certainty that speed would not be required.

Brannoc went after him.

The stolen blade caught the stranger beneath the ribs.

Or should have.

Something turned the point aside. The impact jarred Brannoc's wrist. Beneath the stranger's coat, metal rang with a note too pure for ordinary armor.

Regalia.

The Thrice-Bound Edge, forged in 123 AS, had been described to Brannoc by men who lied for coin and by one woman who had not. They had called it regalia, though no one agreed whether it was worn, carried, or endured. He had never seen it. Yet the sound beneath his blade was the sound of an old promise refusing to break.

The stranger seized Brannoc's forearm.

Pain flashed white.

Brannoc head-butted him.

The hood snapped back. For an instant Brannoc saw a mouth, bloodless and narrow, and eyes that seemed to hold no reflection of the room.

Then Korvath shouted.

Brannoc wrenched free and turned.

Korvath had the bone in one hand. He held it as though it were a key. The men nearest him had stopped. Even the hooded stranger had gone still.

The bone was not large. It was not beautiful. Age had yellowed it, and one end bore a dark stain that no washing had lifted. Yet the air around it seemed to draw inward. The candlewick, though extinguished, smoked toward Korvath's fist.

"What is that?" Brannoc demanded.

Korvath's eyes remained fixed on the bone. "You told me it was yours."

"I told you to hide it."

"You did not tell me what it opened."

"Put it down."

The hooded stranger extended his hand. "Give it to me."

Korvath's fingers closed.

A sound came from the walls.

Not a voice. Not a groan of settling timber. It was the faintest susurrus, a pressure against the ear, as though unseen mouths had begun to sing beneath the stone.

The Silent Choir.

Brannoc had heard tales. Every captain heard tales. The Choir moved through cities without banners, without drums, without even the courtesy of leaving corpses where they could be counted. Their prayers were said in rooms where names had been scraped from the walls. Their silence was not the absence of speech. It was speech stripped of mercy.

The room seemed to listen.

Korvath looked at Brannoc. "You should have told me."

"I should have killed you when I met you."

"Perhaps. But you did not."

The words landed between them with the weight of a confession neither man intended.

The hooded stranger moved.

Brannoc threw himself sideways. A thin blade whispered through the space where his throat had been. He seized a chair and broke it across the attacker's arm. The stranger staggered. Korvath slipped behind the bed, clutching the bone.

"Window," Brannoc said.

Korvath glanced toward it. "We are above the ground."

"Then pray."

"I have never found it reliable."

A blade struck the shutters. Wood split. Cold air entered, carrying the smell of wet stone and distant ash.

Brannoc drove one attacker into the wall and took his knife. The knife was narrow and badly balanced, meant for the ribs rather than the fight. He used it anyway. A cut opened along the man's sleeve. Blood shone black in the dimness.

"Who is the heir?" Brannoc demanded.

The stranger did not answer.

Brannoc caught the next blow on his forearm. The impact numbed his hand. He drove his knee upward, felt something tear, and shoved the man aside.

"Who is the heir?"

The stranger raised his face.

"The one who survives this room."

Beyond the doorway, more feet gathered.

Brannoc heard armor. He heard the scrape of iron rings. He heard someone outside give a low command, and the men within shifted to obey.

The Iron-Ring Cartel, then—or men who wished to be mistaken for them. It hardly mattered. In the Ashen Era, allegiance was often only the name a blade gave its owner before it entered you.

Korvath reached the broken shutters.

He looked down.

Brannoc saw calculation move through him: distance, darkness, the likelihood of bones breaking, the greater likelihood of being taken alive. The smuggler's face tightened.

"Go," Brannoc said.

Korvath's gaze cut back. "And you?"

"I am the merchandise."

"That is not what they said."

"No. It is what they believe."

The hooded stranger stepped over the fallen men. "Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed."

Hearing the full name spoken there, in that cramped room with blood beneath his boots, was worse than hearing the secret one. The epithet had always belonged to other mouths. Soldiers had given it to him. Enemies had polished it. Now it sounded like a summons.

The stranger spoke again, and this time the name beneath the name passed through the room.

Brannoc felt the old door open.

He remembered a hand pressing two fingers to his brow. Remembered the smell of smoke. Remembered being told that if anyone ever called him by that name, he must run—not toward safety, but away from everyone who offered it.

The men surged.

Korvath leapt through the shutters.

Brannoc seized the nearest attacker by the throat and dragged him into the path of the others. Steel struck steel. Someone cursed. The secret name still rang inside him, opening chambers he had buried beneath years of hired blood and cold campfires.

He could not run.

Not yet.

The hooded stranger came through the confusion, reaching not for the blade, not for Brannoc's throat, but for the place beneath his collar where the old scar lay hidden.

Brannoc caught his wrist.

For the first time, the stranger's composure broke.

"You know what I am," Brannoc said.

"I know what you will become."

The room fell silent around those words.

Far below, Korvath struck the ground. Wood shattered. Then came the sound of him running.

Brannoc tightened his grip until the stranger's glove creaked.

"And what is that?"

The stranger leaned close. His breath smelled of bitter herbs and old iron.

"The last crown before the ashes take it."

A shape moved beyond the broken doorway. Not a man. Not quite. A book opened somewhere in the dark, its pages turning though no wind entered.

On the floor, beneath the bedstead, something answered with a dull metallic pulse.

Brannoc looked down.

The bone was no longer in Korvath's hand.

It lay beside his boot, warm as living flesh.

Chapter 3

I died in 300 AS with iron in my mouth and the Accord of Mournthroner still gnawing at the realm.

The dead did not sleep.

They waited beneath the weather.

At Vharencrag Fortress, the snow fell upward.

It lifted from the broken courtyards in pale threads, dragging ash and splinters with it, and vanished into the low black clouds. Brannoc watched from the gatehouse where no living sentry stood. He had been standing there since the bells stopped. Or since his heart stopped. The difference had become difficult to keep.

Below, the fortress endured its own ruin. Towers leaned toward one another like conspirators. The walls were split by old sorcery, their stones fused into glass along the seams. In the yard, men of the Ashen Vanguard carried lengths of chain through the snow. Their victory had been named, though victory seemed a poor word for a place where the dead still shouted from under the flagstones.

The Accord of Mournthroner began in 297 AS and ended in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.

Brannoc had heard the sentence spoken by a clerk with clean hands.

He had heard it in a chamber where the walls were warm and the wine was red, while the clerk's quill scratched across a page. The words had possessed the smug finality of a sealed tomb. Yet the fighting had waged at Vharencrag Fortress in 301 AS, and the fortress had not learned that it was finished.

Neither had he.

"Captain."

The voice came from below.

Brannoc looked down through the arrow slit. A man stood in the courtyard with a hood drawn low over his face. He carried no sword that showed itself, no badge, no banner. His boots were too clean for a soldier and too worn for a courtier.

Korvath Nightbrook, a Smuggler.

Even in death, Brannoc recognized the careful shape of a man who expected every door to be barred and every guard to be bought.

"You are late," Brannoc said.

His voice descended without sound. Korvath lifted his head all the same.

"Dead men are difficult to find."

"I was not difficult. I was here."

"You were a rumor." Korvath glanced toward the western wall. "Rumors do not open gates."

"They do when the gate has no hinges."

Korvath's mouth tightened. He had brought a narrow case beneath his cloak. Brannoc smelled wax, old leather, and the faint mineral stink of magic. The case had been sealed three times. The seals bore no crest that Brannoc knew.

He knew the weight of certain secrets. They settled in the hand like knives.

"Bring it up," Brannoc said.

Korvath did not move.

The dead had no authority over the living. That was one of the first lessons Brannoc had learned after the iron entered him. The living continued to obey banners, coin, hunger, lust, and fear. The dead possessed only memory, and memory could not close a fist.

Below, a torch guttered. The men of the Ashen Vanguard passed through the yard without seeing him. Their armor was gray with salt and snow. Their banner hung limp from the ruined keep, its cloth blackened by the Sundering's old weather.

"Who sent you?" Brannoc asked.

Korvath looked at the fortress.

"Everyone who wants the war to end."

"Then you have been sent by no one."

"Not no one."

"House Morvain?"

Korvath's silence was answer enough to make the dead colder.

Brannoc turned from the slit. The chamber behind him had no roof. Snow drifted across the floor and through the place where his body had once fallen. He remembered the body clearly: the leather torn at the shoulder, the blood soaking the stones, the hand that had made him famous lying open beside him.

The Red-Handed.

They had called him that before they knew whose blood had marked him. They had called him that after. The name had served better than any sigil. A Sellsword Captain required little more than a blade, a company, and men willing to believe he would be the last one standing.

He had been born in 255 AS.

He had been the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

Neither fact had purchased him a father's name.

Korvath climbed the stair. His steps made no echo. At the top, he stopped before Brannoc, and for a moment the living man's face seemed to lose its edges.

"Your blood has been hidden," Korvath said.

"Not well."

"Better than you think."

"The Crown has never wanted me."

“The Crown does not want. People want. The Crown merely gives them a shape to kill for.”

Brannoc looked at the case.

“Open it.”

Korvath drew a small blade and cut the wax. Within lay a dark volume wrapped in oilskin. Its cover was ridged, its corners worn smooth by handling. No title had been written across it, yet Brannoc knew the name before the wrappings came away.

Edge of Gloamreach.

The grimoire breathed once.

Brannoc felt the pull of it through the empty place where his ribs had been. Attunement cost: 46. The number had been written in a margin by a hand too frightened to finish its sentence. He had never touched the book while alive. Now its pages stirred toward him as though they remembered a hand that had not yet claimed them.

“Why bring this to me?” he asked.

Korvath’s gaze remained on the grimoire. “Because the living have begun to fear what the dead know.”

“I know that men lie.”

“You know who paid.”

The wind moved through the chamber. Snow gathered in the shape of a shoulder beside Brannoc, then collapsed.

He remembered the commander.

Not the face. Faces were treacherous things in memory. He remembered the commander’s glove resting on a map. He remembered a purse placed beside the inkpot. He remembered the soft sound of coin shifting against coin while men died beyond the walls.

The losing commander had been bribed to withdraw.

That hidden truth had survived beneath the official account, buried under speeches and ash. The Accord’s collapse unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals, and every reprisal carried the taste of that payment.

Korvath reached for the grimoire.

Brannoc caught his wrist.

The living man cried out.

His fingers closed on nothing, yet Korvath’s arm jerked as if seized by iron. Brannoc felt warmth rush through the contact, the fierce, bright animal of a pulse. It angered him. It reminded him of all the things death had taken without asking.

“Do not touch it,” Brannoc said.

Korvath stared at his own wrist. A red mark had appeared there, five narrow lines pressed into the skin.

“The Red-Handed,” he whispered.

“Names are ropes. Be careful what you hang from them.”

Below, the gates groaned.

Brannoc released him.

Voices rose in the courtyard. The Ashen Vanguard had found the lower passage. Their soldiers shouted to one another, and the sound climbed the fortress in waves. Somewhere beneath the stone, something answered with a slow scraping.

Korvath wrapped the grimoire again.

“You cannot carry that through the garrison.”

“There is no garrison here.”

“Not now.”

Brannoc looked toward the east, beyond the shattered walls and the white emptiness. The Gloaming Reach lay there, dim beneath a sky without dawn. Fenspire stood within it, founded in 57 AS, a core location held under permanent military occupation. Its garrison strength was 3742.

He had once received the figure from a quartermaster who would rather have swallowed a nail than speak it aloud. Three thousand seven hundred and forty-two soldiers beneath one stark spire, watching the dark as if discipline could hold back the night.

“Take the book to Fenspire,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s guarded expression hardened. “That is not a smuggler’s road.”

“It is not a road at all.”

“Then why send me?”

“Because you are a Smuggler.”

“I have a name.”

“Korvath Nightbrook.”

The name seemed to trouble the air. Brannoc had no right to know it, and yet the dead kept what the living discarded.

Korvath tucked the case beneath his cloak. “What will I find there?”

“Men who believe the war ended.”

“The war ended.”

“No.”

“The Accord ended.”

“Words end. Hunger does not.”

A figure moved beyond the arrow slit.

Brannoc turned.

For one breath, the chamber filled with regalia: a blade suspended in black cloth, three bindings circling its hilt, each one tighter than the last. The Thrice-Bound Edge, forged in 123 AS. Its defining record

contained no attunement cost. It did not glow. It did not sing. It merely waited with the patient silence of a vow.

Then the vision was gone.

Korvath had seen it. His face had become bloodless.

“What was that?”

“Something that does not belong to you.”

“Does it belong to you?”

Brannoc looked at his hands.

The epithet had outlived the flesh that gave it meaning. He could still see the blood there, though no blood remained. He had no canonical features to offer the world, no face for statues or painted histories. Only the red hands. Only the station. Only the claim that had never been spoken before the Bleeding Crown.

“It belongs to whoever survives the binding,” he said.

The lower door burst inward.

Ashen Vanguard soldiers flooded the stairwell. Their steel flashed. Korvath stumbled backward, clutching the case. Brannoc stepped between them, though he knew the living could not see him.

The first soldier raised a crossbow.

Brannoc remembered the moment before death: the shape of the bolt, the silence inside his chest, the knowledge that no banner would bend for him. He remembered dying during the Accord of Mournthrone in 300 AS. He remembered the world continuing without permission.

Now the crossbowman fired.

The bolt passed through Brannoc and struck Korvath in the shoulder.

Korvath fell against the wall. The case dropped. Its seals broke.

The Edge of Gloamreach opened by itself.

Every flame in Vharencrag Fortress went out.

From the courtyard came a roar—not of men, but of stone tearing loose from stone. The fortress lurched beneath them. Somewhere far below, a bell began to ring, though no hand remained to pull its rope.

Brannoc seized the grimoire as the pages turned.

On the first page, ink crawled into a single line.

The Accord of Mournthrone was waged at Vharencrag Fortress in 301 AS.

The letters darkened.

Behind him, the soldiers screamed. Korvath dragged himself toward the fallen case. Beyond the broken wall, the snow was rising higher, carrying voices from every road that led toward Fenspire, Crookvale, the High Spires, the Bleeding Crown, the Iron-Ring Cartel, the Silent Choir, House Morvain—

And beneath them all, beneath the Ashen Vanguard’s shouted commands, another voice spoke from the opened book.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

He bent over the page.

The dead fortress drew breath.

“Choose,” it said, and the stones beneath his feet began to—
move.

Not the stones beneath his boots. The fortress.

Its walls leaned inward with the slow, dreadful patience of a man listening at a door. Mortar sifted from the joints. Snow spilled through the broken roof and vanished before touching the floor, each flake taken by the dark beneath the flagstones.

Brannoc kept one hand on the open book.

The leather was cold enough to burn. Its cover bore no title, but the page before him named it in a thin, crowded hand.

Edge of Gloamreach.

Below that, in a smaller script:

Attunement cost: 46.

The number trembled.

“Choose what?” Brannoc asked.

The voice came from the grimoire, though its lips were ink and its breath was the smell of wet ash.

“Blood.”

His fingers tightened against the page. Behind him, Korvath made a wet sound and tried to rise. The smuggler’s boots scraped uselessly over the stone. He had lost his blade somewhere in the snow. One hand clutched his side; the other reached toward Brannoc with the blind insistence of a drowning man.

“Don’t touch it,” Korvath said.

Brannoc looked back. The broken wall had sealed itself with darkness. No snow came through now. No soldiers screamed. The fortress had swallowed every sound except Korvath’s breathing and the slow grinding of its foundations.

“You know the book?”

“I know enough.”

“You serve at Fenthrope,” Brannoc said. “You know enough to tell me what it wants.”

Korvath’s eyes widened. Fear made them bright, almost childlike. “Korvath Nightbrook serves at Fenthrope,” he whispered, as if the words were a password that might open the world again. “That’s all. That is all I am.”

The stone shifted beneath him. His palm slid across the floor, leaving a dark smear.

Brannoc turned back to the page.

A second line had appeared.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed. Born in 255 AS.

The ink gathered at the final mark and ran downward like blood from a nail.

He had heard men speak his epithet in taverns, at campfires, in the muttering silence before a charge. They had made the Red-Handed into a warning, a blessing, a jest for those who had never seen what a captain became when the work was done and the dead still looked up at him.

The book knew his name without being told.

That was worse than any blade.

A third line formed.

Unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

The words did not lie. That was their cruelty.

Brannoc felt the old wound open beneath his ribs, though no sword had entered him. The claim had lived in him like a second spine, hard and secret. Men had died for less than a rumor of it. Others had offered him banners, promises, sealed letters whose wax bore no mark he could trust. He had burned them all. A crown was only a collar with better language.

Korvath crawled another handspan.

“The Crown?” he said. “You knew?”

“Knew what?”

“That it would call you.”

“I have been called by better things.”

The fortress groaned. A seam split the floor between them. Pale light shone below—not firelight, not moonlight, but the color of old metal held beneath water.

The book’s pages began to turn without wind.

One page showed a sword bound three times in black cord.

The Thrice-Bound Edge. Regalia forged in 123 AS.

The image was so precise Brannoc could see the grain of the grip, the small nicks along the guard, the dark binding drawn tight as sinew. It conveyed no promise of power. No hunger. Only restraint.

The next page was a map, though the roads crawled as he watched.

The High Spires rose in serrated strokes. Crookvale crouched among them, rebuilt in crooked lines, its hard walls bristling above a garrison of **1004**. Beneath the name, the book wrote:

Founded in 295 AS. Outside the core holdings.

Brannoc pressed his thumb into the margin. The map recoiled from his touch.

A distant horn sounded.

Korvath flinched. “They’re coming.”

“Who?”

The smuggler glanced at the sealed wall. “All of them.”

The words stirred the fortress. The map darkened, and a spire appeared in the Gloaming Reach, stark against a field of gray.

Fenspire. Founded in 57 AS. Garrisoned.

The number beneath it remained black and unchanging.

3742.

Brannoc saw the walls of Fenspire in his mind: disciplined ranks, watchfires burning without warmth, gates that opened only to those already expected. A core holding. A place that had made vigilance into stone.

Then the page tore itself down the middle.

On one half, the Ashen Vanguard marched beneath a sky the color of bruised iron.

On the other, House Morvain’s shadow stretched across a field of dead snow.

The Silent Choir stood where the horizon should have been, faces hidden beneath pale veils. The Iron-Ring Cartel’s mark appeared as a circle of black links. The Bleeding Crown burned without flame.

Five powers. Five hungers. None of them had room for a man who belonged to all their histories and none of their tables.

“Close it,” Korvath said.

Brannoc tried.

The cover would not move.

The voice rose from the binding. “The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS.”

The stones beneath Brannoc’s boots rolled like a living back.

“The Accord ended in 301 AS.”

A crack opened near Korvath’s knee. He caught its edge with both hands.

“The Ashen Vanguard was named victor.”

The words struck the fortress, and the fortress remembered.

For an instant Brannoc saw Vharencrag Fortress whole: towers unbroken, banners stiff in the wind, the black teeth of its battlements rising above ranks of men. He saw no faces. The vision denied him faces. It showed only hands signing, hands counting, hands passing sealed pouches beneath a table while a losing commander stood beyond a curtain and turned away.

The truth had no trumpet. It had the quiet sound of coin settling into a palm.

Then the vision collapsed.

Brannoc was on one knee.

Korvath stared at him. “What did you see?”

“An accord.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“It is what you received.”

The smuggler’s mouth worked. He looked toward the book, and something in him hardened—not courage, precisely, but the shape courage left when stripped of hope.

“My orders were to bring it to Fenthron.”

“Who gave them?”

Korvath said nothing.

The Edge of Gloamreach turned another page.

A line appeared in red.

Died in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone.

Brannoc read it twice.

The second time, the fortress vanished.

He stood beneath a colorless sky. Snow lay over the ground without covering it. His blood marked a path behind him, though he could not feel the wound that had spilled it. Before him waited a throne made of blackened roots—or perhaps ribs. The shape changed whenever he tried to fix his eyes upon it.

At his right hand, the Thrice-Bound Edge rested in the snow.

At his left, the grimoire hovered open.

Between them stood a crown.

The Bleeding Crown was not a thing of metal. It was a circle of red light suspended at the height of a man’s brow, dripping upward into the sky.

Brannoc heard voices beyond the white emptiness.

The Ashen Vanguard called him commander.

House Morvain called him traitor.

The Silent Choir called him by no name at all.

The Iron-Ring Cartel offered terms.

The Bleeding Crown offered blood.

Behind every voice lay the same demand: kneel, and become useful.

He looked down at his hands. They were red to the wrists. Not with fresh blood. With old blood, dried into the creases, worked beneath the nails, carried through every oath he had broken and every oath he had kept for the wrong reason.

The voice of the book whispered beside him.

“Choose.”

“Between what?”

“Being claimed.”

The crown lowered.

Brannoc did not move.

He remembered men calling him bastard when they meant dangerous. He remembered the careful pauses around his name, the way a room measured him before deciding whether to laugh. He remembered the letters without signatures, the gifts without givers, the silences that had followed every question about his birth.

The crown drew nearer. Its red light warmed his face.

“You think I want this?” he asked.

The grimoire’s pages fluttered.

“No.”

“Then why show it to me?”

“Because you died before you chose.”

The snow beneath him cracked.

Brannoc turned toward the voice. There was no mouth, no shape, nothing but the black rectangle of the open book and the thin white pages turning in impossible wind.

“I died,” he said.

“Yes.”

“When?”

The page answered him.

300 AS.

His death stood there without ceremony. No battlefield. No final boast. No hand reaching to close his eyes. Only the year, exact and merciless.

He felt something inside him recoil—not from death, but from the indignity of being reduced to a line.

The fortress returned in pieces.

First the stone beneath his palm.

Then Korvath’s breath.

Then the snow, pouring through the broken wall again.

Korvath had reached the grimoire. His fingers hovered above the page, trembling.

“Don’t,” Brannoc said.

“I have to.”

“You serve at Fenthron.”

“I serve where I’m paid.”

“Those are not the same thing.”

“They are when hunger is involved.”

The book’s ink crawled toward Korvath’s hand. The smuggler drew back, but not quickly enough. A black thread leapt from the page and wrapped around his wrist.

Korvath screamed.

The sound tore through the fortress. Outside, something answered from the snow.

Brannoc seized the thread.

Cold entered him.

Not cold like winter. Cold like a locked room in which someone had been waiting for him to arrive.

The page blazed.

The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The sword appeared in his grip.

It was heavier than memory, its three bindings drawn tight around the hilt. No blade showed, yet the air before him split from floor to ceiling. Beyond the cut lay Fenthrope—not its streets or walls, not any clear image, but a narrow passage crowded with doors.

Korvath stared into it, face drained of blood.

“Fenthrope,” he whispered.

The thread around his wrist tightened.

From beyond the first door came the muffled scrape of a bolt being drawn.

From beyond the second came the murmur of many voices speaking as one.

From beyond the third came the sound of a crown striking stone.

Brannoc felt the grimoire pulling him forward. The fortress leaned with it. Cracks raced across the ceiling. Snow streamed upward into the dark.

Korvath’s boots slid toward the opening.

“Captain,” he gasped.

Brannoc caught him by the collar.

The smuggler’s gaze locked on his. “If you go through, they’ll know.”

“Who?”

Korvath looked past him, toward the doors.

“The ones who paid the commander to withdraw.”

The book shuddered in Brannoc’s hand.

Behind the doors, a voice spoke his name.

Not the epithet. Not the title.

Only the name his mother had never allowed him to forget.

Brannoc raised the bound sword.

The first door began to open—

The first door opened inward.

No hand touched it. The hinges gave a long, wet groan, as if something on the other side had been forced to wake.

Beyond lay a corridor without walls. Snow drifted through it, though there was no wind. Pale stones hung in the blackness at differing distances, each one bearing a smear of red light. Brannoc saw no floor beneath them. He saw only the suggestion of one, a road remembered by the feet of the dead.

Korvath made a sound in his throat.

Brannoc tightened his grip on the collar of Korvath Nightbrook's coat. "You said they paid the commander to withdraw."

"I said they paid someone."

"The commander."

"The losing commander." Korvath's eyes remained fixed upon the open door. "There is a difference, if you mean to keep breathing."

The voice behind the door spoke again.

"Brannoc Ironmere."

The name entered him like a blade between the ribs. It did not come from the corridor. It came from the sword.

The bound hilt was cold against his palm. The Thrice-Bound Edge had been regalia forged in 123 AS, made to bind what kingdoms could not. It had no attunement cost. Brannoc had always thought that a lie told by dead craftsmen to flatter the living.

The sword was not free.

It had merely chosen not to charge him yet.

He drew it fully.

The blade emerged from its wrappings with a sound like a woman inhaling before a scream. Three dark bands crossed the steel. Beneath them, something moved, thin as ink beneath ice.

The grimoire bucked in his other hand.

"Put it down," Korvath whispered.

"Tell it to me."

"Put it down."

"What is the cost?"

Korvath's face had gone gray. "The Edge of Gloamreach has an attunement cost of 46."

The number seemed to strike the air. The corridor shivered. One of the floating stones split, and from the crack poured a swarm of moths made from scraps of shadow.

Brannoc felt the grimoire's hunger enter his wrist.

"Forty-six what?"

Korvath swallowed. "You know what."

"I know nothing."

"Lives. Names. Years. It takes what the bearer has spent and calls the debt paid."

The book opened by itself.

Its pages were black, but the letters burned white across them. They formed no script Brannoc knew, yet he understood each word as it appeared.

BRANNOC IRONMERE THE RED-HANDED.

Below it:

BORN IN 255 AS.

The ink spread.

The next line did not form at once. It crawled across the page in trembling strokes, as though the book disliked the shape of what it must write.

UNACKNOWLEDGED HEIR TO THE BLEEDING CROWN.

Korvath looked at him then.

Not at the book. At him.

Brannoc's fingers closed around the sword until the edges of the hilt bit through his glove. Somewhere in the fortress, stone fell in a heavy succession. The sound rolled toward them and stopped at the threshold.

"Say it," Korvath said.

"Say what?"

"You heard it."

Brannoc looked down at the page. "The book is a liar."

"Books don't lie."

"Men write them."

"And who wrote that?"

The white letters bled. The next line appeared.

DIED IN 300 AS DURING THE ACCORD OF MOURNTHRONE.

For a breath, Brannoc could not feel his hands.

Then he laughed.

It was not a pleasant sound. The corridor caught it and sent it outward, where it became the muttering of a crowd.

Korvath flinched. "What did you see?"

"My death."

"Whose?"

Brannoc shut the grimoire. Its cover resisted. He forced it closed with both hands, and the leather gave beneath his palms like flesh.

"Mine."

The door widened.

On the far side, shapes stood in a pale assembly. Figures in mail, in robes, in crowns that had been broken and soldered together again. Their faces were veiled by frost. Behind them, a throne leaned beneath a mountain of snow.

Mournthrone.

He had never seen it, but the name lived in the bones of every soldier who had marched beneath the Ashen Vanguard's colors or against them. The Accord of Mournthrone had begun in 297 AS. It had not yet begun, not here, not in this hour that smelled of old mortar and lamp oil, but the door showed it waiting.

The sword trembled.

A second line of writing appeared across its blade.

THE ACCORD OF MOURNTHRONE ENDED IN 301 AS WITH THE ASHEN VANGUARD NAMED VICTOR.

The words were not cut into the metal. They floated above it, red and bright.

Brannoc stared until the letters blurred.

"Then I am dead before it ends," he said.

Korvath's silence was answer enough.

The corridor beyond the door changed.

A fortress rose from the darkness, rebuilt stone upon ruined stone. Its towers were crooked, its walls black beneath a skin of snow. Banners hung limp along the battlements, though none bore a device Brannoc recognized.

"Crookvale," Korvath whispered.

Brannoc had heard the name from caravans that came down out of the High Spires with frost in their beards and blood on their harness. A settlement founded in 295 AS. Rebuilt after whatever had broken it. A place outside the core holdings, where allegiance was a garment worn inside out.

The grimoire opened again.

The page showed the fortress from above. Then the words:

CROOKVALE WAS FOUNDED IN 295 AS IN THE HIGH SPIRES.

The image drew closer. Men watched from the walls. Their faces were hollow with vigilance. The garrison stood in ordered ranks beneath the gate.

GARRISON: 1004.

Korvath's lips moved soundlessly as he counted nothing.

"Rebuilt," he said.

The book printed the word beneath the number.

REBUILT.

Then:

OUTSIDE THE CORE HOLDINGS.

Brannoc felt a pressure behind his eyes. The vision of Crookvale did not seem distant. He could smell its snow, its chimney smoke, the iron tang of old blood caught in the mortar. A sentry turned his head toward him.

The sentry had no face.

Brannoc closed the book again.

This time it shut without resistance.

Behind them, the fortress doors began to move.

Not the outer doors. The ones deeper within. Something was coming through the halls.

Korvath released a breath. "We have to go."

"Through the door?"

"Every other way is caved in."

"Who paid the commander?"

"I don't know."

"You know enough to fear them."

"I know enough to know that the payment was not coin."

A sound came from the corridor beyond the threshold: a soft dragging, repeated at measured intervals. Metal across stone. A chain, perhaps. Or a blade.

Brannoc stepped forward.

Korvath seized his arm. "No."

The smuggler's grip was stronger than it looked. Brannoc could have broken it. He nearly did.

"Let go."

"If they see you, they'll call you by the blood-name."

"I have no blood-name."

"You have the Bleeding Crown in your veins."

The words struck harder than the book had.

Brannoc turned his wrist. Korvath's fingers loosened.

"No one has ever placed a crown on my head."

"That is why you're still alive."

A low wind moved through the open door. It carried voices, hundreds of them, speaking from very far away.

The Ashen Vanguard.

House Morvain.

The Silent Choir.

The Iron-Ring Cartel.

The Bleeding Crown.

The five names rose and sank like drowned bells. Not armies, not houses, not factions—only hungers given banners. Brannoc had served beneath one and sold his sword against another. He had drunk with men who swore loyalty to three, and buried men who had sworn to all five.

The corridor gave him no side to choose.

On the page beneath his hand, another sentence formed.

THE COLLAPSE OF THE ACCORD UNLEASHED A DECADE OF GUERRILLA REPRISALS.

The letters remained after he read them.

A decade.

Not a battle's aftermath. Not a season of vengeance. A decade.

He imagined villages emptied by night. Roads where every milestone bore a different corpse. Children learning the sound of boots before they learned the names of kings. He saw the Accord crumbling beneath its own signatures, while men called the ruin victory.

The grimoire wrote again.

THE LOSING COMMANDER WAS BRIBED TO WITHDRAW.

Korvath shut his eyes.

"There," Brannoc said. "That is what you came to find."

"I came to carry a message."

"To whom?"

Korvath looked at the sword. "To the man who would one day make the message matter."

Brannoc stepped closer. "Who sent you?"

The smuggler's face twisted. Fear had finally stripped away its caution. Beneath it lay not loyalty but exhaustion, the dead weight of a man who had carried a secret until the secret had begun carrying him.

“I cannot say.”

“You can.”

“I cannot.”

Brannoc pressed the bound sword beneath Korvath’s jaw.

The blade did not touch skin. It did not need to.

“Say the name.”

Korvath stared at him. “You think a name will save you?”

“No.”

“Then why ask?”

“Because I am tired of being saved by men who refuse to speak.”

The chain dragged again in the corridor.

Closer.

The frost-veiled figures beyond the door turned toward Brannoc as one. Their heads bowed.

The throne beneath the mountain shifted.

A crown struck stone.

Once.

Then again.

The book slipped from Brannoc’s hand and landed open at his feet. The page was no longer black. It had become a mirror.

In it, he saw himself beneath falling snow.

He wore no crown. He held the sword. Blood covered both hands, though none of it appeared to be his. Behind him burned a fortress with crooked towers. Before him knelt a line of soldiers in Ashen Vanguard colors.

At his feet lay a dead man wearing Brannoc’s own face.

The reflection lifted its head.

Its lips moved.

Brannoc heard the words inside his skull.

You are not the heir because you will rule.

The chain stopped.

You are the heir because they must kill you.

Korvath whispered, “Brannoc.”

The voice from beyond the door spoke once more.

Not the name this time.

The title.

“Red-Handed.”

The Thrice-Bound Edge flared in his grip. Its three bindings split apart, revealing a darkness within the metal deeper than the corridor itself.

Brannoc raised the sword.

Korvath backed away, but there was nowhere left to go. Behind him, the inner doors stood open. Ahead waited the frost-veiled dead, the leaning throne, the future that had already written his death into its ledger.

The grimoire turned one final page.

At the top, a date appeared.

300 AS.

Beneath it, in letters so small he had to bend close to read them, was a single sentence.

THE HAND THAT OPENS THIS DOOR WILL BE THE HAND THAT CLOSES THE CROWN.

Brannoc reached for the threshold.

Something on the other side reached back.

Chapter 4

The bell beneath Fenspire had a voice like iron dragged across a grave.

It sounded once through the fog, and every man in the garrison of 3,742 lifted his head.

Brannoc heard it from the windowless chamber below the eastern tower, where damp crawled down the walls and gathered in the mortar like sweat. The sound came through stone diminished but not softened. It entered the ribs. It made the candle flames bow.

A bell for alarm would have rung twice. Three times meant blood. The old fortress had its own grammar, hammered into metal before the Gloaming Reach learned to fear its own shadows.

Brannoc rested both hands on the table and watched the wax run beneath the candle. The left hand was clean. The right was not.

The blood had dried in the creases of his palm, black beneath the amber light. He had tried the basin. The water had clouded red, then grey, then something the color of weak milk. A servant had taken it away without being told. Servants knew when to flee a room. That was why they lived longer than soldiers.

Across the table, Korvath Nightbrook sat with his hood drawn low. He was a smuggler by trade and by bearing: a narrow, unobtrusive man, made for passing through doors that had no business opening. His hands remained beneath the table.

“Again,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s gaze shifted toward the ceiling. “The bell has already spoken.”

“Then let it speak to you.”

The smuggler swallowed. “A rider came from the Reach.”

“Riders come.”

“This one came without a horse.”

The candle gave a little spit.

Brannoc looked at him. “That is supposed to frighten me?”

“No.” Korvath’s eyes were pale in the gloom. “It is supposed to tell you the rider was not alone.”

Silence settled between them, thick as old ash. Beyond the walls, boots struck the flagstones in hurried measure. Fenspire was garrisoned, disciplined, vigilant. Even panic here marched in formation.

Brannoc turned his hand palm upward. The blood had found the lines in his skin and filled them like writing.

“How many?”

Korvath did not answer.

“Numbers are not prayers, Korvath.”

“Numbers are what got me through the gate.”

That was almost a jest. Almost.

Brannoc reached beneath his coat and drew out the leather-wrapped object. He placed it on the table without unfastening the straps. The bundle was not large, but it seemed to claim the room. Candlelight withdrew from its edges.

Korvath leaned back.

“The Thrice-Bound Edge,” he whispered.

“Regalia forged in 123 AS,” Brannoc said.

“I know what it is.”

“Then you know why men kill for it.”

“I know why men say they kill for it.” Korvath’s mouth tightened. “The difference has filled more graves than the Gloaming Reach.”

Brannoc almost smiled. The expression failed before it reached his face.

Beside the wrapped regalia lay a black volume, its cover swollen from damp and clasped with a dull metal hook. The name had been pressed into the leather in lettering so faint that it appeared only when the candle guttered.

Edge of Gloamreach.

A grimoire. Its attunement cost was 46. The number had been copied into every catalogue that still dared to list the thing. No one had recorded when it was forged. No one had recorded much about the hands that had held it.

Korvath stared at the book with the hatred of a man who had seen a locked door open from the inside.

“You brought both,” he said.

“I brought what was promised.”

“To whom?”

Brannoc unwrapped the regalia by one fold. The metal beneath was dark, neither silver nor iron, and bound in a pattern that seemed to tighten when looked at directly.

“To the people who still understand promises.”

Korvath gave a dry breath. “You mean the people who have soldiers.”

“I mean The Bleeding Crown.”

The name seemed to alter the air. Outside, a command rang through the fortress courtyard. The words were lost beneath the bell, but the obedience they summoned was plain.

Brannoc wound the leather back around The Thrice-Bound Edge.

He had worn many banners. Most had been stitched by hands that never saw a battlefield. Most had been raised for reasons no one could remember after the first corpse fell. But The Bleeding Crown did not need to be remembered. It survived by making itself the wound in every conversation.

“The Accord of Mournthrone has made cowards of too many men,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s eyes flicked toward the door. “The Accord of Mournthrone has made widows.”

“It began in 297 AS.”

“I can count.”

“It ends in 301 AS.”

“If anyone is alive to write it down.”

Brannoc looked past him, though there was only stone. Somewhere above, the tower’s narrow windows faced the Reach. Fenspire stood in that dim country like a spear driven into a dying god. Its garrison of 3,742 was meant to make the place impregnable. It had not made the bell silent.

“The Ashen Vanguard will be named victor,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s hand emerged from the darkness beneath the table. In it was a small knife with no shine along its edge.

“Then why are you here?”

Because victory was a word men used after counting the dead. Because a banner could be nailed to a wall while the wall still burned. Because the losing commander of The Accord of Mournthorne had been bribed to withdraw, and every man with eyes could see the shape of the lie, even if no one dared speak the coin’s name.

Brannoc did not say those things. A truth spoken aloud became evidence. Evidence became ownership. Ownership became a noose.

Instead he said, “The accord is a door.”

Korvath’s knife rested against the table. “Doors open both ways.”

“The one who closes it decides who is trapped.”

“And which side are you on?”

The question was soft. It should have been harmless. It was not.

Brannoc felt the old secret stir beneath his breastbone, not as pride but as an animal waking in a pit.

He was Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed, a member of The Bleeding Crown. He was also its unacknowledged heir, though no oath, decree, or blood-marked ledger had ever given the claim a shape men could be forced to recognize.

There were crowns that sat upon brows and crowns that sat upon throats. His had always been the latter.

“Ask me again,” he said.

Korvath’s knife stopped moving.

The bell sounded a second time.

This time the chamber’s candle went out.

Darkness rushed in. Brannoc heard the scrape of Korvath’s chair, the wet breath of a man trying not to breathe, and beyond the walls the sudden tumult of Fenspire’s garrison. Boots. Steel. A shouted order cut short.

Then something struck the eastern tower.

The impact shuddered through the room. Dust fell from the ceiling. The wrapped regalia slid across the table and struck the grimoire. The clasp sprang open.

For an instant there was no light, yet Brannoc saw the book.

Its pages had opened by themselves.

A grey radiance seeped between them, thin as mist over a grave. Letters moved across the paper in lines that refused to remain still. The air tasted of frost and burnt hair.

Korvath whispered a prayer.

“Do not pray,” Brannoc said.

“I am not praying.”

“Then stop sounding guilty.”

He seized the grimoire and slammed it shut. The radiance vanished, leaving his fingers numb. From the corridor came the scrape of bolts being drawn.

Someone was approaching the chamber.

Korvath rose. The knife in his hand trembled once, then steadied. “You said this room was secure.”

“It was.”

“That is not the same as being safe.”

“Nothing is safe.”

The first blow struck the door.

The iron bands groaned. A little rust shook free and fell like red dust.

Brannoc tucked The Thrice-Bound Edge beneath his coat. Its weight settled against him with a restraint that felt almost like a hand laid upon his shoulder. He left the Edge of Gloamreach on the table.

Korvath stared at it. “You are leaving that?”

“I am.”

“Why?”

“Because whoever comes through that door wants the regalia.”

“And the book?”

“Whoever wants the book is worse.”

The second blow cracked one of the hinges.

Brannoc crossed the room and lifted the bar from its brackets. Korvath caught his sleeve.

“Wait.”

Brannoc turned.

The smuggler’s guarded face had lost its practiced emptiness. “There were no soldiers with the rider.”

“You said there was more than one.”

“I said the rider was not alone.”

A third blow.

The door bulged inward.

Korvath leaned close. His breath carried the sourness of fear. “The dead were walking beside him.”

Brannoc looked at the wood, at the iron hinges, at the thin black seam where the corridor waited beyond.

He had seen men rise after death. Every battlefield made a liar of the living. But Korvath did not speak of corpses animated by spell or wire. He spoke of the kind that remembered.

Above them, the bell began its third ringing.

Blood.

Brannoc drew his sword.

The chamber seemed to narrow around the blade. His right hand closed over the hilt, red-stained and sure. He could feel the old claim inside him now, no longer stirring but standing.

“Open it,” Korvath said.

“Why?”

“Because if they break it, they come in angry.”

“If I open it, they come in invited.”

The door shuddered again. A splinter spun across the floor and stopped against the Edge of Gloamreach.

The grimoire’s clasp clicked.

Once.

Twice.

Brannoc heard something breathe behind the sealed cover.

He reached for the bolt, and from the corridor a voice spoke his full name—■

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

The voice did not come from the corridor.

It came from the wood beneath his hand.

Brannoc stopped with his fingers resting on the bolt. The iron was cold enough to bite through the blood drying across his knuckles. Beyond the door, something dragged its weight from one side of the passage to the other. The sound was patient. It had learned patience from men.

Korvath had gone very still.

“You heard it,” Brannoc said.

“I heard you hear it.”

The third bell gave a final shudder overhead. Its note descended through the stone and settled in Brannoc’s teeth.

The clasp of the grimoire opened.

Not wide. A black slit, no more. From within came the smell of wet ash and old flowers left too long in a sealed room.

Korvath moved toward the table. "Do not touch it."

"That counsel comes late."

"Then heed it late."

Brannoc looked at the door. The planks bowed inward. Dust sifted from the lintel in thin gray streams. Whatever stood outside had stopped striking. That silence was worse than the blows. A siege was honest while it spent its strength.

He drew back the bolt.

The door opened an inch.

Darkness pressed against the gap.

No face waited there. No torch. The corridor beyond was empty from threshold to the bend, though the candles fixed along its walls burned with their flames bent toward the far end. A wet trail marked the stones. It began at the door and vanished into the dark.

Korvath whispered, "Close it."

Brannoc opened it farther.

The air that entered was colder than the chamber air, and carried the metallic reek of blood. Somewhere beyond the bend, a man began to hum. The tune had no shape Brannoc knew, but his bones remembered it. The sound made his sword feel suddenly too light.

He stepped through.

"Brannoc."

Korvath's hand caught his sleeve.

Brannoc looked down at the fingers gripping him. Smuggler's fingers: narrow, scarred, quick. They had slipped knives from belts and coin from purses. They had never held a captain on the edge of a thing neither man could name.

"If I am not back," Brannoc said, "burn the book."

"With what?"

"Your regret."

Korvath's mouth tightened. "I have plenty."

Brannoc pulled free.

The corridor received him without echo. The air was close here, thick with mortar dust and the sour damp of old stone. Behind him, Korvath came out and eased the door nearly shut. The chamber's candlelight narrowed to a blade, then disappeared.

The humming continued.

Brannoc followed the blood.

It had not been spilled in drops. It had been drawn. A thin red line, glossy as lacquer, ran along the stones in a deliberate curve. It led away from the chamber, away from the stair, toward a section of wall where the masonry had been patched in a different age. The newer stones were pale and clean. No mark broke their surface.

The voice spoke again.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

This time it came from inside the wall.

He raised his sword.

The blade caught no light. It seemed to drink what little the corridor offered, leaving the air around it dimmer. The old claim he had felt before the door remained within him, upright and watchful. He did not know whether it belonged to blood, steel, or the grimoire. He knew only that it had begun to resemble hunger.

“Show yourself,” he said.

The wall answered with a soft knock.

Once.

Twice.

A third time, from farther within the stone.

Korvath approached behind him, making less sound than the dust. “That is not a wall.”

“No.”

“What is it?”

“Something that wants out.”

“Then let it stay wanting.”

The grimoire’s clasp clicked in the chamber behind them.

Korvath turned.

For one breath Brannoc watched the smuggler’s face lose its color. Then the door opened by itself. The chamber beyond was empty, the table standing under the candle flames, the Edge of Gloamreach lying open upon it.

Its pages were turning.

Not with the wind. There was no wind. Each page lifted, shivered, and fell with the wet delicacy of skin being peeled from a wound.

Korvath’s voice thinned. “You said burn it.”

“I remember.”

“You also said you were not coming back.”

“I have not come back.”

Another knock sounded inside the wall.

The blood-line brightened.

Brannoc turned toward the patched stones. “What is written in it?”

“You can read.”

“I can read contracts.”

“Then read the one it has made with you.”

The sword’s point touched the wall.

Stone softened.

It did not crack or crumble. It yielded beneath the steel like flesh beneath a thumb. A dark seam spread outward from the point, branching through the mortar. Cold breathed from it. Brannoc smelled rain, though no rain had touched the fortress in the chamber’s sealed dark.

The seam opened.

Beyond it stood a room no larger than a coffin.

A chair occupied the center. Something sat in it with its back to him.

The shoulders were wrapped in a cloak too dark to be black. Water ran from the hem and gathered around the chair legs. The head was bowed. One hand rested upon the armrest. The other hung limp at its side, fingers trailing through the blood that had become a pool.

Brannoc knew the hand.

He knew the ringless knuckles, the crooked little finger, the scar crossing the thumb’s base. He had watched that hand close around a sword. He had watched it sign orders, take payment, break a man’s jaw against a table.

He had watched it burn.

The figure in the chair lifted its head.

There was no face.

Only a depth beneath the hood, a vacancy in which a faint red glimmer moved like a coal beneath ash.

“Do not answer,” Korvath said.

The faceless thing turned toward him.

Korvath staggered back. His boot struck the wall. The sound broke the corridor’s unnatural quiet.

The thing rose.

Its joints made no noise. Water slid from the cloak and crawled uphill along the stones. Where its feet touched the floor, the blood-line divided around them.

Brannoc felt his sword hand tighten.

The chamber door stood open behind Korvath. The grimoire waited on its table. Its pages had stopped turning.

A single line of black writing had appeared across the spread.

He could read it from the corridor.

Wielder: Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.

Below that, in a narrower hand:

Since 314 AS.

For an instant the world lost its order.

The words were not a prophecy. They were not a threat. They possessed the flat authority of an account already settled.

Brannoc stared at the year.

His mouth went dry.

“Korvath,” he said.

“I see it.”

“You know what it means?”

“I know it means the book is lying.”

“Books do not lie.”

“Men write them.”

The thing stepped out of the wall.

Its cloak brushed the stones. Beneath the hood, the red glimmer fixed upon Brannoc’s sword. The old claim inside him stirred toward it, not in fear but recognition. His palm opened without permission.

Across the corridor, Edge of Gloamreach gave a low, papery sigh.

The grimoire’s letters shifted.

Wielder: Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.

Since 314 AS.

The same words. The same year. The ink began to seep through the page, running downward in thin black veins.

Brannoc advanced one step.

The thing lifted its hand.

His sword moved.

Not by his will. The blade tore free of his grip and crossed the corridor, striking the wall beside the creature’s head. Stone burst outward. The impact rang through his arm and shoulder as though he had been the one to swing it.

The thing leaned close to the sword.

A mouth opened where its face should have been.

Inside was a red-lit chamber, and in that chamber stood a man with his back turned, wearing a captain's coat darkened by rain. The man's hand was raised before him. Blood shone along it. Beyond him, banners hung in tatters from unseen rafters.

Brannoc heard voices murmuring behind the mouth.

Not words. Names stripped of meaning.

He seized the hilt.

The sword came free with a sound like a breath drawn through teeth.

The creature recoiled. Its cloak flared, revealing no body beneath it, only the corridor continuing through the shape into a darkness deeper than distance.

Korvath made a choking sound.

"Move," Brannoc said.

They ran.

The corridor stretched under their feet. Doors appeared on either side, then vanished when Brannoc looked directly at them. The blood-line kept pace, flowing backward now, climbing the stones toward the open chamber. Behind them came the scrape of the thing's passage, though it did not seem to walk. It dragged the dark after itself.

Korvath reached the threshold first and seized the edge of the door.

Brannoc crossed behind him.

The grimoire's pages snapped shut.

The creature struck the corridor wall.

Stone folded inward. A wave of force threw Korvath across the chamber. He hit the table, and the candle flame leapt green before returning to its old color.

Brannoc fell to one knee.

His sword skidded away.

The door slammed shut.

Something struck it from the other side.

Once.

The hinges screamed.

Korvath lay among the scattered papers, one hand pressed to his ribs. "You had a plan."

"I had a door."

"It was a poor plan."

Another blow. The table jumped. The grimoire slid toward the edge.

Brannoc rose and crossed the chamber. He saw the black line on its cover, the faint pulse beneath the leather. He thought of the words inside. The year stood in his mind like a nail driven through bone.

He lifted the Edge of Gloamreach.

The book was heavier than it looked. Its cover seemed to resist him, not with weight but with refusal. The attunement cost was 46, the old record had said, and now the number surfaced in his thoughts with the clarity of a sentence spoken close to his ear.

Forty-six.

Not coin. Not blood. Not yet.

“What are you doing?” Korvath demanded.

Brannoc set the grimoire against his chest.

The door shuddered.

The sword lay several paces away, its point aimed at the sealed wood.

“Open,” Brannoc said.

The clasp clicked.

The cover began to rise.

And from beneath it, in a voice that wore his own like a stolen face, something whispered—

The voice spoke again.

“Attunement cost: 46.”

Brannoc’s fingers tightened around the grimoire. The leather was cold enough to burn. Beneath its cover, pages shifted with the soft, patient sound of something breathing in sleep.

Korvath Nightbrook had gone still.

He was not a man easily stilled. Smugglers survived by making themselves smaller than danger, thinner than suspicion. Yet now he stood with one hand inside his coat and the other hovering near the knife at his belt, his gaze fixed on the book.

“Put it down,” Korvath said.

The voice beneath the cover answered in Brannoc’s tone.

“Put it down.”

The door shuddered again. Dust sifted from the lintel. Somewhere beyond it, iron scraped over stone.

Brannoc did not look away from the clasp. “You heard that?”

“I heard you.”

“That was not me.”

Korvath’s mouth twisted. “Then it has excellent manners.”

A seam of darkness showed between the cover and the first page. It was not ordinary dark. It held the color of old bruises, of twilight pressed into a wound. The room seemed to lean toward it. The flame in the

nearest lamp narrowed until it became a blue needle.

Brannoc felt the book searching him.

Not his hands. Not his blood. Something farther in.

It found the years he had spent sleeping beneath roofs that were not his, eating at tables where his name was never spoken. It found the shape of a crown seen through smoke. It found the old, unacknowledged claim buried beneath the sellsword's iron discipline, beneath the contracts, the campaigns, the bodies paid for and left behind.

The Bleeding Crown stirred in the dark of him.

"No," he whispered.

The cover rose another finger's breadth.

Korvath heard the refusal. His eyes flicked toward Brannoc, and for one instant the smuggler looked less wary than afraid.

"You know what it wants."

"I know what books want."

"They want readers."

"This one wants a king."

The word entered the room like a drawn blade.

The door groaned. Something struck it from the other side—not a fist, not a shoulder, but a weight with no patience for hinges. The boards bowed inward.

Brannoc's first instinct was to reach for Edge of Gloamreach. His hand was already on it.

The grimoire laughed.

The sound came from the pages and from the walls and from behind his teeth.

"Your hand," it whispered. "Your hand. Your hand."

He looked down.

The cover had opened.

There was no writing on the first page. Only a dark impression, as if a palm had been pressed into wet ash. Five fingers. A wrist. The mark of ownership without a name.

Brannoc's own hand hovered above it.

Korvath caught his arm.

The smuggler's grip was lean and hard. "No."

Brannoc could have broken free. He had broken stronger men for less. But Korvath's fingers had closed around the scarred place where Brannoc's strength faltered, and pain flashed white behind his eyes.

"You think I need your permission?"

"I think you need someone to remember you are not alone."

The words struck deeper than the pain.

Beyond the door, the iron scrape became a slow dragging. Whatever waited there was testing the threshold. Brannoc could imagine it without seeing it: a shape made of old war, a mouth full of dust, a hand seeking the latch.

The grimoire's pages turned by themselves.

One.

Two.

Three.

Each leaf was blank.

On the fourth, ink appeared.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.

He stared at the name.

Not a title. Not a boast. A verdict.

The ink ran downward in thin black threads. Beneath it, another line formed.

Born in 255 AS.

Korvath swore under his breath.

Brannoc pulled against him. "You knew?"

"I know how to read."

"Not that."

"I know enough to recognize a trap."

The page darkened. More letters rose through the fibers.

The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS.

The room grew colder.

Brannoc's memories did not come as memories. They came as smells: wet leather, extinguished pitch, the mineral reek of blood in rain. The Accord of Mournthrone had not been a single battle, nor a clean division between the living and the dead. It had been years of men calling slaughter negotiation because the word sounded less shameful.

The page turned.

The Accord of Mournthrone ended in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.

Korvath released Brannoc's arm.

The lack of pressure felt like abandonment.

"Read the rest," the voice urged.

"I have no interest."

“You have no choice.”

The door boomed. A crack appeared along one of its planks, black and narrow as a pupil.

Brannoc moved before Korvath could stop him. He seized the sword lying several paces away. The hilt was cold. The blade answered with a tremor that traveled up through his wrist.

The Thrice-Bound Edge rested in its sheath at his side, regalia forged in 123 AS, its presence restrained and binding beneath the worn leather. Edge of Gloamreach was another kind of authority. It did not bind. It opened.

The grimoire turned again.

The hidden truth: the losing commander was bribed to withdraw.

For a moment Brannoc could hear nothing but his own breathing.

Then he laughed.

It came out dry and ugly.

Korvath watched him. “What?”

“That is the truth?”

“That is not a truth. That is bait.”

“It knows about the commander.”

“It knows what people fear. That is enough.”

Brannoc looked at the page. The ink had begun to bead, each black drop gathering at the bottom margin before slipping away into the paper.

The losing commander had been bribed.

How many had died so the withdrawal could be called honor? How many had been sent forward while coin changed hands behind them? The thought did not disgust him. Disgust required surprise. It only sharpened something already present.

The Accord of Mournthrone had ended in 301 AS.

Brannoc had died in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone.

He knew that.

He knew the fact as a man knew the shape of his own grave.

Yet his hand still held the sword. His lungs still filled. His heart still beat beneath his ribs with the slow insistence of a prisoner testing chains.

The grimoire knew this contradiction. It savored it.

“Dead men make excellent heirs,” it whispered.

Korvath backed toward the wall. “Do not listen.”

“Why?”

“Because it is speaking with your voice.”

“It has always been my voice.”

“No.” Korvath’s stare hardened. “That is the worst part.”

The page emptied itself. A new line burned into view.

Fenspire was founded in 57 AS.

The name carried a distant pressure. Brannoc saw a spire in the mind’s eye, stark against the Gloaming Reach, and walls crowded with watchfires. He saw discipline made into architecture. He saw a garrison of 3,742 standing in permanent vigilance beneath a sky the color of ash.

He had never been there.

Or he had been there in the way a dead man had been everywhere his name had traveled.

The page turned.

Crookvale was founded in 295 AS.

This time the vision came crooked and hard-edged: rebuilt stone, wary streets, a garrison of 1004 holding itself apart from the core holdings. Survival had become its governing principle. The number stood clear in the darkness, every digit a nail.

“Why those places?” Korvath asked.

Brannoc did not answer.

The book supplied another page.

The Thrice-Bound Edge was forged in 123 AS.

The sword at Brannoc’s side gave a faint chime.

Not a ringing sound. A recognition.

Korvath noticed. “That is not yours.”

Brannoc’s gaze remained on the grimoire. “You have mistaken possession for ownership.”

“I have mistaken nothing tonight.”

The door cracked again. A sliver of gray light appeared beyond it, though there was no light in the passage. Through the gap came a smell of wet iron and extinguished candles.

The pages began turning rapidly.

The voice multiplied.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

“Unacknowledged heir.”

“Major Sellsword Captain.”

“Bleeding Crown.”

“Dead in 300 AS.”

Each phrase struck a different place inside him. The first was a name others had used to make his violence memorable. The second was a secret others had used to make his existence dangerous. The third was a station he had earned in blood. The fourth was the claim that had never been allowed to become a claim.

The fifth was the only one he could not deny.

He looked at Korvath.

The smuggler's face had gone pale, but his voice remained level. "If you are dead, what am I standing beside?"

Brannoc considered the question.

"The debt," he said.

The grimoire's cover strained wider. The dark beneath its pages deepened until it looked like a well.

Then the voice spoke without wearing his face.

"The Accord of Mournthrone unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals."

Korvath flinched.

Brannoc did not. He had heard the reprisals in the years after the accord—the sudden knives, the burned stores, the villages emptied by men who had learned that peace was only war with its boots removed. A decade stretched before him, long and low and smoking.

The book continued.

"The Ashen Vanguard named victor."

The words came again, but now they were spoken from beyond the door.

"The Ashen Vanguard named victor."

A shape pressed against the crack.

Not a hand. Not yet.

Korvath reached for the latch.

Brannoc caught him. "Wait."

"For what?"

"For it to say my name one more time."

"You are a fool."

"Yes."

The grimoire's final visible page was not blank.

At its center, a sentence had been written in red.

The door opens for the heir.

Brannoc's grip tightened around the sword. The Edge of Gloamreach throbbed against his chest. Its attunement cost was 46. The number returned with terrible clarity, not as a warning now, but as a demand.

Forty-six.

The book had not asked for blood.

It had asked for agreement.

Outside, something breathed against the door.

Korvath whispered, "Do not open it."

The latch began to turn.

Brannoc felt the old claim rise through him, colder than ambition and heavier than grief. He had been born in 255 AS. He had died in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone. The world had named the Ashen Vanguard victor when the accord ended in 301 AS.

None of that mattered to the thing waiting outside.

It wanted the part of him that had survived the grave.

Brannoc placed his palm upon the dark impression.

The page closed over his hand.

And the door opened inward.

Chapter 5

Rain worried the roof like a beggar with a knife.

It slipped through the cracked slate above Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed and fell in cold beads upon the table, darkening the map where the roads had once been inked. The parchment had been folded and unfolded until its creases shone. Mountains rose from it in pale ridges. Rivers wandered like old scars. Whole territories had been rubbed away by thumbs, damp, and the patient violence of men who preferred borders to remain uncertain.

Brannoc set one hand upon the map.

The other was red.

Not with blood. Not yet.

The iron basin beside him held water gone pink from the dye with which he scrubbed his gloves. The color had soaked into the leather and stayed there. It had stained the seams of his cuffs, the nails of one hand, the memory of every eye that had ever looked upon him and decided what sort of man he must be.

The Red-Handed.

A name could be a brand. A brand could become a banner.

Outside, the ruined yard filled with rain. Beyond the leaning wall, the camp muttered in its sleep: harness buckles chiming, a horse stamping, a whetstone rasping over steel. Men breathed beneath canvas. Men dreamed of coin. Men dreamed of the dead. Some dreamed of the Bleeding Crown, though none would confess it within earshot of a priest or a paymaster.

Brannoc lifted the folded message from the table.

The seal had been broken before it reached him.

He turned it over.

“You read it.”

The man by the doorway did not answer.

He had the narrow, unremarkable look of someone who survived by belonging nowhere. Rain silvered his shoulders. His boots were muddy to the knee, his cloak plain, his face more shadow than feature. He kept one hand beneath the cloak.

Brannoc watched that hand.

“Did you read it?” he asked again.

“I know what it says.”

“That was not the question.”

The man’s gaze moved to the basin. “You wash your glove in blood.”

“Dye.”

“Blood is dye, if the cloth is worth little.”

Brannoc smiled without warmth. “And a lie is a message, if the listener is desperate.”

The man stepped into the room. Wind pressed the door against his back, and for an instant the darkness outside seemed to enter with him. He shut it carefully.

Brannoc knew his kind. Not by face. Faces lied too easily. By the way they occupied a threshold. By the silence they brought with them. This was Korvath Nightbrook, a smuggler, and a minor figure in the great machinery of the Ashen Era—though minor men often carried the levers that moved greater ones toward the pit.

Korvath placed a small object on the table.

A black ribbon.

Brannoc did not touch it.

“From whom?”

Korvath’s mouth twitched. “You ask as if the answer could be clean.”

“Nothing travels cleanly through the Gloaming Reach.”

“The message came from there.”

“Then it came through mud, knives, and a dozen frightened hands.”

“Fewer.”

Brannoc looked up.

Korvath’s eyes were pale in the gloom. Guarded eyes. Wary eyes. A man who measured every word against the cost of carrying it.

“Fewer,” Brannoc repeated.

“You have a talent for making a small number feel like a threat.”

“I have a talent for making threats feel small.”

The rain thickened. Somewhere beyond the wall, a horse screamed once and was silenced.

Brannoc unfolded the message. The writing crawled across the page in a cramped hand. He read it once. Then again, though the second reading changed nothing.

A summons.

A demand disguised as an invitation.

The Ashen Vanguard wanted parley. House Morvain wanted obedience. The Silent Choir wanted silence, which was the most honest of the three. The Iron-Ring Cartel wanted whatever could be weighed, counted, or sold. The Bleeding Crown wanted a claimant it could deny until denial became impossible.

The five powers contended over the ruins, and each believed the ruins belonged to it.

Brannoc folded the message along its old crease.

“Who else knows I received this?”

Korvath’s silence was answer enough.

Brannoc reached for the dagger beneath the table.

Korvath did not move. That was either courage or the habit of a man who had survived by refusing to surprise anyone.

“Put it away,” he said.

“Why?”

“Because if you meant to use it, you would already have done so.”

Brannoc considered him. “You have mistaken restraint for mercy.”

“I mistake nothing. That is how I remain alive.”

“Alive is a thin ambition.”

“It is thicker than dead.”

The words settled between them.

Brannoc drew the dagger anyway. Its blade was dull along one side and bright along the other. He used the bright edge to cut the black ribbon in two.

The halves fell upon the map.

One landed across a road that led toward Fenspire.

The name had been written in a faded hand at the edge of the Reach. Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, its stark spire rising through the dim country like a spear thrust up from the earth. A garrisoned core location. A garrison of 3,742. Discipline lived there in walls and watchfires. Vigilance had become its climate.

The other half covered a smaller mark farther north.

Crookvale.

Founded in 295 AS in The High Spires. Rebuilt after whatever violence had cracked its first bones. A garrison of 1004. Outside the core holdings, wary and resilient, governing itself by the simple law of survival.

Numbers were a kind of spell. They made stone seem permanent. They made armed men seem sufficient. Brannoc had watched both fail.

“Fenspire,” he said.

Korvath said nothing.

“And Crookvale.”

Still nothing.

“You carried this far to watch me read a map?”

“I carried it because the road is closing.”

“Roads do not close.”

“Men close them.”

“Men can be killed.”

“Not all at once.”

Brannoc leaned over the parchment. Rainwater trembled in the hollows of the map. The mountains looked like teeth. He imagined marching through them beneath a sky the color of old iron, his sellswords moving behind him in a long, hungry file. He imagined the gates of Fenspire opening. He imagined the garrison counting him as he passed, each soldier a witness, each witness a possible executioner.

Then he imagined the Crown.

Not the circlet. Not the crimson metal or the old throne or the hands that had reached for it and found only ash.

The word itself.

Bleeding Crown.

It had followed him through taverns, battlefields, and rooms where nobles smiled with their mouths and sharpened their thoughts. He was its unacknowledged heir. The truth had no legal weight, no seal, no witness who had not learned to fear its consequences. Yet truth did not require permission to remain true.

Brannoc had been born in 255 AS.

He had learned early that birth was a door, not a welcome.

“Say it,” Korvath murmured.

Brannoc glanced at him. “Say what?”

“You have been staring at the Crown as if it were in the room.”

“It is always in the room.”

“The Crown is not yours.”

The dagger stopped turning in Brannoc’s fingers.

Korvath’s expression did not change, but his shoulders had tightened. A smuggler’s caution. He had carried contraband through guarded places; now he had carried a truth into a room where truth was more dangerous than silver.

“No,” Brannoc said. “It is not.”

The rain struck the roof. A thin stream ran down the wall behind Korvath, finding its way between stones.

“But if it were mine,” Brannoc continued, “would you kneel?”

“I would leave.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the answer that keeps my knees where they are.”

Brannoc laughed softly. The sound had no joy in it. “You have heard too many promises.”

“I have heard enough.”

“And what do you hear now?”

Korvath looked toward the table. Toward the black ribbon. Toward Fenspire and Crookvale and all the roads that men had drawn to pretend the world could be made orderly.

“I hear a summons,” he said. “I hear a trap. I hear men who need you to believe they fear you.”

“Do they?”

“They fear what you might become.”

Brannoc pressed his red-stained hand flat against the map.

He was a Sellsword Captain. The words had been spoken over him by paymasters, commanders, nobles, and dying men. A title bought with other men’s courage, renewed by other men’s blood. It was not a crown. It was not an inheritance. It was a weapon rented by the hour.

Yet even a rented weapon could turn in the hand.

The door shuddered.

Korvath’s right hand vanished beneath his cloak.

Brannoc rose without haste, dagger low beside his thigh. The room seemed to narrow around them. The basin. The map. The message. The black ribbon cut cleanly in two.

A voice came from beyond the door.

“Captain Ironmere.”

Brannoc felt the old name in his bones before the newer one followed.

“The Red-Handed.”

His fingers closed around the dagger.

Korvath whispered, “You were followed.”

“No.”

The voice outside spoke again.

“Open.”

Brannoc looked at the rain sliding down the wall, at the road to Fenspire, at Crookvale’s crooked mark, at the black ribbon lying between them like a severed vein.

Then the latch began to lift.

The latch rose.

Brannoc moved before the door opened. He caught Korvath by the collar and drove him sideways, behind the hanging cloth that divided the chamber from the narrow stair. The smuggler’s breath hissed through his teeth. Brannoc put one finger to his lips.

The door opened a finger’s width.

Rain breathed through the gap. Then a gloved hand appeared, palm outward, empty of steel.

“Captain Ironmere,” said the voice.

Brannoc stood with his dagger low. The old name had been used by men who wanted to buy him, men who wanted to kill him, and men who had not yet decided which would be cheaper. None of them had ever spoken it gently.

“Say what you came to say.”

“Not through a door.”

“Then say it through the crack.”

A pause. He heard the wet shift of boots beyond the threshold. More than one pair.

Korvath made a sound behind the cloth—not fear. Calculation. It was the sound of a man measuring exits and finding each one had a price.

Brannoc kept his eyes on the gap. “You brought company.”

“I brought witnesses.”

“For what?”

“To the warning.”

The door opened another inch. A scrap of pale material slid across the floor and stopped beside Brannoc’s boot.

He did not bend for it.

The room smelled of damp wool, tallow, and the sharp mineral stink of the basin. The black ribbon lay on the table, its cut ends curled as though still remembering the blade. Beyond the shutterless window, rain blurred the roofs of Crookvale until the settlement seemed less rebuilt than drowned and dragged upright again.

“Your warning is wet,” Brannoc said.

“So is the road.”

“Then go back along it.”

The unseen speaker exhaled. “You are expected at Fenspire.”

The name entered the room like cold iron.

Korvath shifted behind the hanging cloth. Brannoc heard the faint scrape of metal. Not a drawn blade. Not yet.

“By whom?”

“Those who have the authority to expect you.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only answer you are being offered.”

Brannoc crouched and picked up the scrap. It was not paper. It was a strip torn from some thicker fabric, pale and waxed, with a mark pressed into it: three intersecting strokes around a hollow center. He knew the shape. He had seen it on gates and writs, on crates sealed against pilfering, on the cuffs of men who believed law was something worn rather than obeyed.

He turned it once between his fingers.

“No seal,” he said.

“Not here.”

“Then this is a piece of rag.”

“Keep it.”

Brannoc smiled without warmth. “You came to a locked room to give me a rag?”

“To give you a choice.”

At that, Korvath stepped from behind the hanging cloth.

He kept one hand beneath his coat. His face remained in shadow, but his shoulders had tightened. Men like Korvath Nightbrook survived by making themselves part of the background until the instant they needed to become a door, a knife, or a lie. He was a Smuggler, and every lawful road had taught him the same lesson: the destination mattered less than who was waiting at the crossing.

“You said no one followed you,” Brannoc murmured.

“No one followed me.”

“Four boots outside.”

“Four boots were waiting.”

The voice beyond the door said, “The smuggler is not part of this.”

Korvath’s hand shifted under his coat.

Brannoc did not look at him. “He is standing in my room. That makes him part of whatever enters it.”

“Then he may leave.”

Korvath gave a small, humorless laugh. “Generous.”

“You should take the offer,” Brannoc said.

“I have taken offers before.”

“And lived.”

“Sometimes.”

The word settled between them. It was too honest for the room.

Brannoc glanced toward the map. Crookvale’s crooked mark had been drawn in charcoal, the lines roughened by damp. The road to Fenspire ran away from it in a thin black stroke, disappearing beneath the fold of the parchment. The message beside it remained unopened. He had brought it out of habit, not trust. Now the seal seemed to stare at him.

“Who knows I am here?” he asked.

“No one who matters.”

“Who matters?”

“Those at Fenspire.”

“Still not an answer.”

The door opened wider.

A blade slid through first, narrow and bright. Brannoc’s hand closed around the dagger. The man outside paused, perhaps waiting for the room to flinch. Brannoc had learned long ago that men who entered with a blade ahead of them feared what might follow.

He kicked the door.

It struck the blade-hand hard against the jamb. A curse broke in the passage. Brannoc seized the edge and pulled. The first man stumbled across the threshold. He wore rain-darkened leather and a hood that hid most of his face. Brannoc drove the pommel of his dagger beneath the hood, into the soft place below the jaw.

The man folded.

The second came in fast.

Korvath sprang aside. A sword cut the air where his chest had been and buried itself in the table. The basin toppled. Water rushed across the map, carrying charcoal into crooked black veins.

Brannoc caught the attacker’s wrist. The man was stronger than he looked, his sleeve slick beneath Brannoc’s fingers. He smelled of wet wool and old ash. Brannoc twisted until the sword came free of the wood, then drove the man shoulder-first into the wall.

Plaster cracked.

The third voice shouted from the passage. “Alive!”

The word made Brannoc hesitate.

Only for a breath. A breath was enough.

The man at the wall slammed his forehead against Brannoc’s mouth. Pain flowered white. Brannoc tasted blood. The dagger came up between them, not deep, only enough to make the attacker recoil and leave a dark line at his throat.

Korvath kicked the fallen sword away.

“Brannoc.”

The use of his first name cut through the struggle more sharply than the blade.

He turned.

The first man was rising.

Korvath had drawn a small crossbow from beneath his coat. It looked absurd in the cramped room, too compact to carry such final authority. Its quarrel rested against the man’s chest.

“Don’t,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s eyes moved toward him. “He has a vote?”

“He has a message.”

“He has a throat.”

The rising man froze. Rainwater dripped from his hood onto the floor. Underneath it, his face was young enough to have retained softness, though terror had stripped it away. He looked at Brannoc as if the epithet had become a visible thing between them.

The Red-Handed.

Brannoc felt the old name gather in the man’s silence. Not a title. A verdict waiting for evidence.

The man against the wall coughed. “Fenspire.”

“What about it?” Brannoc asked.

“They know.”

“Who?”

The man’s mouth worked. He glanced at the strip of waxed cloth in Brannoc’s hand.

“They know what you carry.”

Brannoc’s eyes went to the table.

The grimoire lay beneath the map’s wet fold, its dark cover barely visible. Edge of Gloamreach. Even closed, it seemed to draw the room inward. The book’s attunement cost was 46, and the number had been written in a careful hand inside its first cover, as though warning and invitation were the same thing.

Korvath saw where he was looking.

“So that is the choice,” the smuggler said. “You go to Fenspire with the book, or they come here for it.”

The man with the sword laughed weakly. “Not the book.”

Brannoc crouched beside him. “Then tell me.”

The man pressed one hand to his throat. Blood marked his glove. “The other thing.”

The room seemed to contract.

Brannoc’s gaze moved to the wrapped length resting beneath the bed, where it had been hidden from the first glance. He had not touched it since arriving. Regalia forged in 123 AS. The Thrice-Bound Edge. Its name had passed through too many mouths, each mouth making it sound less like an object and more like a promise that had survived its maker.

Korvath lowered the crossbow by a fraction.

The man on the floor saw that and tried to breathe easier.

“Who sent you?” Brannoc asked.

“If I tell you—”

“You will still be bleeding.”

“If I tell you, they kill what remains.”

“What remains of what?”

The man shut his mouth.

Outside, thunder moved somewhere beyond the high roofs. The sound came late, rolling through Crookvale's rebuilt bones. In the pause, Brannoc could hear the rain striking the sill, Korvath's measured breathing, and the faint wet drip from the corner of the map.

He knelt and lifted the wrapped regalia from beneath the bed.

The binding cord was cold.

Korvath's crossbow rose again. "You should not open it."

"I wasn't planning to."

"You should not carry it either."

"That advice arrives late."

"It arrives before Fenspire."

Brannoc looked at him. "You object to the road?"

"I object to the men waiting at its end."

"You know who they are?"

"I know men who wait beside roads. That is enough."

The first man pushed himself upright, one hand braced against the floor. "You cannot stay here."

Brannoc regarded him.

The man swallowed. "They will burn the room."

"Will they?"

"They will burn the whole—"

He stopped.

Brannoc waited.

The man's eyes darted toward the window, then the door, then the sealed message on the table. He had said too much and understood it now.

"Whole what?" Brannoc asked.

No answer.

Korvath moved to the window and looked down into the rain. "There are more below."

"How many?"

The smuggler's mouth tightened. "Enough."

Brannoc almost laughed. Everyone had discovered the same word tonight.

He picked up the message.

The seal was black, unmarked except for the narrow cut through its center. He broke it with his thumb. Inside was a single line, written in a hand that leaned slightly to the left:

COME BEFORE THE ROAD CLOSES.

No signature. No threat. The absence was more deliberate than either.

The man against the wall watched him read. “You see?”

“I see ink.”

“They are calling you.”

“Who?”

The man’s eyes lifted to Brannoc’s. “The Crown.”

The word did not echo. It did not need to.

Korvath turned from the window.

Brannoc folded the message once, then again, until the paper became a hard little square in his hand. Somewhere beneath his ribs, something long buried shifted—not hope, not fear, but the old animal that had learned to wear both.

At the stairwell, a boot touched the first step.

Then another.

Korvath raised the crossbow toward the door.

Brannoc wrapped the regalia against his chest, felt the hidden weight of the grimoire beneath his coat, and stepped between the men outside and the man who had named the Crown.

The latch began to lift again.

The latch rose.

Korvath’s crossbow creaked as he drew it tighter. The weapon’s limbs shuddered with the strain. Brannoc smelled the old oil on the stock, the sourness of damp wool, and beneath both the mineral cold that climbed through the floorboards.

“Lower it,” Brannoc said.

Korvath did not look at him. “You first.”

The door opened by the width of a hand.

A knife slid through the gap.

Brannoc caught the wrist before the blade could enter. He drove it hard against the jamb. Bone struck wood. The knife dropped, and a breathless curse came from the stairwell. Korvath’s crossbow snapped forward. Its quarrel buried itself in the door above the intruder’s hand.

“Come in,” Brannoc said.

The wrist twisted beneath his grip. Not a soldier’s movement. Too careful. Too practiced. The man on the other side had expected fear, not speed.

Brannoc opened the door.

There were two of them on the landing. The first had a hood drawn low and one hand clasped to his bruised wrist. The second stood behind him with a lantern hooded in black cloth. No colors showed. No badge. Their boots were clean of mud, though the stairwell below was wet.

The first man looked past Brannoc to the folded paper in his fist.

“The regalia,” he said.

Korvath shifted behind him. “You’ve got a talent for making a room smaller.”

“The Crown requires both.”

Brannoc felt the hidden weight beneath his coat answer the words—not with heat, but with pressure. The grimoire pressed against his ribs as though some blind thing within it had turned in sleep.

“The Crown requires,” Brannoc said, “or the Bleeding Crown requires?”

The hooded man’s face remained shadowed. “There is a difference only to those who survive long enough to argue it.”

Brannoc smiled without humor. “Then you have come to the wrong room.”

He shoved the man back. Not far. Just enough to make the stair rail groan. The second stranger lifted the lantern, and its dim light passed across the floorboards, the cracked basin, Korvath’s crossbow, and the red stains dried into Brannoc’s knuckles.

The stranger paused there.

“The Red-Handed,” he murmured.

Brannoc hated the name most when spoken softly.

It had followed him through burned villages and lordly halls, across contracts sealed in blood and contracts broken for less. Some called it praise. Some called it warning. The truth was uglier. Hands remembered what the mind learned to bury.

“Say my name,” Brannoc said.

The hooded man did.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

The room seemed to draw inward.

Korvath moved first. He stepped toward the lantern-bearer, but Brannoc raised one hand. The smuggler stopped, though his eyes remained fixed on the stranger’s throat.

“Who sent you?” Brannoc asked.

“The Bleeding Crown.”

“Names.”

“No.”

Brannoc seized the stranger by the front of his coat and dragged him over the threshold. The man’s shoulder struck the wall. Dust fell from the beam overhead.

“Names,” Brannoc repeated.

The stranger’s breath rasped. “You were not called to bargain.”

“No,” Brannoc said. “I was called because someone has run out of men willing to die in his place.”

The lantern-bearer shut the door behind them. His hand never left the hilt at his belt.

For one moment, no one spoke. Rain whispered against the window. Somewhere below, the house groaned in its foundations.

Then the lantern-bearer said, "You mistake the shape of your inheritance."

Brannoc's fingers tightened.

There it was. Not the Crown, not the summons. The word behind both.

Inheritance.

Korvath's gaze flicked toward him. Brannoc felt the question arrive and die unasked.

The lantern-bearer continued. "You are the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown."

The sentence fell with the weight of a stone dropped into deep water.

Brannoc had heard it in fragments before. In taverns where men drank too quickly. In the mouths of dying captains. In the silence of those who recognized his blood and prayed he had not recognized theirs.

But never spoken plainly in a locked room.

He released the first messenger.

The man stumbled, caught himself, and rubbed his wrist. "There is no shame in what you are."

"Shame?" Brannoc said. "You crossed a wet city with knives to tell me I was born inconvenient."

"You were born dangerous."

"Those are not the same."

"To the Crown, they are."

The name of the Bleeding Crown seemed to stain the air. Brannoc looked down at the folded message. Its wax had cracked beneath his grip. He imagined the hand that had pressed it there, the hand that had written of summons and duty without once writing the word blood.

On the table, Korvath had spread a map.

It showed the shattered realm in ink faded to the color of old bruises. The Ashen Vanguard held its central roads. House Morvain's territories were marked with black thorns. The Silent Choir had no borders at all, only pale circles drawn around places where sound was said to die. The Iron-Ring Cartel had marked its routes in red thread. Beyond them, beneath a crown-shaped blot, lay the territories of the Bleeding Crown.

Five powers contended over the ruins, and every one of them called its hunger necessity.

Korvath tapped the map with one finger. "If they want him moved, they will need a road."

"The road exists," said the first messenger. "Crookvale."

Brannoc leaned over the map.

"Crookvale was founded in 295 AS," the man said. "In The High Spires. It has been rebuilt. Its garrison is 1004. It remains outside the core holdings."

Korvath gave a low, humorless laugh. "A hundred and four ways to be noticed."

“1004,” Brannoc corrected.

The smuggler glanced at him.

Brannoc did not explain. Numbers had teeth. A garrison of 1004 was not a wall; it was a message. Someone wanted the settlement held, watched, and ready.

“Crookvale is not a road,” Brannoc said. “It is a throat.”

“It is the only passage the Crown can trust.”

“No passage trusts anyone.”

The lantern-bearer lifted the black cloth from his lantern. Light spilled over the table. Beneath the map, another sheet had been folded into quarters. He opened it carefully.

“Fenspire,” he said.

The name drew Brannoc’s attention.

“Fenspire stands in the Gloaming Reach. It was founded in 57 AS. It is a core location, garrisoned, with a garrison of 3,742.”

Korvath’s face hardened. “That is not a passage.”

“It is a destination.”

“No.” Brannoc studied the marks on the paper. “It is a cage with a spire above it.”

“Every fortress is a cage.”

“Only if you are inside.”

The lantern-bearer’s eyes lifted toward him. “The Bleeding Crown wants you in Fenspire.”

Brannoc looked again at the map. A thin line ran from Crookvale toward the Reach, then vanished beneath a smear of black ink. No route was drawn onward.

He touched the hidden grimoire through his coat.

The Edge of Gloamreach had come into his possession without a history. Its leather smelled of dust, smoke, and something colder. Its attunement cost was 46, a number written in the margin by a hand that had left no name. He had not opened it since the message arrived. He had feared the book less than what it might show him.

Now the fear moved.

“Why?” Korvath asked.

The first messenger flexed his injured wrist. “Because the regalia recognizes you.”

Brannoc felt the folded thing against his chest.

The Thrice-Bound Edge.

Regalia forged in 123 AS. Its record contained no attunement cost. It had lain silent beneath his coat until the messenger spoke of the Crown. Now its presence seemed deliberate, restrained, as if three unseen bindings had drawn taut around his heart.

“Recognizes me as what?” Brannoc asked.

Neither messenger answered.

Brannoc drew the regalia free.

It was not bright. Nothing in the Ashen Era had earned the right to brightness. Its surface held the color of old iron beneath ash, its edges severe and unadorned. The room’s lantern flame bent toward it.

Korvath swore.

The first messenger took one step back.

Brannoc noticed. Fear had a posture. This was not fear of the weapon. It was fear of what the weapon might confirm.

He broke the folded wrapping.

The instant his fingers touched The Thrice-Bound Edge, the grimoire beneath his coat opened by itself.

Pages scraped against cloth.

A cold wind moved through the room, though the window was shut. The lantern guttered. Ink bled across the nearest page, gathering into a dark pool. Brannoc pulled Edge of Gloamreach free and let it fall open on the table.

The page showed no words at first.

Then a year surfaced.

297 AS.

The ink spread into a crown split down the center. Beneath it, another line appeared.

The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS.

Brannoc stared.

A second year burned into the paper.

300 AS.

The letters that followed were cramped, almost frantic.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed died in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone.

His breath stopped.

The room returned in pieces: Korvath’s hand near the crossbow, the strangers frozen beside the door, the rain threading the dark glass. His own name remained on the page, colder than any epitaph.

He read the next line.

301 AS.

The Accord of Mournthrone ended in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.

The lantern flame rose sharply. Shadows climbed the walls.

More writing crawled from the margin.

Its collapse unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals.

Below that, the final sentence formed.

The losing commander was bribed to withdraw.

No one moved.

Korvath came around the table. "What does it say?"

Brannoc shut the book.

The cover resisted him.

He pressed harder. The leather buckled beneath his palm, and the letters of its title seemed to deepen: Edge of Gloamreach.

"What does it say?" Korvath asked again.

"That the future has poor manners."

The first messenger's face had gone pale beneath the hood. "You opened it."

"I noticed."

"You were not meant to—"

Brannoc struck him across the mouth.

The man hit the wall. The lantern-bearer drew his sword, but Korvath's crossbow rose with it, the quarrel aimed at his eye.

Brannoc placed The Thrice-Bound Edge on the map.

Every mark trembled.

Far away—or beneath the floor, or inside his blood—something answered.

The regalia's three bindings tightened around nothing visible. The map's ink began to run from the borders of Fenspire toward Crookvale, from Crookvale toward the black crown.

The Bleeding Crown.

Brannoc heard, beneath the rain, the slow drag of a blade being drawn.

The hooded messenger wiped blood from his lip. "If you refuse, the Crown will come for you."

Brannoc looked at the page where his death remained written.

"Let it come."

The door behind them clicked.

Not from the latch.

From the other side.

Korvath turned. The crossbow wavered for the first time.

A voice spoke through the wood.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

The same voice that had called him before.

Only now it was closer.

And the grimoire opened again.

Chapter 6

Fenspire rose through the mist like a black nail driven into the mountain.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed watched it from the lower road while rain silvered the ash beneath his boots. The tower had no beauty in it. Beauty belonged to things that expected to survive. Fenspire had been built to endure being hated.

A banner hung above the gate, sodden and dark. Its device was lost in the weather, but the men beneath it were plain enough: helms, hooked spears, crossbows held beneath oilskin. The garrison numbered 3,742, and every one of them seemed to know that the Reach was waiting for a weakness.

“Fenspire was founded in 57 AS,” Korvath Nightbrook said beside him.

Brannoc did not look at the smuggler. “You say that as if the stone remembers.”

“Stone remembers better than men.”

“Stone has no tongue.”

“It has cracks.”

Korvath’s voice was soft, almost swallowed by the rain. He dressed in the color of wet soot, without badge or ornament, and kept his hands hidden beneath his cloak. A face made for forgetting. The sort of face a guard saw, searched, and lost before the next bell.

Brannoc had trusted such men before. He had buried more than one.

The road climbed toward the gate. Behind them, the Gloaming Reach dissolved into gray folds of heather and black water. Ahead, Fenspire’s walls were wet as old bone. The tower rose within them, narrow and severe, its upper windows glowing with the weak amber of watchfires. No smoke drifted from the chimneys. The wind pressed it flat and sent it crawling along the battlements.

Brannoc’s gloved hand rested on the pommel of his sword. The leather was stiff with rain. Beneath the glove, the old color of his hand had been washed clean, but the name remained.

The Red-Handed.

Names did not need blood to keep their shape.

“Are you afraid?” Korvath asked.

Brannoc glanced at him then. “Of Fenspire?”

“Of what waits inside it.”

“That depends what waits.”

Korvath’s mouth twitched. It might have been a smile, though there was no warmth in it. “The Bleeding Crown waits everywhere.”

The words entered Brannoc like a cold blade slipped between ribs.

He looked again at the tower.

His crown. His inheritance. His shame.

The claim had never been proclaimed before a court, never carried in a sealed writ, never blessed by a priest of any power. It lived in whispers and bloodlines and the careful silences of those who had known his mother. It lived in the way certain old soldiers watched him when they thought he was not watching back. Unacknowledged did not mean unreal. A bastard could be denied. A blade could not be denied once it had opened the body.

“Do not speak that name here,” Brannoc said.

“Which name?”

“You know which.”

Korvath’s gaze slid toward the gatehouse. “The one that makes men kneel?”

“The one that makes men kill.”

A bell sounded above them.

Not loud. Not urgent. One measured toll, then another.

The gatehouse stirred. Shutters opened in the walls. Crossbows tilted downward.

Brannoc felt the soldiers’ attention pass over him, weighing sword, cloak, posture, the expensive restraint of his equipment. A Sellsword Captain was never merely a man at a gate. He was a question with steel at his hip. Who had bought him? Who had failed to? How long until his loyalty became a debt?

Korvath stepped forward.

“Hold,” called a voice from above.

Brannoc saw no face, only the dark slit beneath the parapet.

“Names.”

“Korvath Nightbrook.”

The pause that followed was brief but deliberate.

“And the other?”

Brannoc could have given a false name. It might have bought him an hour, perhaps a night. But false names were like false coin: useful only where no one cared to test them.

“Brannoc Ironmere.”

The gatehouse went still.

Rain ticked against his shoulder plates. Somewhere beyond the walls, a dog began to bark, then stopped as though struck.

“And the epithet?” the voice asked.

Brannoc’s jaw tightened.

Korvath turned his head a fraction. “They know you.”

“They know a story.”

“The story has teeth.”

“Open the gate,” Brannoc called.

“State your business.”

“To see someone.”

“Who?”

Brannoc looked at the black slit overhead. “If I knew that, I would not be here.”

That earned him movement. Men shifted along the wall. Metal scraped against stone.

Korvath leaned close enough that Brannoc smelled rainwater and bitter root on his breath. “You were meant to say you carried a message.”

“I carry no message.”

“You carry a war.”

“I carry myself.”

“That may be worse.”

The gate opened a handspan, then stopped. A man in a hooded mantle appeared in the gap. He held no visible weapon, which meant there were weapons close enough to reach them. His face was narrow and bloodless, his eyes fixed on Brannoc with the exhausted hatred of someone examining a familiar wound.

“You are expected,” he said.

Brannoc felt the muscles across his back draw tight. “By whom?”

The man’s eyes moved to Korvath. “Not by you.”

“Then open the gate.”

“You cannot enter armed.”

Brannoc almost laughed. The sound would have been ugly.

“I am a Sellsword Captain.”

“You are Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

“That is what I said.”

“And you were born in 255 AS.”

The rain seemed to thin around him.

He had heard the year spoken in ledgers, in curses, in the mouths of men who had counted his life against the shape of a prophecy. To hear it from this stranger made it feel less like a birth and more like a sentence.

Korvath’s hand emerged from his cloak. Not a weapon. A small iron token rested between his fingers, its surface blackened by use.

The gatekeeper saw it.

His expression changed.

Brannoc noticed. "What is that?"

"Something you were not meant to see," Korvath said.

"You have made a habit of that."

"I survive by habits."

The gatekeeper reached through the gap and took the token. His thumb passed over its face. For the first time, something like fear showed in his features.

"Give up your sword," he said.

"No."

"Then remain outside."

Brannoc looked beyond him, through the narrow opening. Fenspire's inner court lay drowned in rain. Figures crossed it beneath cloaks. At the far end, a stair climbed toward the tower. On the top landing stood a woman in a pale veil, motionless beneath the eaves.

He could not see her face.

He knew she was watching him.

"Who is that?" he asked.

The gatekeeper did not turn. "You were expected by her."

"Her name."

No answer.

The woman lifted one hand.

The gesture was small. The gatekeeper bowed his head.

Brannoc hated her immediately.

Not for the mystery. Mystery was a currency, and he had spent much of his life among debtors. He hated the ease of the command. The assumption that the world would move when she moved.

He had seen that assumption before in the courts of the Bleeding Crown, where men wore red beneath their collars and called obedience peace.

The gate opened wider.

"Your sword," said the gatekeeper.

Brannoc drew it halfway. Rain ran down the blade in a black line. The weapon had no grand name, no forged history fit for a song. It was steel made honest by use. He held it out hilt first.

The gatekeeper reached for it.

Brannoc did not release it.

For a moment the two of them stood joined by the sword, the rain beating between their hands.

"If this is an ambush," Brannoc said, "you will need more than a wall."

The gatekeeper met his eyes. "If this were an ambush, you would already be dead."

"Then you have failed to impress me."

"Not yet."

Brannoc let go.

The man took the sword and stepped aside. Korvath passed through first, his shoulders hunched, his face emptied of interest. Brannoc followed.

Fenspire smelled of wet iron, boiled grain, and old ash. The stones beneath his boots sloped toward channels cut in the courtyard, where rainwater ran red-brown from the walls. Soldiers watched from covered walks. Their faces were young in some places and ancient in others. Every man carried the same narrow stillness, the patience of those who had been taught that danger announced itself only after it arrived.

Brannoc counted the exits without meaning to.

One gate behind him. Two covered passages. A stair to the battlements. The tower entrance guarded by four men who pretended not to guard it.

His hand felt wrong without the sword.

The Thrice-Bound Edge lay somewhere inside the tower, if the whispers had not lied. Regalia forged in 123 AS, bearing a name that sounded less like a weapon than a sentence imposed upon one. No record named an attunement cost. That absence troubled Brannoc more than any price could have. Everything that bound a man asked payment. If the record was silent, perhaps the payment had been hidden.

Korvath glanced back. "You are staring."

"At the tower."

"You should stare at the people."

"I know what people do."

"And the tower?"

"It has not yet lied to me."

They reached the foot of the stair. The veiled woman waited above them.

Up close, she seemed neither old nor young. The pale cloth concealed everything but the shape of her mouth. Rain whispered from the eaves. Behind her, the doorway stood open upon darkness.

"You came late," she said.

Brannoc looked toward the sky, though no light showed through the cloud. "You gave no hour."

"I gave a summons."

"I received a rumor."

"Rumors travel farther."

"Then your message was poorly made."

The mouth beneath the veil curved. "You speak like a man who believes he has choices."

“I speak like a man who has survived without your permission.”

Something moved behind the doorway.

Not a soldier. Something quieter. A dry rustle, like pages shifting in a sealed room.

Korvath’s posture changed.

Brannoc noticed. “What is inside?”

The veiled woman ignored him. “The Accord of Mournthrone is not finished.”

“It ended.”

“It ended for those who signed it.”

“The Ashen Vanguard named itself victor.”

“Named itself,” she said. “There is a difference.”

The words struck close to truths Brannoc had kept buried beneath campaigns, coin, and drink. The Accord of Mournthrone had begun in 297 AS and ended in 301 AS, but endings were courtly things. Men declared them while soldiers still bled in ravines. A victory could be purchased as easily as a withdrawal. A commander could be bribed, and a host could vanish from the field beneath the respectable cloak of strategy.

He had seen enough of war to know that banners lied better than men.

“What do you want from me?” he asked.

The woman turned toward the dark doorway. “What you were denied.”

His breath caught before he could stop it.

Korvath said, “Do not.”

The woman looked down at him. “You brought him here.”

“I brought a blade.”

“You brought the heir.”

The courtyard seemed to contract around them.

Brannoc heard the soldiers breathing. Heard rain dripping from the tower stones. Heard, from somewhere below, the faint scrape of his confiscated sword being carried away.

He climbed one step.

The woman did not move.

“The Bleeding Crown has no heir,” he said.

“Then why did you come?”

“I came for an answer.”

“No. You came because a part of you still believes blood can make a door open.”

The darkness behind her stirred again.

A smell spilled from it—dust, bitter herbs, and something colder, touched by twilight. On a table within, half-seen beneath a cloth, lay a broad black volume bound in material that seemed to drink the candlelight.

The Edge of Gloamreach.

Brannoc had heard of the grimoire in campfires and sealed rooms. Its attunement cost was 46. He had never believed the number mattered until he saw the book waiting in the dark, its spine marked by a thin seam of gray light.

The veiled woman descended one step toward him.

“Take off your glove,” she said.

Brannoc’s bare fingers flexed beneath the leather.

“No.”

“Your hand has been named.”

“My hand has been wounded.”

“By whom?”

He thought of old steel, old treachery, old oaths spoken over cups that tasted of ash. He thought of the crown he had never worn and the men who would rather see it burned than see it rest on his head.

The woman reached for him.

Brannoc seized her wrist.

Every soldier in the courtyard raised a weapon.

Korvath whispered, “Brannoc.”

The woman did not struggle. Beneath the veil, she smiled again.

From the open doorway, the black grimoire opened by itself.

And somewhere inside Fenspire, the bell began to toll.

The woman’s wrist was cold beneath his grip.

Not cold as skin went cold in winter, nor as a corpse cooled beneath a shroud. The chill of her ran inward, a thin, deliberate current that entered through his palm and climbed his arm. His wounded hand answered with a pulse of pain.

The soldiers’ weapons remained raised.

Korvath stood three paces away, his face gone narrow and bloodless. He had the look of a man who had found a door in a wall and understood, too late, that something on the other side had already opened it.

“Release me,” the woman said.

Her voice had not changed. That was the worst of it. No strain. No fear. No anger. It carried the mild patience of someone waiting for a servant to finish making a mistake.

Brannoc tightened his fingers.

The bell tolled again.

Its sound came down through the stones of Fenspire, vast and black. Dust shivered from the archway. In the courtyard, one of the horses screamed and reared against its tether, showing the wet ruin of its mouth. No one moved to calm it.

The grimoire's pages turned.

They did not flutter. They turned with purpose, one after another, their edges scraping together like small knives being drawn. The book lay open on the flagstones inside the doorway, untouched by wind. Its cover was blacker than the shadows around it, its shape severe and old.

"Edge of Gloamreach," Korvath whispered.

The name passed through Brannoc like a hook.

The woman's gloved hand rose. The fingers of it touched the back of his bare wrist. He felt the pressure through the scarred flesh, and beneath that pressure something searching, patient as a root beneath stone.

"Take your hand from me," she said.

"Tell them to lower their weapons."

"They will not."

"Then they may keep them raised until their arms rot."

A soldier shifted near the well. Brannoc heard the leather of his grip creak. He did not look at him. Every man in the courtyard had become a line of force, a bowstring drawn to the point where courage and terror were indistinguishable.

Korvath said, "Brannoc, the book is speaking."

"No book speaks."

From the doorway came a sound like a breath dragged through a dead throat.

The pages stopped.

Ink gathered upon the open leaf. It rose from the fibers in black beads, joined itself into strokes, and began to write.

Brannoc could not read it from where he stood. He saw only the movement: the crawling script, the cramped columns, the sudden blackening of the page. Then the letters brightened—not with light, but with the pallor of old bone.

The woman watched him watching the book.

"You know what it wants."

"I know what books want. To be burned."

"Not this one."

"Especially this one."

A faint smile touched her mouth beneath the veil. "You mistake being named for being chosen."

The words found something soft beneath his ribs.

He had lived among men who spoke of names as if names were chains. Sellswords gave false ones at gates, kept true ones from taxmen, and died beneath names borrowed from better men. His own had been carried across battlefields in whispers, scraped from contracts, muttered over cups. Brannoc. Ironmere. The Red-Handed.

A name could buy a blade.

A name could open a grave.

The grimoire turned another page.

This time the writing was large enough for him to see.

BRANNOC IRONMERE THE RED-HANDED

The letters stood alone at the top.

His hand opened.

The woman's wrist slipped half an inch in his grasp, but he caught it again. The soldiers raised a collective breath. Somewhere behind him, a buckle clicked.

Below his name, the ink continued to form.

BORN IN 255 AS.

His jaw locked.

The courtyard seemed to recede. The wall, the soldiers, the doorway, the woman—all of it drew away beneath the bell's tolling, leaving only the page and the black strokes that crawled over it.

He had never told the men here when he was born. He had never told most men anywhere. Birth was a weakness if it could be counted, a measure by which another man might decide how long one had left to be useful.

The grimoire wrote on.

DIED IN 300 AS.

The next bell-strike did not come.

Silence fell so completely that Brannoc heard the horse breathing through its nose. He heard the scrape of his own thumb against the woman's glove. He heard the blood working inside his wounded hand.

For one instant, the line refused meaning.

Then it entered him.

Not as fear. Fear was clean. Fear had a blade's edge and a direction. This was heavier. It was the sensation of standing in a room where everyone had already mourned him and no one had thought to tell him.

His eyes went to the woman.

She did not look surprised.

"You knew."

"I had read the page."

“And you brought me here to show it.”

“I brought you here because the page was sealed.”

“By whom?”

Her silence was answer enough to make the soldiers uneasy.

Korvath took one step toward them. “What does it say?”

Brannoc turned his head.

The smuggler stared at the grimoire as though it were a hungry animal. His guarded manner had broken apart, revealing the old caution beneath: not the caution of a coward, but of a man who survived by knowing when not to be present.

“It says my name,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s eyes flicked to the woman. “That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you’re getting.”

The woman’s fingers moved beneath his grip.

Brannoc felt a hard object press into his palm. A sliver of metal, thin and cold. He glanced down.

The thing was no larger than a fingernail, dark at its center and pale along one edge. It had not been there before. He had felt no motion, seen no trick of hand.

Her voice lowered.

“Give it to the book.”

“Why?”

“Because it has remembered you.”

“Books remember nothing.”

“Then let it forget.”

The shard bit him.

His blood welled around it, bright against the black metal. The old wound in his hand opened with a wet sting. A drop fell to the flagstones.

The grimoire answered.

Every page lifted at once.

A wind burst from the doorway, though the courtyard air remained still. It struck Brannoc in the chest and drove the smell of dust, iron, and distant rain into his lungs. The soldiers cried out. One loosed his weapon; the bolt struck stone and spun away. Another dropped to one knee.

The woman did not move.

The black leaves of Edge of Gloamreach turned in a single roaring wave. The ink on the open page spread outward, consuming the words. His name dissolved. The line beneath it remained.

DIED IN 300 AS.

The letters began to drip.

Brannoc's wounded hand burned. He looked at the shard. It had sunk beneath his skin, not deep, but deep enough that the edges had vanished. Black veins traced outward from it, fine as cracks in ice.

He tried to pull it free.

Pain flashed white.

The woman caught his hand.

"Do not."

He nearly struck her. The impulse came up through him swift and trained, the old answer to restraint. He stopped only because the soldiers would fire, and because her grip had become impossibly strong.

"Take it out."

"If you tear it loose, the book will open the rest."

"The rest of what?"

She leaned close. Her veil smelled faintly of soot.

"The part that tells you who kills you."

For the first time, her calm broke.

Not much. A tremor touched the final word. But Brannoc heard it.

He studied her covered face. "You're afraid."

"I am careful."

"Same disease, different coat."

The book slammed shut.

The force of it struck the doorway. Black sparks crawled along the threshold and vanished into the stone. The soldiers flinched as one. Korvath swore under his breath and reached inside his coat.

Brannoc saw the motion.

"Don't," he said.

Korvath's hand stopped.

"You brought that thing here," Brannoc said.

"I carried it."

"That is not the same defense."

"I was told it had to reach Fenspire."

"By whom?"

Korvath looked at the woman.

There it was again: the silence, the refusal, the shape of an allegiance neither of them would name.

Brannoc turned his grip until the woman's wrist bent. She made no sound, but her shoulder tightened.

"Who sent you?"

"No one."

"Everyone is sent by someone."

"Not the dead."

His hand stilled.

The courtyard darkened though the sky above the walls had not changed. A shadow passed over the stones, too broad to belong to any bird. The black grimoire trembled once inside the doorway.

The woman said, "You have very little time."

"For what?"

"To decide whether you want to die as yourself."

A bitter laugh scraped out of him. "The book has already decided."

"The book has written a fact."

"Facts can be altered."

"Not all."

He looked again at the page visible between the grimoire's covers. The ink had soaked through, staining the leather beneath. His name was gone, but he could still see the pressure of the letters in the paper, the grooves left by whatever hand—or thing—had written them.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed died in 300 AS.

The sentence settled inside him with the weight of a stone dropped into deep water.

He saw no battlefield. No assassin. No grave. The book had given him no face to hate, no weapon to avoid, no path by which a man might cheat the dark. Only the date. Only the certainty.

He had spent his life refusing other men's endings.

The woman's wrist was still in his grasp.

"Why show me this?" he asked.

"You asked to know who had named your hand."

"And?"

"I did not say the name came from the living."

The bell began to toll again.

This time it rang from beneath them.

The stones under Brannoc's boots shuddered. A seam opened between the flagstones, a black line widening toward the doorway. The soldiers broke formation. Some shouted for the gates; others backed into one another, weapons wavering. Korvath drew the thing from his coat at last—not a blade, not any weapon Brannoc recognized, but a small iron ring held between two fingers.

The woman tore her wrist free.

Brannoc caught only the edge of her glove.

She stepped backward toward the open doorway.

“Wait.”

The word left him before pride could stop it.

Her veiled head tilted.

He hated her for hearing the plea inside it.

“Come with me,” she said.

Behind her, Edge of Gloamreach opened once more.

A hand rose from between its pages. It was made of ink, thin and jointed, and it reached across the threshold toward Brannoc.

The ink hand touched his palm.

Cold entered him without breaking the skin. It was not the cold of winter, nor of steel left beneath rain. It was the absence of warmth—the place where warmth had been scraped away. His fingers opened against his will.

The hand folded itself around them.

Brannoc struck at the wrist with his free hand. His blow passed through blackness and found the edge of the doorway. Pain flashed up his arm. The soldiers nearest him cried out as though he had struck them instead. One loosed an arrow. It vanished into the open grimoire with a wet, sucking sound.

The woman did not flinch.

“Come with me,” she said again.

“What is on the other side?”

“An answer.”

He looked past her veil.

There was no corridor beyond the door. No chamber, no stair, no sky. The pages of Edge of Gloamreach had opened upon a depth that refused shape. Pale ash drifted through it, rising instead of falling. Far away, something vast moved behind a membrane of darkness, its passage bending the dimness as wind bent long grass.

Brannoc had lived among men who sold certainty by the measure. Priests sold it in white halls. Captains sold it over maps. Kings sold it with wax seals pressed into blood. He had learned to distrust any answer that did not come with a price.

The hand tightened.

His knees nearly gave.

Korvath Nightbrook was staring at him. The smuggler’s face had gone slack, all its guarded slyness burned away. In his fingers, the little iron ring looked dull and harmless. Brannoc knew better now. It had

the stillness of a shut eye.

“Do not take another step,” Korvath said.

The woman’s head turned by a fraction. “You brought him here.”

“I brought you the book.”

“You brought the door.”

“I brought what I was paid to bring.”

“Then be paid.”

Korvath’s mouth tightened. “That was not the bargain.”

The soldiers heard the exchange, or enough of it to understand that the world had become a marketplace in which they were the merchandise. Their fear changed shape. Fear of the unnatural could still be endured; men had endured it since the Sundering. Fear of being cheated was older, and more immediate.

A spearpoint pushed between the soldiers. It trembled toward the woman’s veiled face.

“Shut the book,” its owner said.

The ink hand pulled Brannoc forward.

He caught the spearshaft before it reached her. His grip closed. Wood groaned.

“Lower it.”

The soldier looked at him, bewildered. “Captain—”

“Lower it.”

The spear dipped. Brannoc shoved it aside, and the man stumbled against his fellows.

The woman watched him. Though her face was hidden, he felt her attention settle on the place beneath his ribs where old secrets had grown teeth.

“You have already chosen,” she said.

“I chose not to watch a frightened boy die for the sake of your pride.”

The soldier was not a boy. Brannoc knew that. He had seen the man’s beard, his scars, the hard calluses where a weapon had been carried too long. But terror stripped years from the face. It made every soldier young.

“And what do you call the choice you made before that?” she asked.

He said nothing.

The room smelled of singed wool, iron, and the bitter mineral scent rising from the pages. His coat dragged against the threshold. Beneath it, his heart beat with the brutal steadiness of a marching drum.

He had spent his life walking toward doors other men barred against him.

The Bleeding Crown had never acknowledged him. Its silence had been more elaborate than denial. There were seals that opened for him and mouths that closed when he entered. There were old hands that lingered too long over his face, searching for a resemblance no one dared name. He had learned the shape

of his inheritance through absences.

Now the doorway offered him no crown, no army, no proclamation. Only darkness wearing the manners of invitation.

The ink hand crawled higher.

Black fingers crossed his wrist. They left no stain, but he felt words forming under his skin, each letter a small, deliberate wound.

Korvath stepped nearer. "Brannoc."

It was the first time the smuggler had spoken his name.

The soldiers heard it. Their eyes shifted toward him. Some had known. Some had guessed. Others understood only that Korvath Nightbrook had addressed a Sellsword Captain without title, and that the name itself seemed to have disturbed the air.

Brannoc did not look away from the doorway.

"How do you know me?"

Korvath swallowed. "I know what people pay to move."

"People?"

"Secrets."

"Mine?"

"Yours are too heavy for one man."

A laugh came from somewhere in the formation. It died at once.

The woman lifted her hand. The iron ring in Korvath's grasp answered with a faint chime. Not metal striking metal. Something more distant, like a bell heard beneath deep water.

The doorway widened.

The edges of Edge of Gloamreach darkened. Its pages flexed, their corners lifting as though the book breathed. The threshold drew the room toward itself. Loose ash skittered over the floor. A dropped knife slid across the stones and disappeared into the dark.

Brannoc planted his boots.

For a moment, he held.

Then the hand beneath his skin pulled.

He had been wounded by men with axes, hooked blades, sharpened farm tools. He had been stitched in darkness and cauterized by fire. Pain had always been a thing with a border. It entered, it raged, it passed.

This had no border.

The letters under his skin were moving toward his elbow.

"What happens if I refuse?" he asked.

"Your body remains," said the woman.

“And the rest?”

She did not answer.

That was answer enough.

Brannoc looked back at the room. The soldiers stood in a broken ring, their weapons lowered but not abandoned. They were waiting for him to make the kind of decision men could obey. They wanted him to become solid again—to give an order, name an enemy, place himself between danger and those paid to follow him.

He had done that all his life.

The Ashen Vanguard would have called it duty. House Morvain would have called it leverage. The Silent Choir would have called it a vow. The Iron-Ring Cartel would have measured it and sent an invoice.

The Bleeding Crown would have called it nothing.

Brannoc’s gaze found Korvath.

“You knew this would happen.”

“No.”

“You knew enough to fear it.”

“Yes.”

“And you brought me anyway.”

Korvath glanced at the ring. His fingers had begun to bleed where its edge bit into them. “I was told the book would open for a man with a claim.”

“What claim?”

The smuggler’s eyes moved to Brannoc’s hand.

The hand of ink had reached his forearm.

The soldiers shifted. A murmur ran through them, low and ugly.

Brannoc felt the old heat stir in his blood. Not magic. Not anything so clean. Anger, perhaps. Shame. The instinct to kill the nearest witness before the truth could find a tongue.

He had never told Korvath the truth.

Few had been allowed close enough to hear it.

The woman said, “You may leave him here.”

Korvath’s jaw worked. “That was not the bargain.”

“You have said that.”

“And I mean it.”

Something moved in the depth beyond the doorway. The vast shape turned. For an instant, Brannoc saw a pale curve that might have been a face or the underside of a wing. He saw hollows where eyes could have been. He saw a crown—not worn, but embedded in the thing’s darkness like a wound that had forgotten

how to close.

His breath stopped.

The Bleeding Crown was not there. He knew that. The crown was stone, blood, history, a power contended over by hands that had forgotten what it meant to rule. Yet the shape beyond the pages had summoned it from him, and that was worse than seeing any relic.

The woman took his hand.

Her glove was warm.

The warmth broke him.

Brannoc surged backward, wrenching against the ink hand. The threshold screamed—not loudly, but inwardly, through his teeth and behind his eyes. Every soldier in the room dropped to one knee. The book slammed its pages together around the doorway, then opened again with Brannoc half-drawn across the sill.

Korvath shouted something.

Brannoc did not hear it.

He struck the stone with his shoulder. His fingers clawed at the floor. Blackness streamed between the cracks beneath his nails. The letters in his arm flared, and for an instant the words became clear.

Not his name.

Not any name.

A command.

He read it, and the reading entered him like a hook.

The woman leaned close. Through the veil, he smelled smoke and crushed leaves.

“If you cross,” she whispered, “you will learn why they hid you.”

“Who hid me?”

Her silence returned.

Behind him, Korvath made a choked sound.

Brannoc turned his head.

The smuggler had dropped the iron ring. It lay on the floor, upright now, spinning without motion. Within its hollow was not the stone beneath it but a narrow glimpse of red light, pulsing in time with Brannoc’s heart.

The soldiers were no longer watching the woman.

They were watching him.

His hand had become ink to the elbow.

There would be no returning to the room as the man who had entered it. Perhaps that was the answer she had offered. Perhaps every door was merely a mouth waiting for the traveler to understand he had already been swallowed.

Brannoc fixed his stare on Korvath.

“If I go,” he said, fighting for breath, “close the book.”

Korvath stared at him.

“Do you hear me?”

“I hear you.”

“Close it when I tell you.”

“And if you do not tell me?”

Brannoc looked into the depth beyond the threshold, into the ash that rose and the shape that waited without impatience.

“Then decide what kind of coward you are.”

Korvath flinched as though struck.

The woman pulled.

Brannoc’s shoulder crossed the threshold. The darkness took him to the bone. He tasted old blood. Somewhere far behind him, men began to pray—not to the Silent Choir, not to any power they could name, but to the simple mercy of remaining themselves.

The woman’s hand closed around his.

This time, he did not resist.

The pages of Edge of Gloamreach rose on either side of him like black wings.

And from the room beyond, Korvath whispered, “Brannoc, that is not the book’s other side.”

The doorway began to close.

Chapter 7

Rain worried the shutters of the tower as though it had been sent to pry them loose.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed stood with one hand on the table and watched the black water slide down the narrow glass. Beyond it, Crookvale crouched beneath the weather, rebuilt stone shouldering against the dark. Its roofs had been laid in uneven tiers, its walls repaired in colors that did not belong together. Survival had made the place ugly. Survival had made it stubborn.

A lamp guttered behind him.

“Say it again,” Brannoc said.

The man at the table swallowed. “The offer is sealed.”

“Offers are sealed when they are buried.”

“The Iron-Ring Cartel will provide coin.”

“Coin for what?”

The man’s mouth tightened. He wore no colors. That was a color of its own.

Brannoc lifted his hand from the table. The knuckles were scarred, the skin darkened by old blood that no soap had persuaded to leave. He had not earned the name Red-Handed by killing one man, or ten. Names grew in the mouths of others, fed by fear and repetition. They had called him captain before they called him dangerous. They had called him dangerous before they called him heir.

The last name had never been spoken in a room with a locked door.

“Coin,” Brannoc said, “for what?”

“For the withdrawal.”

The rain hissed in the chimney.

Somewhere below, a guard laughed too loudly, then stopped. Brannoc imagined the man touching the hilt of his weapon afterward, embarrassed by the sound he had made. In Crookvale, even laughter had to prove it belonged there.

“The Ashen Vanguard has already named itself victor,” said the courier. “The Accord of Mournthrone is finished in all but language.”

“Finished?”

“The Accord began in 297 AS. It ends in 301 AS.”

“Then it has not ended.”

The courier glanced toward the shutters. “It will.”

Brannoc leaned closer. The man smelled of wet wool, lamp oil, and the sour fear of someone carrying a message that could outlive him.

“Who paid you to tell me this?”

“No one.”

“That is a poor answer.”

“It is the true one.”

“Truth is not improved by being poor.”

The courier’s fingers pressed flat against the table. “The losing commander was bribed to withdraw.”

There it was. Not a rumor, then. Not merely the kind of rot that rose from a battlefield when too many dead men lay under too little earth. The words entered the room and found a place to sit.

Brannoc looked again through the rain-blinded glass.

The Ashen Vanguard. House Morvain. The Silent Choir. The Iron-Ring Cartel. The Bleeding Crown.

Five powers, each pretending the realm could be stitched without reopening the wound. Five hands reaching into the same ash, each certain the cinder that burned belonged to it.

“And you expect me to believe the Cartel is buying a victory already won?”

“The Cartel is buying what comes after.”

“After the accord?”

“After the name.”

Brannoc’s thumb rubbed the edge of the table. The wood had been planed smooth, but one splinter remained. He worried it until it pierced the callus.

The decade of guerrilla reprisals had not yet begun. He knew that because the roads still carried wagons, because men still wore uniforms instead of hiding their faces, because a messenger could enter a tower and speak of withdrawal without having his tongue cut out for bringing the word. Yet he could feel the future crouched beneath the floorboards.

“Where is the commander?” Brannoc asked.

The courier’s eyes hardened. “I was not told.”

“Was he bought before the battle or after?”

“I was not told.”

“You have been told very little.”

“I have been told enough to keep breathing.”

Brannoc smiled without warmth. “That is a skill. Not a virtue.”

The courier looked at his hand. “They say you are the Bleeding Crown’s heir.”

“They say many things.”

“They say unacknowledged.”

“Then they have heard the word correctly.”

The man flinched, almost imperceptibly. There were people who feared the Crown, and people who feared what might claim it once the Crown began to bleed. Brannoc had spent his life among both kinds. Born in 255 AS, he had learned early that blood could be a door, a chain, or a blade held to the throat. His had

been all three.

He turned from the window.

“Leave.”

“The answer?”

“You have not yet made an offer.”

“The Cartel wants—”

“The Cartel wants everything. It is the only prayer merchants know.”

The courier rose, but did not move toward the door. “If you refuse, the Ashen Vanguard will take Crookvale.”

“Crookvale is outside the core holdings.”

“It still has a garrison of 1004.”

“Numbers are not walls.”

“They are men behind walls.”

“Men can be paid.”

“Not all men.”

“No,” Brannoc said. “Some must be frightened.”

The courier’s face went pale.

Brannoc almost pitied him. Almost. Pity was a warm drink, and warm drinks made a man careless. He had watched captains die with their hands wrapped around cups. He had watched lords bargain away villages while discussing the quality of the wine. He had watched men kneel to the Bleeding Crown and rise believing themselves taller.

On a shelf beside the lamp lay a packet of copied records, bound in black thread. Brannoc had not opened it since dusk. The top page had worked loose, exposing a line of cramped script.

The Thrice-Bound Edge was forged in 123 AS.

He touched the page with one finger.

The artifact was named as regalia, though the record offered no attunement cost. Its title had been written three times in three different hands, each one more careful than the last. The Thrice-Bound Edge. A restrained name for something made to bind. A blade, perhaps. A crown. A promise shaped until it could cut.

He had seen men kill for less than a promise.

The courier followed his gaze. “That is not what I came to discuss.”

“No,” Brannoc said. “You came to discuss what men will do when promises fail.”

A low sound rolled through the tower. Not thunder. A horn from the outer wall.

The courier turned sharply.

Brannoc did not.

Another horn answered from the dark.

The room seemed to narrow around them. The lamp flame bent, then steadied. Brannoc reached for the sword at his side, not drawing it, only resting his fingers against the hilt. Steel had its own language. It spoke more plainly than heralds.

“How many?” he asked.

“I don’t know.”

“Then find out.”

The courier moved at last, but Brannoc caught his sleeve.

“If the Cartel has men outside the walls—”

“It does not.”

“You sound certain.”

“I was told there would be no—”

Brannoc twisted the sleeve until the man’s breath broke. “You were told very little.”

The tower door shook beneath a fist.

“Captain!” called a voice from the stairwell.

Brannoc released the courier. “Enter.”

The door opened. A guard stood there, rainwater shining on his shoulders. He was young enough to still believe armor could make a man whole.

“Movement below,” the guard said. “No banners. Three groups at the east road. More in the gullies.”

“Are they attacking?”

“Not yet.”

“Then they are waiting to see whether we are frightened.”

The guard looked at the courier.

Brannoc saw the calculation begin. It was the simplest arithmetic in the realm: one stranger, one secret, one tower threatened. The answer was usually blood.

“Seal the inner gate,” Brannoc said.

“Captain—”

“Do it.”

The guard hesitated. Brannoc let him.

A seasoned sellsword captain needed no crown to command a room. He needed only the willingness to make the first wound.

“Go,” Brannoc said.

The guard went.

The courier stood beneath the open door, listening to boots strike the steps below. “If they are the Ashen Vanguard—”

“They are not.”

“How can you know?”

“Because the Vanguard would have shown its colors.”

“Perhaps they want us to think—”

“Perhaps you want me to think.”

The courier’s fear sharpened into anger. That was better. Anger had edges. Fear only had weight.

Brannoc gathered the copied records and folded them beneath his coat. The page bearing the line about The Thrice-Bound Edge brushed his ribs. Forged in 123 AS. Older than the rebuilt stones. Older than Crookvale. Older than most claims men now called ancient. The knowledge pressed against him like a hidden coin.

Outside, the rain thickened. Its sound filled the pauses between horns.

“Take me with you,” the courier said.

“You are safer here.”

“You mean to leave me.”

“I mean to leave you alive.”

“Then let me go.”

Brannoc looked at him.

The man understood his mistake before Brannoc spoke. A smuggler might have found a way through the gullies. A priest of the Silent Choir might have passed unseen beneath the rain. A servant of House Morvain might have lied with more elegance. But this courier had arrived with a sealed offer and no name behind it. He was not a messenger. He was bait that had learned to walk.

At the far end of the tower, something struck the outer wall.

Dust sifted from the ceiling.

The courier whispered, “They have begun.”

“No,” Brannoc said, drawing his sword.

The blade came free with a soft, intimate sound.

“They have only knocked.”

A second impact shuddered through the stone. The lamp flame rose tall and blue. Below, men shouted. Metal rang against metal. From the eastern wall came the sudden roar of frightened horses, followed by a cry that ended too quickly.

Brannoc stepped toward the stair.

Behind him, the courier said, “If Crookvale falls, the reprisals will spread.”

“They will spread whether it falls or stands.”

“The Accord can still be preserved.”

“The Accord is a word men use when they want corpses to wait politely.”

He descended one step.

The courier moved after him.

Brannoc turned the sword in his hand, letting the lamplight run along its edge. “Stay.”

“I can fight.”

“You can carry a message.”

“To whom?”

Brannoc glanced at the black-windowed dark, at the unseen roads leading toward the High Spires, toward the Gloaming Reach, toward every throne built upon ruin.

“To anyone who still believes the future is something they can purchase.”

He went down.

The stairwell smelled of wet stone and old smoke. Below, the garrison was waking in fragments: buckles drawn tight, boots slipping into iron, curses whispered against the dark. Brannoc passed through them without slowing. Men moved aside because they knew his name, or because they knew his hand, or because they had heard what happened to those who stood between him and a decision.

At the bottom, the inner gate trembled.

A captain in the courtyard shouted for oil.

Brannoc raised his sword.

“Open it.”

The shouting stopped.

Rain streamed through the murder slits. Beyond the gate, shapes moved among the ruins—too many to count, too patient to be raiders. No colors. No torches. The dark itself seemed to have taken positions.

One of the soldiers stared at him. “Captain, the gate—”

“Open it.”

“Those are enemies.”

“Then they have come far enough to meet us.”

The winch groaned. Chains shifted overhead. The gate began to rise, stone grinding against stone, and the rain blew in sideways, cold as a hand laid upon a grave.

Brannoc stepped beneath the lifting arch.

On the road beyond, someone called his name.

Not captain.

Not Red-Handed.

The other name.

The one the Bleeding Crown had never acknowledged.

Brannoc's sword lowered by a fraction as the darkness answered—

The word struck deeper than any challenge.

Brannoc stopped beneath the rising gate. Rain streamed from the ironwork above him and broke against his shoulders, darkening the leather there. Behind him, men shifted along the parapet. He heard the small noises soldiers made when courage was being measured and found wanting: a buckle drawn tight, a thumb testing a blade, breath taken through the teeth.

Again the voice came from the road.

“Unacknowledged heir.”

The soldiers heard it this time.

A murmur passed through them, low and ugly. Someone laughed, but the sound died quickly. Brannoc felt the old wound open beneath his ribs—not pain, precisely. Pain was clean. This was a hand reaching into him and closing around the thing he had spent his life pretending was not there.

He stepped beyond the gate.

The darkness on the road shifted. Figures emerged by degrees, not from concealment but from the rain itself. Cloaks without colors. Faces veiled. Steel held low. They did not advance. That was the first thing that frightened him.

Raiders came hungry.

Assassins came quickly.

These had come to be witnessed.

Behind Brannoc, the gate chains shrieked. “Captain,” one of the soldiers called. “Come back under stone.”

Brannoc kept his sword lowered.

“Tell me who sent you.”

The nearest figure tilted its head. A hood concealed the face, though rain ran from its hem in steady threads. When it spoke, the voice was neither old nor young.

“The one who knows what you are.”

“That knowledge has not improved anyone's life.”

“The Bleeding Crown knows.”

At the name, the men behind him went still.

The Crown had been spoken of in taverns as a curse, in halls as a claim, in battlefields as a promise that never arrived. Brannoc had learned to hear it without turning his head. He had learned to sleep while others whispered of bloodlines and succession. He had learned to let them call him Red-Handed, as though

the epithet had been forged in battle and not hammered over the mouth of a secret.

“The Bleeding Crown has never acknowledged me,” he said.

“No.”

The figure raised a gloved hand.

Something moved behind the line of cloaks. A case was carried forward, narrow and blackened, its surface shining with rain. It was set upon the road between them.

Brannoc’s soldiers muttered. The men who had brought it stepped away.

“Open it,” said the hooded voice.

“Open it yourself.”

“We did not come to touch what waits inside.”

“Then you have brought me a corpse.”

“No.”

Brannoc looked at the case. Its clasps were made of dull metal, each shaped like a closed eye. No crest marked the lid. No wax sealed it. The absence felt deliberate, more threatening than any royal device.

He glanced back at the gate. The arch had risen high enough to admit a mounted man. Beyond it, the fort’s lamps burned weakly through the wet. His men watched him with the naked devotion of those who had mistaken habit for loyalty. They would follow him into a killing ground if he gave the order. They would also remember the order.

“Stay where you are,” he said.

He crossed the road.

The rain softened the world. It blurred the cloaked figures, the gatehouse, the wounded lights. It made a private chamber of the space between him and the case.

His boots struck the lid’s shadow before they struck the case itself.

A scent rose from the road: wet ash, old leather, something bitter beneath. Brannoc crouched. The clasps released under his fingers with a faint click.

Inside lay a book wrapped in oilskin.

Not a weapon. Not a head. Not a letter bearing the seal he had feared since boyhood.

He peeled back the covering.

The binding was gray-black and swollen, its surface marked by lines that seemed to move when the rain touched them. Along the spine, letters had been impressed into the hide.

Edge of Gloamreach.

Brannoc did not touch it.

He had seen the title once before, in a room where men with clean hands debated the value of forbidden things. The grimoire had been described there in voices lowered by greed. Its attunement cost was 46. The number had stayed with him—not because it meant anything to him, but because the men speaking it had

looked afraid of the price.

A soldier behind him whispered, "Captain?"

Brannoc lifted the book from its case.

The cold entered through his gloves.

Not the cold of rain. This was older, a depth without weather. The marks on the cover tightened beneath his palm. Somewhere in the dark, one of the cloaked figures drew breath sharply.

The book opened by itself.

Its pages were pale as old bone, though no script appeared upon them. The blankness pressed against his eyes. Brannoc felt a pull in his wrist, then in his shoulder, as if the book were trying to turn him toward some unseen horizon.

He closed it.

The figures did not move.

"Why bring this to me?"

"Because it will open for you."

"Then you are fools."

"Perhaps."

The answer unsettled him more than defiance would have. Men who came armed into a fortress did not usually make room for uncertainty. Men who spoke in the name of the Bleeding Crown made less.

Brannoc rose with the grimoire in his hand.

"Who are you?"

"We are the remainder."

"Of what?"

The hood inclined toward the fortress behind him.

"Of the promise made when the realm broke."

That was poetry, and poetry was a kind of lie. Brannoc had spent too long among captains and claimants to mistake beautiful words for anything but a sheath around a knife.

He turned his head slightly. "You heard that? They call themselves a remainder."

No answer came from the gate.

He looked back at the road. The hooded figure stood close enough now that he could see the rain beading on the leather of its gloves. Beneath the hood, the face remained shadowed.

"Tell me what you want."

"You."

The old wound opened wider.

“Dead?”

“Not yet.”

The word passed through the rain with the quiet certainty of an execution order.

Brannoc smiled, though there was no humor in it. “You crossed the dark to tell me I may live?”

“We crossed it to tell you that living will cost more.”

“Everything costs more when men cannot afford to say what they mean.”

“You mean the Crown.”

He said nothing.

“The Bleeding Crown has an heir,” the figure continued. “The realm knows this, though the realm has not been told.”

“The realm knows nothing.”

“The realm knows hunger. It knows the smell of a lord’s panic. It knows which men look away when your name is spoken.”

Brannoc’s fingers tightened around the grimoire. The cover seemed to pulse once beneath the leather.

He remembered all the eyes that had measured him. All the smiles that ended before reaching the mouth. All the bargains in which he had been offered silver, land, absolution—anything but recognition. An unacknowledged heir was useful. A named heir was dangerous. Between those truths lay the whole shape of his life.

“You want me to claim it,” he said.

“We want you to survive what comes.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“No.”

A sound came from the ruins beyond the road.

Metal scraping stone.

The soldiers at the gate raised their weapons. Brannoc turned, grimoire still in hand. The shapes among the broken walls had tightened their circle. He could no longer see open ground between them.

“How many?” someone called from the parapet.

Brannoc did not answer.

The cloaked figure spoke behind him. “They are not ours.”

“Then whose?”

“Everyone’s.”

A bolt struck the gatehouse.

It hit one of the soldiers in the throat. He folded without a cry, his hands fluttering at the wound while the men around him shouted and recoiled. Another bolt clattered against the stone. Then the road erupted with

motion.

The figures in the dark surged forward.

Brannoc threw the grimoire back into its case and kicked the case toward the gate. It skidded through mud. A soldier seized it by the handle, dragging it clear as arrows hissed overhead.

“Close the gate!” Brannoc roared.

The chains began to move.

He met the first attacker beneath the arch. Steel rang. The impact jarred his arm to the shoulder. The attacker wore no colors and fought without sound, blade cutting from the hip in a flat, efficient stroke. Brannoc turned it aside, stepped in, and drove his pommel into the veiled face.

Bone gave.

The figure fell, and another came over it.

Rain ran into Brannoc’s eyes. He wiped it away with the back of his hand, leaving red across his cheek though he could not tell whose blood it was. Behind him, men shouted for room. Before him, the darkness pressed closer.

The hooded messenger had vanished.

Brannoc saw the absence and understood it as a betrayal.

“Coward!” he shouted.

Something answered from near the case.

Not the messenger’s voice.

His own.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

He turned.

The grimoire lay open in the mud.

Its pages were no longer blank. A black line had appeared across the nearest sheet, thin as a crack in ice. Beneath it, letters gathered slowly, bleeding into being.

The sword in Brannoc’s hand felt suddenly heavy.

The gate descended behind him with a thunderous grinding, cutting off the fort, the soldiers, the lamps, and every retreat he had not yet admitted he needed.

On the page, the final word formed.

Heir.

Then the darkness lunged, and Brannoc reached for the impossible—

The darkness struck him without weight.

It entered through his eyes.

For one breath Brannoc saw nothing but blackness, and in that blackness he felt the shape of himself being taken apart—not flesh from bone, but certainty from certainty. His sword vanished first. Then the mud beneath his boots. Then the iron taste of the air.

He reached for the ground and found a page.

It buckled beneath his palm, warm and damp as skin.

Letters crawled beneath his fingers.

BRANNOC IRONMERE THE RED-HANDED.

He tried to wrench his hand away. The ink had already climbed into the lines of his palm. It burned there with a cold so complete that his knuckles seemed to belong to someone else.

“Name your price,” he said.

His voice came back from every direction.

PRICE.

“Gold.”

PRICE.

“Blood.”

The word shuddered through the dark.

BLOOD.

Brannoc shut his hand. Somewhere beyond the page, something breathed with the patience of a buried king.

He had seen men bargain with demons, saints, and starving armies. They all made the same mistake. They believed the thing across from them wanted what they possessed.

The grimoire wanted what he had not yet given himself permission to become.

A pale seam opened before him.

Through it came the smell of snow on stone.

Then the world returned in a rush.

He stood upon a high road under a colorless sky. Below, the rebuilt walls of Crookvale clung to the mountainside, their crooked towers shouldering one another against the wind. Smoke dragged low over the settlement. Men in the garrison’s colors watched from the battlements, too distant to be faces. A banner snapped above them, then tore loose and vanished into the ravine.

Brannoc knew the place. He knew it with the intimacy of a wound he had never suffered.

“Crookvale,” he whispered.

The road answered with no echo.

A number had been cut into the nearest milestone.

He placed his hand over it. The stone was warm.

Crookvale had been founded in **295 AS**. The knowledge did not arrive in his mind; it surfaced through him, as though the grimoire had dredged it from some drowned chamber in his blood.

He looked toward the walls.

No sentry moved.

Below, the gate stood open. Beyond it, the street descended through rebuilt houses and shuttered workshops. The place had the hush of a settlement waiting to hear whether it was still alive.

“Why show me this?”

A figure stood beside the milestone.

Korvath Nightbrook wore the same guarded stillness he had carried at the fort, but the road had hollowed him. His cloak hung wet around him. His hands were empty.

Brannoc’s fingers found the hilt that was no longer there.

“You’re dead,” Brannoc said.

Korvath glanced toward the open gate. “That is an ambitious conclusion.”

“Where is my sword?”

“Where you left it.”

“I left it in my hand.”

“You leave many things there.”

The old anger rose cleanly. Brannoc welcomed it. Anger had edges. It could be held.

He struck at Korvath.

His fist passed through the smuggler’s chest and closed on winter.

The road buckled. The walls of Crookvale folded inward like paper touched by flame.

When the world steadied, Brannoc stood beneath a vast black spire.

Fenspire rose from the Gloaming Reach, its stone vanishing into low cloud. Every window burned with a pinprick of watchful fire. Lines of soldiers moved along the walls in ordered silence. Behind the battlements, weapon racks filled the courtyards. The garrison was not merely present; it was the shape of the place.

3,742.

The number appeared in the air above the gate.

Brannoc read it twice.

“Core holding,” he said.

Korvath stood several paces away now, his face turned toward the spire. “A garrisoned one.”

“Who holds it?”

The answer came from the stone.

THE ASHEN VANGUARD. HOUSE MORVAIN. THE SILENT CHOIR. THE IRON-RING CARTEL. THE BLEEDING CROWN.

The five names rolled over one another like armies marching beneath the earth.

Brannoc looked up at the tower. "All of them?"

"Not in the same room."

"Then put me in the room."

Korvath's mouth twitched, though it was not quite a smile. "You have spent your life trying to enter rooms that were built to exclude you."

"My life."

The words caught.

A strip of parchment appeared across the sky. Its surface was gray and marked with a single line of script.

BORN IN 255 AS.

The cold sharpened.

Brannoc stared at the words until they blurred.

He had never known his birth year. Not truly. There had been whispers, ledgers altered by careful hands, a woman who would not speak of the night he first cried. Men had called him many things before they called him captain. Bastard. Stray. Red-Handed. The grimoire offered the number without pity.

"Who wrote that?"

Korvath did not answer.

Another line formed beneath it.

UNACKNOWLEDGED HEIR TO THE BLEEDING CROWN.

Brannoc laughed once.

The sound died at his feet.

"No."

The spire's windows went dark one by one.

"No," he said again, louder. "An heir is named. An heir is witnessed. An heir is given a place at the table before someone decides the table must burn."

The parchment remained.

He struck it with his palm. The sheet split around his hand, but the words did not tear. They sank into him.

The Bleeding Crown.

The name had followed him through camps, alleys, and battlefields, never spoken plainly, always crouching behind another man's silence. He had taken coin from lords who looked at him too long. He had killed for commanders who never learned his face. He had thought the hunger in him came from poverty,

from violence, from the years spent being useful to men who found usefulness cheaper than trust.

The grimoire had found a simpler answer.

Korvath said, “You knew.”

“I suspected.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“It is when suspicion keeps you alive.”

A bell sounded within Fenspire.

Not an alarm. A summons.

The stone beneath Brannoc’s boots opened.

He fell into a hall lined with banners.

The Ashen Vanguard’s cloth hung scorched and stiff. House Morvain’s standard drooped as if it had been soaked in rain that never dried. The Silent Choir had no colors at all—only white fabric marked by a black vertical seam. The Iron-Ring Cartel displayed interlocked iron circles, each one painted over the last. Above them all hung the banner of the Bleeding Crown, its red field split down the center.

Five chairs stood around a table.

Four were occupied.

The fifth waited.

Brannoc recognized no faces. That was worse than recognizing enemies. The figures had been stripped of age, station, and feature. Their voices emerged from the banners behind them.

“The Accord of Mournthrone begins in **297 AS**,” said one.

A second voice followed. “The Accord ends in **301 AS**.”

“Named victor: **the Ashen Vanguard**.”

The table cracked between them.

“Collapse.”

The banners stirred though there was no wind.

“Ten years of guerrilla reprisals.”

Brannoc looked from one empty face to another. “That has not happened.”

“It will.”

“Then why tell me?”

The fourth figure leaned toward the vacant chair. “Because the losing commander is bribed to withdraw.”

A purse appeared on the table.

It was small. Plain. Heavy enough to drag the cloth toward it.

Brannoc saw no hand take it. He heard no terms. Yet the betrayal filled the hall, rank and intimate. Armies would die believing they had been defeated by steel. Villages would burn believing they had chosen the wrong oath. Men would whisper of cowardice when the truth was that someone had counted the price of retreat.

“Who paid him?” Brannoc asked.

The figures turned toward him.

“Sit.”

The fifth chair was made of black iron.

He approached it slowly. On its back, three cuts had been carved into the wood. The markings resembled the bindings of **The Thrice-Bound Edge**, though the weapon itself was nowhere visible.

He touched the chair.

Pain opened in his wrist.

A final line appeared above the table.

BRANNOC IRONMERE THE RED-HANDED DIES IN 300 AS DURING THE ACCORD OF MOURNTHRONE.

He withdrew his hand.

For a moment, the hall became very quiet.

Then Brannoc began to laugh.

It was not a pleasant sound. It had no joy in it, only disbelief hammered thin enough to ring.

“Not yet,” he said.

The figures watched him.

“Not in this room.”

The page beneath the chair darkened. Ink pooled around his boots.

He drew back, but the floor seized him. Black tendrils rose from the boards, winding around his ankles, his calves, his knees. They did not feel like rope. They felt like written commands.

The grimoire’s name appeared across the table.

EDGE OF GLOAMREACH.

The letters shone with a twilight glow.

Brannoc dragged one foot free. Skin tore. No blood came. Only ink.

“I have no oath to you.”

The empty chair creaked.

From somewhere above, beyond the sealed roof, a woman’s voice spoke—not Korvath’s, not his own.

“Everyone has an oath.”

He looked toward the sound.

At the far end of the hall, a door stood open.

Beyond it was not another chamber, but the fort he had left: mud, lamps, barred gate, the messenger's body—or perhaps only the messenger's shadow—waiting beside the case. The soldiers were still shouting. Time had not moved there.

Brannoc could return.

The grimoire did not say what would follow.

He looked back at the table. At the purse. At the empty chair. At his own death written in a hand that had never trembled.

Then he saw a sixth mark beneath the names of the five powers.

A smear of red.

Not ink.

His blood.

The door to the fort began to close.

Brannoc lunged.

The black bindings climbed to his waist. The hall tilted. The empty chair slid nearer across the floor, its legs groaning against the stone.

He reached through the doorway and caught the edge of the world.

For one heartbeat, his hand rested on the mud outside.

A soldier screamed his name.

Brannoc looked down at the black letters burning across his palm.

HEIR.

The door narrowed to a slit.

He bared his teeth and pulled.

Something on the other side pulled back.

Chapter 8

The wind came down from the High Spires with teeth in it.

It worried the walls of Crookvale, found every seam in the rebuilt stone, and filled the watchtowers with a thin, ceaseless moan. Below, the settlement crouched beneath the dark like something that had survived a beating and expected another. Fires burned behind narrow shutters. Iron shutters, iron doors, iron bands around every gate. Crookvale had remade itself in the image of fear.

I stood upon the western wall and watched the road vanish beneath the snow.

My hand was clean.

That bothered me more than blood would have.

Men had given me the name Red-Handed because names were cheaper than truth. A captain needed an emblem, a rumor, something that would reach a camp before he did. The name had served. It had opened gates, emptied purses, and silenced mutinies before mutiny could form a mouth.

But tonight my hands were clean, and the thing I had come to do could not be washed from them.

Behind me, boots scraped over the wallwalk.

“Captain.”

I did not turn. “If you have come to tell me the weather is foul, save your breath.”

“The weather is foul.”

“Then save it anyway.”

The guard halted a few paces away. He smelled of wool, lamp oil, and the sour fear of a man who had been ordered to deliver a message without being told its meaning.

“Korvath Nightbrook has arrived.”

That name moved through me like a knife entering an old scar.

“Alone?”

“Yes.”

“No horse?”

“No.”

“No escort?”

The guard hesitated. “He says he has none.”

“He says many things.”

The man shifted his weight. Stone creaked under his boots. “He was found beneath the south gate. He knew the old smuggler’s cut.”

Of course he did. Korvath Nightbrook made a profession of knowing where walls were weakest. He worked in the dark spaces between law and hunger, carrying whatever could be hidden and selling it to whoever did not ask where it came from. His face had the forgettable quality of a shut door. His clothes

were plain. His eyes were not.

“Put him in the lower chamber,” I said. “Search him twice.”

“He has already been searched.”

“Then search him by someone who knows what a book looks like.”

The guard frowned.

“Anyone can hide a knife,” I said. “The clever ones hide the reason for carrying it.”

He left. The wind returned to me.

Crookvale had been founded in 295 AS. I had repeated the words when I first entered the place, because facts were a way to keep the mind from surrendering to the shape of a place. Founded in 295 AS. Rebuilt after ruin. A garrison of 1004. Outside the core holdings, and therefore always waiting for the hand that would claim it—or the blade that would cut it loose.

Numbers had no mercy in them. They did not care how many had frozen in the passes, how many walls had fallen, how many men had been hanged from the gate beams until the crows learned their faces. A place was founded in a year. A garrison held a number. A dead man remained dead.

I looked down at my right hand.

The fingers were broad, scarred across the knuckles. The nails were rimmed with old black despite the washing. I had been told once that hands betrayed a man more completely than his face. Mine had made their confession long ago.

Not the one that mattered.

That secret had never touched my skin. It lived behind my teeth, under the tongue, where a man could carry it into a grave.

I was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

The thought did not thunder. It did not brighten the night or summon ghosts from the snow. It sat within me as it had always sat: cold, patient, and heavier than iron.

Unacknowledged. That was the shape of it. No proclamation. No seal. No courtly witness to drag before a tribunal. A claim without a voice was only a dangerous kind of silence.

And if the Crown knew what I was, then every road I walked became a road toward a throne or a scaffold.

I descended from the wall.

The lower chamber had been a storehouse before the rebuilding. Now it contained a table, two chairs, a brazier, and a drain set into the floor. The drain was newer than the rest. Someone in Crookvale had learned to improve the architecture of murder.

Korvath sat with his hands on the table.

He had not been searched well enough.

I saw it in the way he held himself, careful but not stiff, one shoulder slightly higher than the other. A hidden object altered the body around it. The eye might miss the object. The flesh did not.

His hair was damp from the weather. Snow clung to the hem of his coat. He looked like a man who had spent his life making himself too unimportant to remember.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed,” he said.

“Korvath Nightbrook.”

“You took your time.”

“I was standing in the wind deciding whether to let you freeze.”

“That would have been discourteous.”

“I have never been accused of courtesy.”

His mouth twitched. “You have been accused of worse.”

“By men who survived long enough to speak.”

The brazier clicked as the coals shifted. Its heat could not reach the corners. Water ran somewhere inside the walls, slow and hollow, like a finger drawn down a coffin lid.

I pulled out the chair opposite him but did not sit.

“What did you bring?”

“Nothing.”

“Then you came for something.”

“I came to speak.”

“Speech is what men call the thing they do before asking for gold.”

Korvath glanced at my hand. “You have no gold to spare.”

“You are observant.”

“I am alive.”

“By a narrow margin.”

He leaned back. The chair gave a small groan. “There are people asking questions.”

“People always ask questions.”

“These are better questions.”

“Names.”

“I was not given names.”

“You were given coin.”

“I was given a warning.”

“From whom?”

His eyes lifted to mine. There was the guardedness in them, the wary stillness of a creature that had learned every open hand might close around its throat.

“From someone who knows what you are.”

The room became smaller.

Not visibly. The walls remained where they had been. The brazier still breathed its dull heat. Yet the air seemed to draw inward, pressing my ribs together.

I sat at last.

Korvath watched me do it.

“Say it plainly,” I told him.

“Plain speech is dangerous.”

“So is the crooked kind.”

“Not here.”

“Here is the only place you are.”

His gaze moved to the door. Beyond it, the guard stood somewhere in the passage, pretending not to listen. A man who had been trained to obey could still be trained to betray. Loyalty was not a wall. It was weather.

Korvath lowered his voice. “They know there is a claim.”

“There are always claims.”

“They know this one is hidden.”

“Half the realm claims a crown when drunk.”

“This one is not half the realm.”

The brazier gave a soft red sigh.

I kept my face still. It was the first discipline a sellsword learned: never let a blow reach the place where it could be read. My pulse had become a hammer under my throat, but Korvath would see only a man considering whether to kill him.

“Who sent you?” I asked.

“No one.”

“Try again.”

“No one sent me.”

“Then why come?”

“Because I dislike being dead.”

“Most men do.”

“I heard that you were here.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the beginning of one.”

I reached across the table and caught his wrist.

Korvath moved quickly. Not quickly enough.

The hidden weight pressed against his sleeve as I twisted his arm. He hissed, and something hard struck the tabletop with a muted clack. A narrow metal tube rolled between us and stopped against my knuckles.

The guard outside shifted.

“Stay there,” I called.

Korvath stared at the tube.

“Your searchers missed it,” I said.

“They searched for weapons.”

“Then they were fools.”

“It is not a weapon.”

“Everything is a weapon when placed in the right hand.”

I took up the tube. It was cold enough to bite. No crest marked it. No name. The cap had been sealed with black wax, and within the wax lay a single impression: a crown pierced through its center.

My mouth dried.

Korvath flexed his freed wrist. “Open it.”

“You brought it.”

“I brought it to you.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“You are the only man in Crookvale who can decide what it means.”

I looked at the seal until the crown blurred.

The Bleeding Crown had no need to speak my name. It had only to remind me that names were not required for recognition.

“Where did you get this?”

“From a courier.”

“Where is he?”

“Dead.”

“By your hand?”

“No.”

“Whose?”

Korvath’s expression tightened. “That is the warning.”

Outside, a bell began to ring.

One strike. Then another.

The sound rolled through the stone, deep and dismal. The guard shouted in the passage. Feet pounded overhead. Somewhere above us, men were running toward the walls.

Korvath rose.

I pressed the tube beneath my palm. “Sit.”

“There is movement at the south gate.”

“You knew there would be.”

“I suspected.”

“You walked into Crookvale knowing an attack was coming?”

“An attack is a generous word.”

The third bell sounded.

Dust sifted from the ceiling.

For one suspended moment, neither of us spoke. I felt the old instinct gathering in me—the clean and brutal answer to uncertainty. Draw steel. Secure the door. Put Korvath on his knees. Find out who had come by making someone bleed until the truth crawled out.

That instinct had fed me for years. It had never once told me what to do with a crown.

I broke the black seal with my thumb.

Inside the tube was a strip of pale material, folded once. No signature. No explanation. Only a line written in a hand that seemed to lean away from the page:

The heir walks beneath a borrowed name.

Korvath watched my face.

The door burst inward.

The door burst inward.

Korvath moved first. Not backward—sideways, slipping into the seam between the wall and the iron-bound frame as if the darkness had made room for him. A blade flashed where his throat had been.

I caught the attacker’s wrist.

The impact jarred my shoulder. The intruder wore a coat of boiled leather beneath a rain-dark cloak, the hood drawn low. No badge. No colors. The knife in his hand was narrow and ugly, made for ribs rather than battlefields.

I drove my forehead into his face.

Bone gave. He made a wet sound and folded. I kept hold of the wrist, twisted until the knife fell, then stamped his knee sideways. The corridor filled with the smell of dust, rain, and blood.

Two more shapes crossed the threshold.

Korvath threw a brass weight.

It struck the nearest one beneath the ear. The man staggered, and Korvath was on him at once, one hand clamped over his mouth, the other dragging a cord from somewhere inside his sleeve. He pulled hard. The cord tightened around the man's throat.

The third drew a sword.

I stepped into its reach.

Steel skimmed my coat and found no flesh. My hand closed over the hilt, my other fist sinking beneath the attacker's ribs. He exhaled against my knuckles. I wrenched the sword free and struck him with its pommel.

He dropped beside the first.

For a moment the corridor held only the rasp of Korvath's breathing.

Then the bells began again.

Not the measured toll from below. These were closer, frantic, struck by a hand that had forgotten rhythm.

The man beneath my fist groaned. I seized his cloak and dragged him into the room. Korvath released the other, who collapsed against the jamb, clutching at his throat.

"Who sent you?" I asked.

The first man spat blood onto my boot.

I pressed the stolen sword beneath his jaw.

"Who sent you?"

His eyes found mine beneath the hood. There was fear in them, but fear was cheap. It could be purchased with steel, fire, or the mere promise of being left alive.

"The seal," he rasped.

I glanced toward the table.

The broken tube lay open beside the lamp. The pale strip of material had not moved. The line remained there, leaning away from the page.

The heir walks beneath a borrowed name.

Korvath crossed the room and kicked the door shut. He had recovered his knife. A thin red line marked his cheek.

"You know them?" I asked.

"No."

"You expect me to believe that?"

"I expect you to believe nothing."

He crouched beside the man whose knee I had broken. From the attacker's belt he drew a small packet wrapped in waxed cloth. He weighed it in his palm, then looked at me.

"Search the others."

I did.

The second carried a coil of wire, two keys, and a folded scrap marked with a charcoal stroke. No insignia. No coin. The third had a purse containing dull trade pieces and a strip of black ribbon. Nothing that named a master.

Korvath opened the packet.

Inside lay a book no larger than his hand, bound in cracked gray hide. No title marked its cover. The leather smelled of damp stone and old smoke.

“What is it?” I said.

“A ledger.”

“Of what?”

His thumb worried at the edge of the cover. The guarded look he wore when lying came upon him—not a change in expression, but a tightening, as if some inner door had been barred.

I took the book from him.

The first pages contained columns of names and places, written in several hands. Some had been scratched away. Others were circled in red. I read through them while the wounded men breathed around me.

Most of the entries were meaningless without a key. Deliveries. Transfers. Debts. Grain, salt, iron, bodies.

Then I saw the place-name.

Fenspire.

The letters had been pressed hard enough to score the page.

“Read it,” Korvath said.

“I can read.”

“Then read it aloud.”

The entry beneath the name had been written in a careful hand:

Fenspire ruled by The Iron-Ring Cartel.

The lamp flame bent in a draft.

Beyond the narrow window, rain whispered against the shutters. Somewhere below, the bells faltered and stopped.

Korvath watched the words as though they might rise from the page and put a knife into him.

“How long?” I asked.

“Long enough.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you’ll get until we are out of this room.”

I closed the ledger. “You brought me here.”

“I brought you somewhere the walls were thick.”

“You brought me into a room with three knives waiting behind the door.”

“I did not bring the knives.”

“But you knew they might come.”

He said nothing.

The first attacker tried to sit. I placed a boot against his chest and pushed him back down.

“Why were they looking for this?”

Korvath’s gaze flicked to the pale strip.

“Not the ledger.”

“Then what?”

“The name.”

The word seemed to settle over the room with the weight of ash.

I looked again at the message. The hand that had written it appeared almost delicate, yet each stroke had the stubbornness of a scar.

“Who is the heir?”

Korvath’s mouth hardened.

“Don’t.”

“That is not an answer either.”

“It is the answer that keeps you breathing.”

I turned the ledger over. A second compartment had been cut into the back cover. Inside was a folded square of black paper.

Korvath lunged.

I caught him by the throat and drove him against the wall. The room shuddered with the impact. His knife clattered across the floor.

“Brannoc.”

He rarely used my name. Hearing it in his mouth did not make him sound afraid. It made him sound as though fear had passed beyond him and found something colder.

“What is in the paper?”

“If you open it, every road between here and the Crown becomes a grave.”

“Then it should be a familiar sight.”

I tightened my hand.

Korvath’s fingers closed around my wrist. He was not strong enough to break the hold, but he was quick, and quickness had kept him alive where courage would have gotten him buried. His eyes shifted toward

the wounded men.

“They are not alone.”

I listened.

At first I heard nothing but the rain.

Then came the scrape of boots below.

Many boots.

The building had begun to wake around us. Doors opened. Voices rose, muffled by floors and walls. A frightened shout broke off. Something heavy fell. The bells rang once, twice, then dissolved into a clatter of metal.

Korvath breathed through his nose.

“More are coming,” he said.

“I had noticed.”

“Not for the ledger. For you.”

“Why?”

“You know why.”

The words struck harder than they should have. The message. The black seal. The careful hand. The old instinct gathering beneath my ribs, demanding that uncertainty be given a throat.

I released him.

He bent, retrieved his knife, and cut the cord from the second attacker’s belt. Then he crossed to the window and lifted one shutter by a finger’s breadth.

The rain had turned the outer yard into a smear of torchlight and black mud. Figures moved beneath the eaves. Some wore cloaks. Some wore armor. All of them looked alike in the wet dark.

“Can we leave through the window?” I asked.

“Not without breaking something.”

“Then break it.”

He gave me a humorless glance. “You first.”

I looked down at the three men.

The one with the broken knee had stopped pretending not to listen. Blood threaded from his nose to his mouth. The other, still choking from the cord, was trying to crawl toward the hall.

I caught his ankle and dragged him back.

“Tell me who sent you.”

He clawed at the floorboards.

“Fenspire,” he said.

Korvath went still.

The man coughed. “Fenspire sent us.”

“Fenspire is a place.”

“The Iron-Ring Cartel rules Fenspire,” Korvath said.

The attacker’s eyes widened at the name, and in that widening I found the truth—not its shape, but its direction.

I hauled him upright.

“Who in The Iron-Ring Cartel?”

He shook his head.

I slapped him.

“Who?”

His lips trembled. “The record says the smuggler was born there.”

Korvath’s face emptied.

“What record?” I asked.

The man looked at him.

That was answer enough.

I turned to Korvath. “What record?”

He drew the black paper from my hand before I had realized he’d moved. His knife opened it with one clean stroke.

Inside was a narrow slip, folded around a strand of pale hair.

No. Not hair.

Thread.

The writing was cramped and cramped again, as if the author had feared the paper itself.

Korvath read it once.

His hand began to shake.

I took the slip.

KORVATH NIGHTBROOK — BORN: 348 AS.

The words were followed by marks I could not decipher, then a seal impressed so lightly it had nearly vanished.

For several breaths, the room seemed to tilt.

Korvath had always been a man made of exits. He slipped through markets, wars, and other men’s hungers with the same narrow patience. A smuggler needed no history, only a destination and something worth carrying there.

But the paper had given him one.

“Is it true?” I asked.

He stared at the line.

Outside, someone shouted orders. A fist struck the door below. The wounded man began to pray, though no god’s name came from his mouth.

Korvath folded the slip once.

“I don’t know.”

“You don’t know the year you were born?”

“I know what I was told.”

“By whom?”

His eyes lifted to mine.

The door shook in its frame.

“Brannoc,” he said, “if they open that door, they will not ask which of us is the heir.”

Another blow.

The hinges screamed.

He thrust the ledger against my chest and drew his knife in reverse grip.

“Then tell me what you are hiding.”

The door splintered.

Korvath stepped toward it, and the first black-cloaked figure forced one arm through the gap, fingers searching for the latch as Korvath whispered—

Korvath stepped toward it, and the first black-cloaked figure forced one arm through the gap, fingers searching for the latch as Korvath whispered—

“Read the last page.”

The hand found the iron.

I seized Korvath by the collar and dragged him aside as the door burst inward. The black-cloaked man stumbled through the wreckage, his shoulder striking the table. The lamp leapt. Oil sheeted across the boards, and fire ran through it in a thin, eager tongue.

Korvath’s knife entered beneath the man’s jaw.

There was no cry. Only the wet click of breath attempting to continue.

Korvath wrenched the blade free and shoved the body back into the breach. Two more figures pressed behind it, their cloaks soaked dark with rain or blood. The room filled with the smell of iron, lamp oil, and the cold mud tracked in from the street.

“Last page,” he said again.

I had the ledger open against my forearm. The paper was swollen, the ink running in narrow black veins. Most of the entries were accounts: grain, iron, horses, names crossed out and written again. The hand changed every few pages, as if the book had passed through more lives than any man ought to possess.

At the back, beneath a torn strip of leather, someone had written a single line.

I knew the script.

Not because I had seen it before, but because it resembled my own.

Halvard Vane the Grave-Sworn commands Crookvale (since 362 AS).

For a moment the words refused to mean anything. They sat there with the dead calm of a blade laid upon a table.

“Who is Halvard Vane?” I asked.

Korvath drove his shoulder into the door. The corpse wedged in the opening groaned as the men beyond tried to push through.

“You know who.”

“I do not.”

“You will.”

The second black-cloaked figure thrust a short sword through the gap. The point punched through the wood and stopped a finger’s breadth from Korvath’s ribs. He twisted aside, caught the blade under his arm, and hacked down with his knife. The steel snapped. A curse rose beyond the door.

I turned the page.

The writing below the line had been scraped away so violently that the parchment had torn. Beneath it, in a narrower hand, were three words.

After Mournthrone falls.

A tremor went through me. I told myself it was the floor shaking beneath the assault. I told myself many things in those days. A captain survives by making lies that wear the shape of orders.

“What does it say?” Korvath demanded.

“Halvard Vane the Grave-Sworn commands Crookvale since 362 AS.”

The door went still.

Even the men outside seemed to hear the words through the splintered wood.

Korvath looked at me then, and whatever guarded mask he had worn since I found him in the lower rooms cracked at the edges.

“You read the year.”

“362 AS.”

“That is not possible.”

“Neither is your calm.”

His mouth tightened. "Crookvale has a garrison of 1004."

The number struck me strangely. Not as a fact, but as a weight. A thousand blades could make a lord bold. Four more could make him believe the gods had counted him among the chosen.

"And Halvard commands them?"

"Commands Crookvale," Korvath said. "The line does not say commands the garrison."

"Then the book is careful."

"The book is bait."

"Bait for whom?"

"For the man who thinks an heir is a man."

The fire had reached the curtain. Cloth blackened, curled, and fell in glowing tatters. Smoke crawled along the ceiling, thickening the air until each breath tasted of old ashes. Beyond the ruined door, someone began to murmur. Not prayer. The cadence was too measured, too empty. Words without a god's name.

The Silent Choir, perhaps. Or men who had learned to imitate them.

I folded the ledger shut.

Korvath caught my wrist. His fingers were cold despite the heat.

"Do not take that."

"You brought it here."

"I brought it to bury."

"Under a floor?"

"Under a lie."

The door shuddered again. The corpse slumped from the breach, and a black-cloaked hand seized the edge. Korvath pulled me toward the rear wall.

There was no passage there. I had seen the room when we entered: stone, shelves, a rusted rack, nothing else. But smugglers built doors where honest men saw walls. Korvath pressed his palm against a section of mortar and waited.

Nothing happened.

"You said you knew a way out."

"I said I knew a way."

"Those are different things?"

"Tonight, they are."

He pressed again. The mortar gave beneath his hand with the softness of wet bread. A square of stone withdrew into darkness.

Behind us, the black-cloaked men began to break through.

Korvath shoved the ledger into my coat.

“No.”

“You wanted to know what I was hiding.”

“I wanted an answer.”

“You have one.”

“A line in a book is not an answer.”

“It is more than most kings receive.”

The opening was narrow, barely wide enough for a man to turn his shoulders. Cold air breathed from it, carrying the mineral stink of deep stone. I looked into the black and saw nothing.

“Go,” Korvath said.

I did not move.

The fire snapped behind us. Sparks drifted through the smoke like red insects.

“Who wrote it?”

Korvath’s face had gone pale beneath its grime. “A dead man.”

“That narrows it poorly.”

“The hand is yours.”

I looked down at the ledger again. The final line trembled in the firelight.

Halvard Vane the Grave-Sworn commands Crookvale (since 362 AS).

The letters were mine. Not my hand as it was, but my hand stripped of haste and anger, aged into something colder. The final stroke of *Crookvale* curved exactly as mine did when I signed contracts. The little break in the ink after the number was mine too.

I had never written those words.

A blade came through the shattered door and buried itself in the table. Another black-cloaked figure forced his way over the threshold. His face remained hidden, but I saw a pale mark at his throat: a circle cut by three vertical lines.

He raised a hooked sword.

Korvath threw the lamp.

Oil and flame struck the man’s chest. Fire climbed him at once. He beat at it with both hands, silent beneath the hood, while the men behind him recoiled. Korvath seized my arm and drove me into the wall.

The stone aperture widened.

We entered the dark.

The slab closed behind us with a grinding sigh. On the other side, the burning man crashed against it. His fists struck once, twice. Then the blows became frantic. Then they ceased.

We stood pressed together in the passage, breathing smoke and stone.

I could hear water somewhere below. It fell at long intervals, each drop carrying through the dark as distinctly as a bell.

Korvath released me.

“Where does this go?”

“Out.”

“Toward what?”

“Down first.”

The passage sloped beneath the room. My boots found worn steps, slick with condensation. Korvath moved without hesitation, one hand on the wall, the other holding his knife low. I followed, the ledger hard against my ribs.

The dark altered around us. The air cooled. The smell of fire faded, replaced by wet earth and something sweeter beneath it, like flowers left too long in a sealed chamber.

“You knew my hand,” I said.

“I knew your name before I knew your face.”

“My name is sold in every camp between the ruined roads.”

“Not that name.”

The steps ended at a ledge. Far below, black water moved without sound.

Korvath stopped.

I nearly struck his back.

Across the chasm, a narrow bridge emerged from the stone. It had no rail, no posts, no visible support. At its far end stood a door of pale wood, untouched by damp or rot. Someone had carved a crown into it and painted the carved channels red.

I felt the ledger shift beneath my coat, though I had not touched it.

“What is that?” I asked.

“The way out.”

“You said this was a smuggler’s route.”

“It is.”

“No smuggler built that door.”

Korvath glanced at me. “No smuggler built the first one.”

The water below stirred.

Something had moved beneath its surface.

Korvath stepped onto the bridge. The stone dipped beneath his weight, then steadied. Halfway across, he looked back.

“Brannoc.”

He had not used my name like that before. Not as a warning. Not as an apology.

I placed one boot on the bridge.

The ledger opened inside my coat.

A page turned by itself.

Across the chasm, behind the pale door, a voice spoke in the same cadence as the writing—my voice, worn thin by years I had not lived.

“Halvard Vane the Grave-Sworn commands Crookvale since 362 AS.”

The door began to open.

Chapter 9

Rain worried the roofs of Crookvale with thin, patient fingers.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed stood beneath the gatehouse arch and watched it descend through the torchlight. The rain turned the packed earth black. It drew the old blood from the stones in narrow red threads, as if the town itself had found a vein and meant to open it.

Behind him, the garrison waited in the dark.

Crookvale had been founded in 295 AS, but its walls already bore the exhausted look of something much older. The rebuilt towers leaned into the High Spires wind. Their stones did not match; some were pale, some charcoal, some veined with the glassy scars left by the Sundering. Survival had made the town crooked. Survival had made it hard.

A sentry shifted on the parapet.

“Captain.”

Brannoc did not turn. “If you’re going to lie, make it a useful lie.”

The sentry swallowed. “There’s someone at the lower road.”

“Who?”

“He gave no name.”

“Then he has one.”

“He says he carries a message from Fenspire.”

That made Brannoc look up.

Far beyond the rain, beyond the folded blackness of the highland, Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach with its stark spire thrust into the dim sky. It had been founded in 57 AS. A core location. Garrisoned. The ledger claimed 3,742 soldiers held its walls, and men trusted ledgers because numbers seemed cleaner than fear.

“What sort of message?” Brannoc asked.

“Sealed.”

“By whom?”

The sentry hesitated.

Brannoc smiled without warmth. “You see how easily a man can die of details?”

“He carries the Iron-Ring mark.”

“Open the gate.”

The sentry stared down at the rain.

“Captain,” he said, “the lower road is watched.”

“By whom?”

No answer.

Brannoc placed one hand upon the pommel at his hip. The other hand—his right—was bare despite the cold. It was the hand that had earned him the name the songs gave him, though the songs disagreed about how. Some said it was the blood of a lord. Some said it was the blood of a priest. Some said Brannoc had once plunged it into a brazier and held it there until the flesh blackened, to prove that pain was merely another kind of coin.

The truth had never been worth correcting.

“Open the gate,” he said again.

This time the sentry obeyed.

The hinges groaned. Rain blew inward. A figure entered beneath the arch, wrapped in a coat too plain to be expensive and too well-cut to be poor. He moved as men moved when every doorway might be a trap: without haste, without trust.

Korvath Nightbrook.

Brannoc knew him by reputation, which was the only safe way to know a smuggler. Korvath worked in the spaces between laws, moving things that powerful people preferred to pretend did not exist. He had the guarded manner of a man who carried secrets as other men carried knives.

Korvath stopped several paces away.

“Brannoc Ironmere,” he said.

“Titles are cheaper than names.”

“I brought something for the Sellsword Captain.”

“I’m not paid to be flattered.”

“You’re paid to remain alive.”

Brannoc glanced toward the closing gate. “That bargain has begun to sour.”

Korvath reached inside his coat and produced a narrow black case. No crest marked it. No wax sealed it. The thing seemed less carried than concealed by the dark around it.

Brannoc did not take it.

“From Fenspire?”

“From someone who wants you to believe it came from Fenspire.”

“Who?”

Korvath’s mouth tightened. “Someone who knows what you are.”

The rain hissed on the torches.

Brannoc felt, beneath the coat and mail, the old scar at his sternum draw tight. Not pain. Recognition. There were truths a man could spend his whole life outrunning, only to find them waiting at the next gatehouse.

“What am I?” he asked.

Korvath looked at his right hand.

“The unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.”

For a moment the whole gatehouse became silent enough for Brannoc to hear water drip from the brim of his own hood.

Then he laughed.

The sound did not travel far.

“An heir requires an acknowledgment.”

“Not always.”

“Always, if he wants to sit on the throne.”

“Perhaps the throne is not what they fear you taking.”

Brannoc stepped closer. Korvath’s composure held, but the smuggler’s eyes flicked once toward the murder slits above them. Counting exits. Counting witnesses. Counting the breaths remaining in his body.

“You came through a watched road to recite a nursery tale.”

“I came because the armies are moving.”

“Which armies?”

“The Ashen Vanguard has withdrawn from the eastern ridge.”

“That isn’t an answer.”

“House Morvain is calling it a retreat. The Silent Choir is calling it an offering. The Iron-Ring Cartel is calling it a buying opportunity.” Korvath’s gaze hardened. “The Bleeding Crown has called it nothing.”

Brannoc looked out through the gate.

Crookvale’s rebuilt street vanished into mist and rain. Somewhere beyond the walls, men waited with orders they did not understand. Somewhere beyond them, commanders made maps of hunger and called the lines strategy.

“The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS,” Brannoc said. “Every fool in the realm knows that.”

“Then you know what comes next.”

“It has not ended.”

“Not yet.”

The words crawled beneath Brannoc’s skin.

The Accord had been called an agreement by those who signed it and a war by everyone who bled beneath it. Mournthrone hung over every negotiation like a blade suspended by a thread. No army marched without claiming necessity. No lord tightened a levy without calling it protection. The Ashen Vanguard spoke of order. House Morvain spoke of blood. The Silent Choir spoke in silences. The Iron-Ring Cartel spoke in weights, measures, and debt. The Bleeding Crown spoke through the mouths of men who had never seen the crown itself.

And Brannoc stood between those voices with no name anyone dared write beside his.

“Show me,” he said.

Korvath handed him the case.

The metal was cold enough to bite. Brannoc opened it.

Inside lay a folded strip of treated hide and a ring of dull iron. Beneath them, wrapped in grey cloth, rested a book no larger than a man's hand. Its cover was ridged like dried skin. No title had been stamped upon it, but when Brannoc touched the clasp, letters surfaced in the dark.

Edge of Gloamreach.

A grimoire.

He had heard of it in taverns where the lamps were kept low and the doors barred from within. They said its attunement cost was 46. Men who repeated that number usually lowered their voices afterward, as though the number itself might hear them.

Brannoc did not open the book.

"Why give me this?"

"I didn't."

"Who did?"

Korvath's expression became a locked door.

Brannoc placed the grimoire back in the case. Beneath it, the folded hide had begun to sweat black through its creases.

He opened that next.

The writing was cramped and severe.

The first line named no sender. The second contained a list of roads, garrisons, and stores. The third named Crookvale. The fourth named Fenspire. The fifth contained a sentence that made Brannoc's fingers still.

The Thrice-Bound Edge.

Regalia forged in 123 AS.

The record beside it contained no attunement cost.

He read the line twice. Then he read the ones beneath it.

A weapon, perhaps. Or a crown's symbol. Or a binding given shape. The name had the feel of something locked away because the world had once learned what it could do.

Korvath watched him.

"Does it say where it is?" the smuggler asked.

"No."

"Does it say why you were sent the message?"

"No."

"Then you've been useful."

Brannoc folded the hide.

His hand shook once.

He closed it into a fist until the tremor stopped.

“I was born in 255 AS,” he said.

Korvath did not move.

“Why are you telling me that?”

“Because men keep speaking of my blood as if it began in a room where I wasn’t present. I was born in 255 AS. I learned the sword before I learned the shape of my own inheritance. I became a Sellsword Captain because steel was more honest than lineage.”

“And now?”

“Now someone wants me to collect a piece of regalia forged in 123 AS.”

“Someone wants you to choose a side.”

“I’ve chosen sides.”

“Then choose a throne.”

Brannoc struck him.

Korvath’s head snapped sideways. He did not fall. Blood appeared at the corner of his mouth, bright as a garnet in the torchlight.

The gatehouse guards watched without watching.

Brannoc felt the familiar heat in his right hand, though the blow had landed with the left.

“Don’t mistake knowledge for permission,” he said.

Korvath wiped his mouth. “You think I don’t know what you are?”

“I think you know what men have paid you to say.”

“Then listen to what they haven’t paid me to say.”

He reached inside his coat again.

This time Brannoc drew his sword.

The blade whispered free.

Korvath froze with two fingers inside the lining.

“Slowly,” Brannoc said.

Korvath withdrew an oilskin packet and held it between thumb and forefinger. “This came from Mournthrone.”

“Everything comes from Mournthrone now.”

“It bears the seal of the losing commander.”

Brannoc’s point remained steady. “There is no losing commander while the Accord continues.”

“There will be.”

The rain thickened beyond the arch.

Brannoc stared at the packet. He imagined opening it. He imagined finding orders, confessions, names. He imagined the final shape of the war, the shape no herald would sing: a withdrawal purchased in secret, a battlefield abandoned for a purse, a victory dressed afterward in banners.

He imagined the Ashen Vanguard beneath the walls of Mournthrone.

The thought entered him like cold water.

On the hide, beneath the directions and the names of artifacts, a final line had been written in ink so dark it reflected the torch flame.

The Ashen Vanguard was the victor of The Accord of Mournthrone.

Not would be.

Was.

Brannoc read it again.

Something moved high above the gatehouse. A boot scraped stone. One of the unseen sentries made a small choking sound.

Korvath looked up.

Brannoc turned toward the parapet, sword raised, and heard the first crossbowstring snap—

The bolt struck the stone beside Brannoc’s hand and burst into black splinters.

Korvath swore. His knife flashed upward, though there was nothing for it to meet but torch smoke and the ragged mouth of the gatehouse above.

“Down,” Brannoc said.

He seized Korvath by the collar and dragged him behind the broken merlon as a second bolt hissed over them. It vanished into the dark beyond the gate. Somewhere below, a horse screamed once, then kicked against its harness until the sound became a dull, frantic hammering.

Brannoc pressed his shoulder to the cold stone. The hide remained clenched in his fist.

“Who knew?” Korvath whispered.

Brannoc could feel the smuggler’s breath against his cheek. Damp. Sour with fear.

“About the withdrawal?”

“About any of it.”

Above them, boots crossed the parapet. Not hurried. Not searching. Waiting.

Brannoc looked at the ink-dark line again.

The Ashen Vanguard was the victor of The Accord of Mournthrone.

The words had the calm of a verdict already delivered. They did not belong on a map of roads, nor among the cramped notes concerning the two artifacts hidden beneath the gatehouse foundations. Yet there they

were, laid down with the confidence of a hand that had watched the banners fall.

His thumb passed over the name.

The Accord of Mournthrone had begun in **297 AS**. Every captain in the shattered realm knew that much. It had become the measure by which men counted hunger, requisitions, burned keeps, and sons who did not come home. But the line claimed an ending not yet suffered. It named the Ashen Vanguard victor while the walls still held and the armies still breathed.

A future written as a memory.

“Give me the hide,” Korvath said.

Brannoc turned his head.

Korvath’s face was a pale blur beneath the hood. “If they take you, they’ll cut it out of you.”

“They’ll take you first.”

“I’m smaller.”

“Not by enough.”

Another bolt struck the merlon. Stone dust breathed into Brannoc’s eyes. He blinked through the grit and saw, for the briefest instant, a figure standing beyond the crenellation: a long cloak, a lifted arm, the pale glimmer of a hooked blade.

Then the figure was gone.

Brannoc rose.

Korvath caught his sleeve. “What are you doing?”

“Leaving.”

“There are men above us.”

“There are men behind us.”

The gatehouse shuddered as something heavy struck the outer doors. Dust descended in a gray veil. The unseen sentries made no challenge. No alarm bell rang. Their silence was worse than treachery. It had the thick, deliberate shape of an order obeyed.

Brannoc tucked the hide beneath his coat and drew his sword.

The leather around the hilt was slick. He glanced at his palm. The old red stain had opened again along the lifeline, whether from the cold or the pressure of his grip. The men who called him the Red-Handed believed the name belonged to slaughter. They had never understood that blood clung to a man most stubbornly when he was trying not to spill it.

Korvath watched the sword clear its sheath.

“You said the lower passage was empty.”

“I said I had used it.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“It is when you’re being chased.”

They moved along the wall, bent beneath the arrow slits. The gatehouse smelled of wet mortar, lamp oil, and the stale iron scent of old weapons. Brannoc counted the steps without speaking. At the end of the passage, a narrow stair descended into darkness.

Korvath reached for the lamp.

Brannoc stopped him.

Below, something scraped.

A blade being drawn slowly across stone.

Korvath's fingers tightened around the lamp handle. "We could go up."

"And join the men who have already decided to kill us?"

"Perhaps they only want the map."

"Then they are more foolish than they sound."

The impact against the outer doors came again. This time, the hinges cried. The whole structure leaned into the blow.

Brannoc looked toward the parapet. The torchlight had thinned. The sentries remained silent.

He thought of the other hidden truth, the one the hide had wrapped in lines of cipher and smuggler's shorthand: the losing commander had been bribed to withdraw. Not defeated. Bought.

That truth would not remain buried. It would rise after the accord and walk from village to village with a knife in its hand. A decade of guerrilla reprisals, the note had said—not in those words, but in a column of marks that Korvath had taught him to read. A decade of ambushes, reprisals, vanished patrols, fields salted by fear. Victory would be another name for the door opening.

"Down," Brannoc said.

He descended first.

The stair was tight enough to scrape his shoulders. The darkness below held the mineral chill of buried places. Korvath followed, breathing through his teeth. Above them, wood split with a deep, wet crack.

Brannoc reached the bottom and found a chamber cut into the foundation. Its walls had been painted black long ago, though damp had peeled the pigment into scales. A low table occupied the center. Upon it lay a long bundle wrapped in oilskin and a book bound in gray hide.

The book seemed to drink the lamp's weak glow.

Korvath descended the last step. When he saw the table, all his fear sharpened into greed.

"No," Brannoc said.

The smuggler halted.

"That is what we came for."

"We came to see whether the rumor was true."

"Now we know."

"Knowing is not carrying."

Korvath smiled without humor. "You have become cautious at the end of your life."

Brannoc's hand tightened on the sword.

The bundle on the table bore three iron clasps. Beneath them, a strip of faded cloth had been tied in a knot so elaborate it resembled a little bound fist.

"The Thrice-Bound Edge," Korvath breathed.

The name seemed to alter the air.

Brannoc stepped closer. He did not touch the bundle. The regalia had been forged in **123 AS**, long before the Sundering's wounds had closed over. Its record contained no attunement cost. That absence troubled him more than any price could have. Men trusted a thing that declared its hunger. A thing that named no cost merely waited for the account to be discovered.

Korvath reached toward the first clasp.

Brannoc struck his wrist with the flat of his blade.

The smuggler recoiled. "You said it was regalia."

"I said nothing."

"You brought me here."

"I brought you to open a door."

"And what is this?"

"A reason not to."

The book lay beside the bundle, its cover ridged like old scar tissue. On its spine, in letters almost rubbed away, was written **Edge of Gloamreach**.

Korvath's eyes fixed upon it. "The grimoire."

Brannoc felt the room grow narrower.

"Attunement cost," Korvath murmured, reading the notation stamped beneath the title. "**46**."

His voice changed when he said the number. Desire entered it, and desire was always the first rot.

"The forging date is not recorded," Brannoc said.

"You can read that?"

"I can read enough."

"Then read the rest."

Brannoc bent over the open page.

The script had been written in several hands, layered one over another. Some lines were prayers. Some were inventories. One passage had been scraped away so violently that the parchment beneath was furred and torn. In the margin, someone had drawn a crown with its lower points dripping ink.

The Bleeding Crown.

The mark did not surprise him. It only made the secret inside him feel less like a secret and more like a blade turned inward.

He was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown. The words had never been spoken over him by any court, nor sealed by any witness who mattered. Yet blood did not require acknowledgment to remember itself. It traveled in silence. It waited in the body like an ember beneath ash.

Korvath saw the crown in the margin.

His gaze lifted.

“Is that yours?”

Brannoc shut the book.

“No.”

“That was not what I asked.”

“It is the answer you’re receiving.”

The impact above came a third time. This blow drove a splinter of the gate inward. Men shouted now, muffled by timber and stone. The sentries had begun to die loudly.

Korvath snatched up the grimoire.

Brannoc caught him by the throat and drove him against the wall.

The lamp swung between them. Shadows climbed Korvath’s face. His hands clawed at Brannoc’s wrist.

“Leave it,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s eyes watered. He still managed to grin.

“You fear a book?”

“I fear what men become when they think a book fears them.”

From above came the sudden rush of feet. The stair filled with the scrape of boots.

Brannoc released Korvath and turned.

The first attacker appeared in the stairwell, crouched beneath the ceiling. He wore no crest. His crossbow was already leveled.

Brannoc moved before the weapon fired.

He threw the lamp.

Oil burst across the man’s chest. Flame climbed him in a single bright sheet. The crossbow snapped; the bolt struck the wall. The burning figure stumbled backward into those behind him, and the stair became a furnace of limbs, curses, and cloth catching fire.

Korvath shouted.

Brannoc seized the wrapped regalia from the table. The bundle was heavier than it looked. Something within shifted against the iron clasps, not loose, not alive, but bound with such pressure that the sound went through his teeth.

The grimoire remained in Korvath's hand.

"Move!" Brannoc roared.

They ran toward the rear of the chamber, where the wall seemed solid.

Korvath plunged his knife into a seam.

A section of stone gave inward.

Cold air poured through the opening, carrying the smell of rain and high earth. Beyond lay a narrow passage descending beneath the foundations, too low for a mounted man and too dark to promise survival.

Behind them, the burning attacker fell. The men on the stair came over him.

Brannoc shoved Korvath through the gap, then followed with the bundle pressed to his ribs. A bolt struck his backplate and skittered away. Another sank into the stone beside his head.

He crawled into the dark.

For several breaths there was only the sound of their hands scraping grit and the ragged breathing of the wounded. Then the passage opened beneath them. Korvath slid first, vanishing with a muffled cry.

Brannoc dropped after him.

He landed hard on one knee. Pain traveled up his thigh. Above, the gap narrowed as the pursuers found it. A hand reached through, fingers dragging over the floor.

Brannoc raised his sword.

The bundle pulled against his arm.

Not physically. Not exactly.

The Thrice-Bound Edge lay within its wrappings, forged in **123 AS**, and the old bindings seemed to answer the blood beneath his skin. The chamber behind him filled with firelight. A man forced his shoulders through the gap. His face was blackened, his eyes white with pain.

Brannoc lifted the blade.

The man stared at him.

"Wait," Korvath whispered from somewhere ahead. "Wait, Brannoc. There's something here."

Brannoc's sword hovered at the intruder's throat.

Beyond the burning man, more hands groped through the breach.

And from the darkness ahead came a sound like a crown being dragged slowly across stone—

The burning man's fingers closed around the sword-arm.

His touch was almost gentle.

Brannoc drove the pommel into his mouth. Bone gave. The man sagged, but did not release him. Behind him, the breach exhaled smoke and the wet stink of men who had crawled through fire. More hands clawed at the stones. Someone sobbed. Someone else prayed without words.

Then the thing in the darkness dragged its crown again.

Stone grated against metal.

The sound passed through Brannoc's teeth.

"Korvath."

"I hear it."

"Then tell me what it is."

"I would, if the dead would stop whispering."

The passage ahead opened into a chamber too large for the keep that contained it. Firelight reached only the nearest flags. Beyond them, pillars rose and vanished into blackness, each wrapped in chains the color of old blood. Something moved between them—not a body, not a shadow, but a hesitation in the dark.

The man at Brannoc's feet made a bubbling sound.

Brannoc tore free and kicked him back through the breach. The wounded intruder struck the others. Their hands withdrew. For a moment the flames painted only empty stone.

"Bar it," Brannoc said.

Korvath did not answer.

Brannoc turned. The smuggler stood at the edge of the chamber with a lantern held low, his face obscured by its hood. He had one hand pressed against the wall. His other clutched a book bound in grey hide.

The book was not burning.

That troubled Brannoc more than the men behind them.

"Come here."

Korvath's gaze remained fixed on the dark. "You know what I found?"

"I know you found something you mean to sell."

"I mean to survive."

"That is a smaller ambition."

"It has kept me alive."

"Not for much longer."

The crown scraped once more.

Korvath flinched. The lantern flame leaned toward the sound, thin and blue at its heart.

Brannoc entered the chamber. The air grew cold around him, but beneath the cold lay a deeper sensation: the pressure of being watched by something that had forgotten how to blink. The Thrice-Bound Edge tugged against its bindings. He could feel the blade through the wrappings, a patient weight beneath his arm.

Korvath lifted the grey book.

"Edge of Gloamreach," he said.

The title had been stamped into the hide in letters that seemed to drink the lantern's light.

Brannoc looked at him.

“It is a grimoire,” Korvath continued. “Attunement cost is 46.”

“Cost to whom?”

“To whoever opens it.”

“Then why is it open?”

Korvath’s thumb rested on the cover. “It was open when I found it.”

“Where?”

“In a dead man’s hands.”

“Whose?”

The smuggler’s mouth tightened. “Dead.”

Brannoc took another step.

The floor shifted beneath him.

Not moved. Remembered.

For the length of a breath, the chamber became a highland road beneath a white sky. Rebuilt walls leaned around a settlement crouched among the heights, their edges crooked and hard. A gate stood open beneath a watchtower. Men occupied every wall-walk, every stair, every killing ground.

A voice spoke from nowhere.

“Crookvale was founded in 295 AS in The High Spires.”

The vision broke.

Brannoc staggered. His boot scraped sparks from the flagstone.

Korvath had gone pale. “You saw it.”

“I saw a settlement.”

“Crookvale.”

“Why?”

The grey book trembled in his hand.

The voice came again, not aloud this time, but beneath his thoughts.

“Rebuilt. Garrison of 1004. Outside the core holdings.”

Brannoc shut his eyes.

He saw the crooked walls again. The settlement endured beneath a sky the color of ash. Its garrison stood in perfect silence, not watching the passes, but the ground beneath them. Their stillness had the shape of fear.

Then a second place rose behind his eyelids.

A spire pierced a dim horizon. The land around it was drowned in violet mist, and the walls below were crowded with soldiers. No banner flew. No gate opened. The whole fortress seemed to have been hammered into the world as a warning.

“Fenspire stands in the Gloaming Reach,” whispered the unseen voice. “Founded in 57 AS. Core location. Garrison of 3,742. Garrisoned status.”

Korvath crossed himself with two fingers.

Brannoc opened his eyes. “You brought me here to show me garrisons?”

“I brought you here because the book showed me roads.”

“Roads to Crookvale?”

“Roads to everything.”

“Everything belongs to someone.”

“That is what makes it valuable.”

The sound of the crown came nearer.

The chains around the pillars tightened, one after another. Dust fell from the ceiling in pale streams. In the darkness, something drew breath. It was a vast breath, slow and damp, as if the chamber itself had lungs.

Korvath backed toward the breach.

Brannoc caught his collar.

“Open the book.”

“No.”

“Open it.”

“It knows my name.”

“Then it has good taste.”

“It knows yours as well.”

Brannoc felt the old instinct rise in him—the clean, brutal answer to refusal. His hand tightened. Korvath’s boots slipped on the dust.

Then the grey hide whispered.

Not words. Pages turning inside it.

Brannoc released him.

The book opened by itself.

Its leaves were black at the edges and pale at the center, as though each had been cut from a piece of moonless sky. No ink marked the first page. Slowly, a red line appeared. It ran from the upper corner to the bottom, straight as a sword cut.

Another line crossed it.

Then another.

A crown took shape.

Not the jeweled circlet worn by kings in painted histories. This was an iron band warped by heat, its points hammered inward. Beneath it, letters gathered.

BRANNOC IRONMERE THE RED-HANDED.

Korvath made a strangled noise.

Brannoc stared at the name.

The chamber seemed to draw closer around him.

“Read,” he said.

“I can’t.”

“You can.”

“I know what it says.”

“Read it.”

Korvath’s voice came thinly. “Born in 255 AS.”

The letters beneath his name lengthened.

“Continue.”

The smuggler swallowed. “Unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.”

The crown in the darkness stopped moving.

For an instant there was no fire, no breach, no groaning stone. Only the sentence hanging between them.

Brannoc had heard the word heir before. It had been used as an insult, a threat, a bargaining chip passed from one knife-hand to another. Never spoken without a price. Never spoken where walls could remember.

He looked at Korvath.

“Who told you?”

“The book.”

“Books lie.”

“Not like this.”

Brannoc seized the grimoire. Its pages were cold, colder than the air. The instant his fingers closed on it, the red letters sank into the paper and another passage rose beneath them.

The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS.

The words appeared one at a time.

It ended in 301 AS.

The black page drank the lantern-light. Brannoc read on.

BRANNOC IRONMERE THE RED-HANDED DIED IN 300 AS DURING THE ACCORD OF MOURNTHRONE.

His grip slackened.

Behind him, the men at the breach began to hammer at the stones. Their voices rose in panic. They had seen something beyond the fire, or heard it, and whatever it was had made them forget Brannoc.

Korvath whispered, "That is not a prophecy."

"No."

"It is a record."

"No."

The page shuddered beneath Brannoc's hands. The letters blurred, then formed a final line.

THE CROWN HAS ALWAYS KNOWN ITS BLOOD.

Brannoc closed the book.

The pressure in the room broke.

The crown scraped across stone with a violence that shook dust from the vault. Something struck the nearest pillar. Chains snapped taut. The lantern went out.

Darkness swallowed them.

Korvath's breathing became quick and shallow. "Brannoc."

"Silence."

"I cannot see."

"Neither can it."

"You do not know that."

"I know enough."

The Thrice-Bound Edge pulled again.

This time Brannoc did not resist.

He unwound the bindings. The cloth fell in heavy loops, revealing the weapon's hilt. There was no glow, no flame, no theatrical sign from the heavens. Only the quiet presence of regalia forged in 123 AS, waiting beneath the dark.

The thing moved.

Stone cracked.

Brannoc drew.

The blade came free with a sound like a lock opening.

Somewhere beyond the pillars, something recoiled. The chains screamed. Korvath cried out, and the book struck the floor.

Brannoc stepped between the smuggler and the dark.

“Stay behind me.”

“You said silence.”

“I changed my mind.”

The breach burst inward.

Men poured through it, coughing and blind, stumbling over one another. Brannoc cut the first across the chest. The Thrice-Bound Edge passed through cloth, leather, bone. The man folded without a cry. Another lunged. Brannoc turned the blade and struck with the flat, breaking the attacker’s temple. A third reached for Korvath.

Korvath drove a small knife beneath the man’s jaw.

The dead fell at their feet.

For a heartbeat, there was only the crackle of the fire and the wet rasp of Korvath’s breath.

Then, from the depths of the vault, a voice spoke.

It did not call Brannoc by his name.

It called him by his inheritance.

The darkness opened like a mouth.

And within it, beneath the dragging crown, something held out a hand.

Chapter 10

The rain had turned the high road to black soup by nightfall, and the wheels of the cart sank with a wet, sucking sound that made Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed think of teeth being pulled.

He sat beneath the torn awning with one hand resting on The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The regalia lay across his knees in its oil-dark sheath. It was not a soldier's weapon, though soldiers had died beneath it. Its bindings gave off no light. They did not whisper. The thing merely endured his touch, as if it had been waiting through all the years for the right hand—or the wrong one—to claim it.

Brannoc had wielded The Thrice-Bound Edge since 277 AS.

He had been younger then, though the world had not been kinder. He remembered the first time he had drawn it: the weight descending into his palm, the silence of every witness, the sudden knowledge that some objects did not make a man greater. They only gave his enemies a shape to fear.

Beyond the curtain of rain, the walls of Fenspire rose from the Gloaming Reach. The stark spire at its center cut the clouded sky like a nail driven through rotten cloth. Fires burned along the battlements. Their glow found the puddles and died there.

The city was garrisoned. That much was plain from the watchfires, the iron discipline of the sentries, the measured passage of patrols beneath the gatehouse. Fenspire did not sleep. It watched.

A man crouched opposite Brannoc, soaked through the shoulders and careful not to look at the sword.

"Your master will not come," Brannoc said.

The man's mouth tightened. "I have no master."

"Then you have chosen a poor night to become honest."

"I carry a message."

"Messages have masters."

The man glanced toward the rear of the cart. Brannoc heard the guard outside shift his weight. Another spat into the mud. Neither spoke. The rain battered the awning, and beneath it the air smelled of wet leather, horse sweat, and old ashes.

"The Ashen Vanguard has named itself victor," the messenger said.

Brannoc smiled without warmth. "Has it?"

"The Accord of Mournthrone—the victor is the Ashen Vanguard."

He said it as if repetition could make the words heavier. As if victory were a stone and not a cloak thrown over a corpse.

Brannoc's thumb moved once along the sheath of The Thrice-Bound Edge. The bindings had been forged into the regalia long before the Accord, long before most of the men now boasting beneath its banners had learned to hold a blade. The artifact had a patience that disgusted him.

"Who sent you?" he asked.

The messenger looked again toward the rain.

Brannoc caught him by the throat and drove him against the cart's inner wall. Wood groaned. The man's boots struck the floorboards once, twice. His hands clawed at Brannoc's wrist.

There was no effort in the captain's grip. That was what frightened men most: not strength, but the absence of strain.

"You came into my shelter," Brannoc said. "You spoke the name of the victor. Now you will speak the name of the hand behind your tongue."

The messenger's face had gone pale beneath the road grime.

"House Morvain," he rasped.

Brannoc released him.

The man fell forward, coughing into his sleeve. For a moment the only sound was the rain and the deep, hollow ringing of the spire's bell somewhere beyond the walls.

House Morvain. One of the powers that fed upon the broken realm. The name carried the taste of old wine and sharpened knives. Brannoc had never trusted noble houses. They hid cowardice behind curtains, and when they killed, they sent others to hold the blade.

"What does House Morvain want?"

"Safe passage."

"For whom?"

The messenger did not answer.

Brannoc drew The Thrice-Bound Edge an inch from its sheath.

The cart seemed to contract around the sound.

"For whom?" he asked again.

"For a company."

"A company of what?"

"Men."

"Every fool with a spear calls himself a company."

"They are soldiers."

"Whose?"

The messenger stared at the strip of dark metal showing beneath the sheath. "Not yours."

Brannoc slid the blade home. "That is not an answer."

The man swallowed. "They are to pass through Fenspire before the next bell."

Brannoc turned his head toward the rain-veiled walls. "House Morvain wants armed men inside a garrisoned city."

"They will not enter the city."

"Then why tell me?"

“Because the gate captain—”

Brannoc’s hand moved, and the messenger stopped.

“No names,” he said. “You are already carrying too many.”

The man looked at him with the dull hatred of someone who had been made helpless and wished to blame the nearest cause. Brannoc knew that look. He had worn it in younger years, before he had learned that hatred was a coin one spent only when there was no sharper currency.

“You are Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed,” the man said.

“I am.”

“The unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.”

The rain seemed to recede.

For one breath, Brannoc heard only the blood within his own ears.

Then he laughed. It was a quiet sound, and the messenger flinched from it more than he had from the sword.

“Is that the message?”

“It is what they say.”

“They say many things.”

“They say the Crown has been denied to the man who could take it.”

“By whom?”

The messenger looked toward the curtain again. “By everyone who fears what would happen if you did.”

Brannoc leaned back against the cart wall. The wood was cold through his coat. Outside, one of the guards called a challenge. Another answered. Fenspire continued its watch, stern and sleepless, the city’s stone ribs holding fast against the Reach.

He had heard the epithet in taverns, in ruined keeps, in the mouths of women who had never seen his face. The Red-Handed. Some said it was for the enemies he had killed. Others said it was for the blood he had refused to wash away. None knew enough to be certain.

The Crown knew.

The Crown had never named him.

“Tell House Morvain,” Brannoc said, “that I do not open gates for rumors.”

“The soldiers will pay.”

“Everyone pays.”

“They can offer more.”

“Then they should offer it to someone who believes coin buys obedience.”

The messenger gathered himself. “The Ashen Vanguard is victor. Their banners will come to Fenspire. When they do, every man who stood against them will need a place to vanish.”

“Is that what House Morvain is offering? A place to vanish?”

“A place to survive.”

Brannoc watched the man’s wet hands. No rings. No crest. The fingertips were stained black with road mud, but the nails were clean. A messenger who did not labor. A servant trained to carry secrets without understanding them.

“Survival,” Brannoc said. “A word used by cowards to dress their bargains.”

“You speak as if you have never bargained.”

“I sell a sword. That is not the same as selling the hand that holds it.”

The messenger’s eyes flicked down.

Brannoc saw it. The man saw him see it.

“You want The Thrice-Bound Edge,” Brannoc said.

“No.”

“Your employers do.”

“I know nothing of it.”

“Then you know less than you pretend.”

The rain strengthened, rattling against the cart’s patched roof. A cold thread slipped through the tear above them and ran down Brannoc’s neck. He did not move.

The Thrice-Bound Edge rested across his lap like a sealed accusation. He remembered the year he had taken it, the faces watching, the way the world had shifted by the width of a blade. Since 277 AS, men had approached him with offers made of gold, blood, promises, and silence. None of them had asked whether he wanted the thing he carried. They wanted only to know what it would cost to make him set it down.

A bell sounded from Fenspire.

Once.

The messenger’s face changed.

“How long?” Brannoc asked.

“Until the next bell.”

“Until the next bell for what?”

“For the company to reach the eastern road.”

Brannoc rose.

The cart roof forced him to stoop, but the messenger seemed to shrink beneath him. Brannoc lifted the sheath and secured it at his side. The familiar weight settled against his hip. He felt its presence through the leather, through cloth, through the old scars that crossed his palm.

Outside, the guards fell silent.

Brannoc pushed open the rear flap. Wind entered first, carrying rain and the iron smell of the road. One guard stood beside the wheel with a hand on his sword. The other watched the wall.

“Take him to the horses,” Brannoc said.

The messenger stumbled out behind him.

“What will you do?” the man asked.

Brannoc stepped into the rain. Water struck his face, cold as thrown gravel.

“I will go and see whether your soldiers are soldiers.”

“And if they are?”

Brannoc looked toward the eastern road, where darkness lay thick between the standing stones.

“Then they will have to explain why they are walking toward a city that does not want them.”

He began down from the cart.

The messenger caught his sleeve. “You cannot refuse House Morvain.”

Brannoc looked at the hand until it fell away.

“I have refused worse.”

At the edge of the road, a rider emerged from the darkness. The horse came at a hard pace, slipping in the mud, foam pale upon its bit. The rider hauled the reins, nearly falling as the animal stopped before Brannoc.

No crest marked the cloak. No weapon showed except a knife at the belt.

“Captain,” the rider said.

Brannoc waited.

“The eastern watch has gone dark.”

Behind them, the bell in Fenspire began to ring again.

Not once.

Again and again, the sound rolling over the Gloaming Reach like iron dropped into a grave.

The messenger whispered, “They have entered the road.”

Brannoc’s fingers closed around the hilt of The Thrice-Bound Edge.

Somewhere beyond the rain, men were moving beneath a banner no one had dared to name. Somewhere inside Fenspire, a gate was opening—or had already been opened. And above the walls, beneath the stark spire and the sleepless fires, the Ashen Vanguard’s promised victory waited with its teeth bared.

Brannoc drew the blade.

The darkness before him seemed to draw breath.

The blade made no sound as it cleared the sheath.

That was the first wrongness.

Steel ought to announce itself. Even a dull sword had a little voice in it—the rasp of metal against leather, the intimate complaint of a thing being woken. The Thrice-Bound Edge slid free as quietly as a secret passing from one mouth to another.

Rain jeweled its length. The firelight from the wall crawled over the weapon and found no color to keep.

Brannoc held it low.

“Close the gate,” he said.

The messenger stared at him through the wet dark. “Captain—”

“Close it.”

“But the road—”

“Is not our concern until the gate is closed.”

The man swallowed. Behind him, the bells continued their iron repetition. Their tolling had ceased to be an alarm and become a condition of the night, like rain, like hunger, like the old ache beneath Brannoc’s ribs that never fully left him.

He turned toward the walls.

Fenspire’s inner yard churned with movement. Men crossed through the rain in knots of black and rust, carrying bows, spears, buckets, coils of rope. The garrison had awakened without panic, which was more dangerous than panic. Panic scattered. Discipline gathered. Fires burned beneath the covered walks, making the rain shine in sheets. Above them, the stark spire rose into the low cloud, its upper stones lost beyond sight.

At the gatehouse, a horn sounded once.

A second answered from the eastern wall.

Then nothing.

Brannoc’s mouth tightened.

“Send word to the western towers,” he said. “No one leaves the fortress. No one enters. If a man claims a seal, cut off his hand before you read it.”

The messenger flinched.

Brannoc looked at him. “You heard me.”

“Yes.”

“Then make the order live.”

The messenger ran.

Brannoc followed at a slower pace, The Thrice-Bound Edge held in his fist. The weapon’s hilt was cold despite his hand. He had carried it since 277 AS, long enough for lesser men to decide that the sword had chosen him, or that some curse had fastened itself around his wrist. Men liked explanations that spared them the labor of looking closely.

At the foot of the gatehouse stairs, a woman in a soaked cloak stepped from beneath the arch.

She had entered the yard without being challenged.

Two guards stood behind her, both alive, both watching her as though they had forgotten what their weapons were for.

Brannoc stopped.

The woman removed her hood. Rain ran from her hair and along the sharp planes of her face. She carried no banner, no visible blade. A narrow case hung beneath her cloak, bound in oilskin and dark cord.

"You are late," she said.

"Who are you?"

"Someone who knows why the eastern watch went dark."

The bell rang again overhead. The sound pressed down through the stone.

Brannoc studied the case. "Open it."

Her gaze shifted to The Thrice-Bound Edge. Not fear. Recognition, and something colder behind it.

"Not here."

"Then you should have chosen a quieter night."

"I chose the night that was given to me."

He took one step closer. The guards behind her tightened their grips.

No one moved.

A smell came from the open gatehouse: wet wool, lamp oil, old mortar, and the copper-sour trace of blood. Brannoc breathed it in and felt the part of himself that had survived too many campaigns rise awake. It did not care about banners. It did not care about causes. It measured distance, footing, hands, throats.

The woman saw the calculation in his face.

"You have the wrong enemy in front of you," she said.

"There is no wrong enemy. Only the one nearest."

She drew the case from beneath her cloak and set it on the stone ledge between them.

The cord had been sealed with black wax. No emblem marked it.

Brannoc did not touch it.

"Where is Korvath Nightbrook?"

Her expression did not change, but the pause was answer enough.

"Alive," she said.

"That was not the question."

"He was at Blackford."

The name entered the yard and seemed to remain there.

Brannoc looked toward the rain beyond the gate. The road was a black wound between the walls, empty beneath the weather. Somewhere beyond it, the unseen force was entering the road. Somewhere within the fortress, the eastern watch had gone dark.

“Was?” he asked.

“He left.”

“For where?”

“To bring warning.”

“Here?”

“To whoever still understands warning.”

Brannoc placed The Thrice-Bound Edge against the case. The blade made the oilskin smoke.

The woman’s composure broke for the first time. Her hand went toward her breast, where a concealed weapon might have rested.

Brannoc’s sword remained still.

“What is in it?” he asked.

“A record.”

“Of what?”

“Of where the old regalia were kept.”

The rain struck the stone between them.

Brannoc felt the night narrow.

“Say it.”

She watched him, and he saw that she understood what name lived beneath his name. Not the name men shouted when they wanted his sword. Not the epithet painted in taverns and whispered in barracks. The other one. The blood-hidden one. The claim no court had acknowledged and no grave could safely bury.

“The Thrice-Bound Edge housed in Crookvale,” she said.

Her voice was quiet.

The gatehouse seemed to lean around the words.

Brannoc looked down at the sword in his hand. Its dark surface reflected neither the fire nor his face.

“And the other?”

“Edge of Gloamreach housed in Blackford.”

For a moment there was only the bell.

Then Brannoc laughed.

It was a small, humorless sound. The woman’s eyes hardened.

“You find this amusing?”

“I find the dead fond of inventories.”

“The record was copied before the roads were sealed.”

“By whom?”

“I do not know.”

“Everyone knows something.”

“Then ask someone else.”

Brannoc lifted the tip of the blade and touched the black seal. The wax cracked. A thread of cold escaped the case, so faint he might have mistaken it for air slipping through the gatehouse stones.

The woman caught his wrist.

Her fingers were strong.

Brannoc turned his hand, and the grip broke. He did not strike her. He did not need to. She stumbled back against the wall, and the guards raised their weapons too late.

“Do not touch me again,” he said.

She pressed her lips together. “If you open that here, the men in the yard will hear it.”

“Good.”

“It is not meant to be heard.”

“Then it should not have been brought to a fortress under attack.”

“It was brought because the fortress is under attack.”

The distinction irritated him. He had spent his life surrounded by men who believed a different arrangement of words could change the weight of a corpse.

Brannoc tore the case open.

Inside lay a folded sheet of gray hide, several strips of blackened parchment, and a shard of something pale as old bone. The markings on the hide were not letters as he knew them. They curved inward, each stroke hooked around a central emptiness.

The Edge of Gloamreach was not visible.

Still, Brannoc felt its absence.

The Thrice-Bound Edge trembled once in his grip.

Not fear. Recognition.

The woman whispered, “You should not have done that.”

“Yet you brought me the key.”

“It is not a key.”

“Then why does my sword know it?”

She looked at the weapon, and the guarded mask fell from her face entirely. Beneath it lay terror—not of him, but of what might be listening through the blade.

A shout rose from the eastern wall.

Another answered from inside the fortress.

The gates groaned.

Brannoc turned.

The great beams had begun to lift.

Men shouted below. The chain mechanisms clattered with brutal patience. One of the gate guards ran down the stair, his boots slipping on the wet stone.

“Who gave the order?” Brannoc called.

No one answered.

The woman moved toward the case.

Brannoc caught her cloak and hauled her back. “You knew.”

“I knew the gate would open.”

“And you came here anyway.”

“I came because someone must reach the spire.”

“Why?”

“Because the people opening the gate are not the people you should be fighting.”

The chain rattled overhead. A seam of darkness appeared between the doors, and beyond it the road waited under rain.

Brannoc’s first thought was not of invasion.

It was of treason.

His second was worse.

He looked at the gray hide again. The inward-curving marks seemed to have shifted. Not moved—he would not grant them that—but altered in the manner of a face seen from the corner of the eye.

“Take me to the spire,” he said.

The woman shook her head. “No.”

He brought The Thrice-Bound Edge up beneath her chin.

“Take me.”

“If you go there, you will be seen.”

“I am already seen.”

“Not by the ones who matter.”

The gate opened another handspan.

Through the gap came a smell of mud, wet leather, and extinguished fires. No army appeared. No horse. No torch. The road remained empty.

That emptiness frightened him more than a column of men would have.

From somewhere beyond the gate, a voice called his name.

Not his title.

Not the name used by soldiers or creditors or those who wanted a bargain.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

The woman went still.

The voice came again, muffled by rain.

“Your crown is waiting.”

The words struck deeper than steel.

For one instant, the yard vanished. He saw a hall of black stone, a circlet split down the middle, hands reaching through a red wash of light. He saw the face of no one he could name. He saw himself kneeling—not in surrender, but because the floor had become too far away to stand upon.

Then the vision broke.

Brannoc’s hand tightened around The Thrice-Bound Edge until the hilt bit flesh.

The blade answered.

A line of darkness ran along its length, thin as a vein beneath skin.

The woman stared at it. “You hear it now.”

“I hear a man outside a gate.”

“You hear the claim.”

“I hear a trap.”

“Those are not different things.”

The gate chain screamed. The doors began to part.

At the far end of the yard, men in the colors of the Ashen Vanguard turned toward him. Their faces were pale in the firelight. Some had weapons drawn. Others stood beside the walls as if awaiting a command already given.

Brannoc looked from them to the opening gate, then to the case at his feet.

The Thrice-Bound Edge had been housed in Crookvale.

The Edge of Gloamreach had been housed in Blackford.

Two relics. Two places. One road leading into the dark.

And somewhere beyond the widening doors, a voice wearing the shape of his buried inheritance waited for him to step outside.

Brannoc raised the sword.

“Ring the bells,” he said.

The woman’s eyes narrowed. “For what?”

“For everyone.”

He kicked the case toward her and faced the gate.

The darkness beyond it moved.

The darkness beyond it moved.

Not like a man. Not like any living thing.

It gathered beneath the archway, drawing the night inward until the torches guttered blue. Rain hissed somewhere beyond the gate. The smell of wet stone entered with it, and beneath that a sweeter odor—old blood left too long in a sealed room.

The woman with the case took one step back.

“Captain,” she said.

Brannoc did not turn. “Ring them.”

“They’ll hear.”

“That is the intention.”

A bell began in the upper tower.

Its note fell through the keep like a stone dropped down a well. Another answered from the inner wall, then another from the yard. The sound shook dust from the rafters. Men cursed. Somewhere a horse screamed and kicked against its stall.

Beyond the gate, the darkness spoke.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

His name entered the hall with a stranger’s mouth around it.

He felt the old wound beneath his ribs tighten. Not pain. Recognition. The kind a knife might feel when it found the seam in a coat.

The woman raised the sword case. “What is it?”

“Something that knows too much.”

“Then kill it.”

The answer almost pleased him. Almost.

Brannoc stepped beneath the arch.

Rain silvered the paving stones. Beyond the gatehouse, the road descended through black pines and broken ground. No rider waited there. No torch. No shape that could have made the darkness move.

Yet a voice breathed from the trees.

“You carry regalia forged in 123 AS.”

The Thrice-Bound Edge grew cold in his hand.

Behind him, men crowded the gatehouse. Their fear had a smell: salt, leather, and the faint sourness of bowels loosening under mail. The bell continued to toll overhead. Its rhythm was uneven now. Someone was striking it with whatever strength remained in his arms.

Brannoc lowered the sword point until it touched the stone.

“The Thrice-Bound Edge has no tongue.”

“Regalia does not require a tongue.”

The words seemed to come from everywhere—the trees, the wet walls, the mouths of the watching soldiers. A whisper passed through the men behind him. One of them made a warding sign against his breast.

Brannoc turned his head slightly. “No one fires.”

The woman’s grip tightened on the case. “You know what this is.”

“I know what it wants.”

“And what does it want?”

“To be opened.”

She looked down at the black iron clasps. “The Edge of Gloamreach?”

The name crossed the yard like a cold hand.

The grimoire had been housed in Blackford. Brannoc had never seen its pages, but he had seen what remained of a man who tried to turn them. The corpse had been found folded into itself, every joint bent in the wrong direction. No mark had been made upon the flesh. The eyes had simply gone dark, as though night had been poured through them.

A book that demanded an attunement cost of 46 was not a book. It was a bargain with the shape of a book.

The voice in the trees whispered, “Bring it to me.”

Brannoc smiled without warmth. “Come take it.”

The darkness paused.

That pause was worse than an answer.

A figure emerged between the pines.

It wore a hood darkened by rain and moved with the careful economy of someone accustomed to being overlooked. No weapon showed. No insignia. The face beneath the hood was narrow, watchful, and tired in the way of a man who had survived by never appearing to be worth killing.

Brannoc knew him.

“K■■■■orvath Nightbrook,” he said.

The smuggler stopped where the road met the yard.

Several soldiers lifted their bows despite the order.

Korvath raised both hands. "I came alone."

"No one comes alone," Brannoc said.

"Then I brought what you need."

"Which is?"

Korvath glanced past him toward the case. "Time."

A laugh escaped one of the soldiers. It died quickly.

Brannoc studied the man's wet boots, his empty hands, the mud caught beneath one thumbnail. Korvath Nightbrook had the look of someone who had crossed places where roads were only rumors. Smugglers survived by carrying truth in one pocket and a lie in the other, never confusing which one was valuable.

"Where is the book?" Brannoc asked.

"Not in Blackford anymore."

The bells continued above them.

The gatehouse seemed to contract around the words.

"Who moved it?"

Korvath's eyes flicked toward the soldier holding the case. "Not who. What."

Brannoc took one step down into the rain. The Thrice-Bound Edge hung loose beside his thigh. It felt heavier than it had a moment before, as though the old regalia had remembered the weight of a crown.

"Speak plainly."

"I found the road empty."

"That is not plain."

"The road was empty," Korvath repeated. "The houses were empty. The watchfires burned without anyone tending them. The book was gone."

"Gone where?"

"I followed the marks until they stopped."

"Where?"

Korvath looked at the sword. "Here."

A gust moved through the yard. Rain struck Brannoc's face. He tasted iron.

Behind him, one of the older soldiers murmured, "The Crown."

The word did not belong in the mouth of a frightened man. It belonged in halls, beneath banners, behind sealed doors. It belonged to the Bleeding Crown and all the blood that had been spent pretending blood was proof.

Brannoc heard it anyway.

He had been born in 255 AS, under a name that had never been written beside the name of the house that sired him. The Bleeding Crown had made no place for him, yet its claim lived in the bones of his life. Unacknowledged heir. A phrase spoken softly by enemies who wanted him ambitious and allies who wanted him useful.

He had learned young that a hidden inheritance was more dangerous than an open one. A visible prince could be guarded. A concealed one could be used by anyone who found him.

The voice in the trees returned.

“Unacknowledged heir.”

The soldiers went still.

Korvath’s face lost what little color the rain had left in it.

Brannoc lifted the sword.

“Show yourself.”

The woods gave him no answer.

The Thrice-Bound Edge shivered once. Its binding seemed to tighten around his palm—not cutting, not drawing blood, but reminding him that the blade had been forged to hold what should not be free.

The five powers of the Ashen Era had all learned the same lesson in different languages. The Ashen Vanguard called it order. House Morvain called it blood. The Silent Choir called it silence. The Iron-Ring Cartel called it price. The Bleeding Crown called it rightful return.

None of them called it fear.

From the road came a low scraping sound.

Something dragged itself over the stones.

The soldiers shifted. One bowstring creaked.

“Hold,” Brannoc said.

The sound came again.

At the edge of the torchlight lay a strip of black leather, slick with rain. A buckle clung to it. Beneath the buckle, a hand had been sewn into the strap, the fingers curled around the leather as if still trying to unfasten it.

Korvath stared.

“That was on the book’s chain,” he whispered.

“Whose hand?”

He swallowed. “I don’t know.”

The voice sighed through the trees.

“You know.”

Brannoc looked at the dead hand. There were no rings, no marks he recognized. Nothing to tell him whose blood had paid for the warning.

He thought of Crookvale.

The settlement had been founded in 295 AS in The High Spires, then rebuilt after whatever ruin had first claimed it. Its garrison numbered 1004, enough to make the walls appear formidable from a distance, not enough to make them safe. Crookvale remained outside the core holdings. That was the truth of it: rebuilt, armed, and still peripheral. A place expected to endure without ever being permitted to matter.

The Thrice-Bound Edge had been housed there.

Now it rested in his hand.

Far to the east, Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, a core location with a garrison of 3,742 and a garrisoned status that never softened into peace. A disciplined fortress beneath a permanent watch. If the book had passed through the Reach, someone there should have seen it.

Someone should have died loudly.

Brannoc glanced at Korvath. "You came from Blackford by way of Fenspire?"

"I came by no road you know."

"Did you see the spire?"

"I saw its shadow."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one I have."

The smuggler's gaze moved toward the woods. "There are things moving between the powers now. Not messengers. Not soldiers. Things that carry words from one stronghold to another and leave the meaning behind."

"Whose words?"

Korvath's mouth tightened. "All of them."

A murmur rose among the men. The Iron-Ring Cartel. House Morvain. The Silent Choir. The Ashen Vanguard. The Bleeding Crown. Their names were not spoken, but each seemed to stand among the torches, invisible and patient.

Brannoc stepped toward the hand in the road.

The voice spoke again, closer now.

"You will not reach 300 AS."

The sword went still.

For one heartbeat, rain and bell and breathing vanished. There was only the statement, lying between him and the gate.

Korvath's eyes widened. "What did it say?"

Brannoc did not answer.

The voice pressed through the trees.

"You will die in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone."

A soldier dropped his bow.

The bells stopped.

Silence rushed into the yard, vast and immediate. Brannoc felt the prophecy enter him like cold water. It found every hidden chamber: the heirship no crown had acknowledged, the debts no ledger had recorded, the faces of men who had trusted his sword because they could not trust his name.

He looked down at The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The blade reflected no torchlight. It reflected him instead, but not as he stood. In the steel, he wore a crown of dark metal. Blood ran from both his hands. Behind him, something burned beneath a broken throne.

Then the reflection blinked.

Brannoc raised his gaze.

The thing in the trees had come close enough for him to see the pale suggestion of a face beneath the branches.

Not Korvath's.

Not any face born of flesh.

"Open the case," Brannoc said.

The woman stared at him. "Captain—"

"Open it."

Korvath backed away. "You cannot attune to the Edge of Gloamreach here."

"I am not attuning."

"What, then?"

Brannoc turned the key in the lock.

"I'm asking it a question."

The clasps sprang apart.

Inside, beneath layers of oilskin, lay a book bound in something that looked like leather until it breathed.

The pages opened by themselves.

From the forest came a sound like a thousand distant voices inhaling together.

Brannoc leaned over the grimoire.

On the first page, written in ink the color of fresh wounds, were three words.

I REMEMBER YOUR FATHER.

And from beneath the gatehouse floor, something answered by knocking once.

Chapter 11

Rain worried the shutters like a beggar too proud to speak.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed stood beneath the unlit brazier and listened to it scratch at the wood. The chamber smelled of wet wool, lamp oil, and the old mineral stink that rose from the stone whenever the Gloaming Reach turned cold. Beyond the shutters, Fenspire held its silence beneath the dark: the stark spire, the walls, the watchfires burning in disciplined rows. A garrisoned place. A place that had forgotten how to sleep.

Fenspire had been founded in 57 AS. Its garrison was 3,742.

Brannoc knew the number because men made numbers of walls, blades, grain, and bodies. Numbers were the language of those who preferred to kill without looking upon the dead.

He had looked upon enough.

The door opened without a knock.

Korvath Nightbrook slipped through the gap and closed it behind him. He wore a soaked cloak the color of chimney ash, and water shone at the hem. His face had the guarded blankness of a man who lived by moving other men's secrets through places where secrets were not welcome.

"Captain," Korvath said.

Brannoc did not turn. "If you had come bearing good news, you would have brought a candle."

"I brought news."

"Then you brought what you could afford."

Korvath's mouth tightened. He crossed the chamber, keeping to the edge of the lamplight. A smuggler's instinct: never stand where a blade could find you cleanly. He set a leather packet upon the table.

The packet was sealed in black wax.

Brannoc stared at it.

"The mark?" he asked.

"Unbroken."

"That is not what I asked."

Korvath looked toward the shutters. "The mark belongs to the Bleeding Crown."

The rain seemed to stop.

Not outside. Inside him.

Brannoc had carried the Crown's blood as a wound no physician could see. It had been whispered into his childhood, hissed across paid beds, breathed by dying men who mistook him for someone else. Unacknowledged heir, they called him when they wanted to purchase his obedience. Bastard, when they wanted to make obedience sound like mercy.

He was Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed, a major Sellsword Captain, born in 255 AS. The words had been carved into contracts, shouted over battlefields, and muttered in taverns by men who had never met

him. The other truth had never been written where a seal could make it binding.

He was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

That was why men feared him when he was useful and despised him when he was not.

He reached for the packet.

Korvath caught his wrist.

The smuggler's hand trembled. Only slightly. Brannoc noticed because he noticed everything that might precede treachery.

"Not here," Korvath said.

Brannoc looked down at the fingers touching him.

Korvath released him.

"Then where?"

"The room below."

"There is no room below."

"There is always a room below."

Brannoc almost smiled. It would have been a poor thing, that smile. "You have been listening to frightened servants."

"I have been listening to men who know which walls are hollow."

The chamber gave a long, low groan. Somewhere beneath the floor, water moved through a buried channel. Fenspire had been built upon older stone, and older stone had moods. The fortress had endured too much to be trusted.

Brannoc took the packet and broke the seal with his thumb.

Inside lay a strip of vellum and a square of dark cloth. The cloth bore a pale embroidered edge, binding itself back upon itself in a pattern that made the eye ache.

"The Thrice-Bound Edge," Korvath said.

Brannoc lifted the cloth between finger and thumb. It was not a blade, though men spoke of it as though steel slept within the folds. Regalia, the records called it. Forged in 123 AS. Its defining record contained no attunement cost.

No cost.

Brannoc had learned that anything described as costless had merely hidden its price.

"What does it bind?" he asked.

Korvath's gaze fell to the vellum. "That is what the message says."

Brannoc unfolded it.

The writing was narrow and severe.

The Edge of Gloamreach remains in Fenspire.

He read the line again.

A grimoire. Its attunement cost was 46. No forging date was recorded. The name itself seemed to gather the dimness of the chamber: Edge of Gloamreach. Twilight in the shape of a book. A thing that might contain a road, a command, or the final words of someone who had learned too late that knowledge was another form of hunger.

Beneath the first line, another had been written.

Do not let the Ashen Vanguard take it.

Brannoc folded the vellum.

“The Vanguard already holds this fortress,” he said.

“The Ashen Vanguard holds the walls,” Korvath replied. “That is not the same as holding what lies beneath them.”

“Who else knows?”

“House Morvain knows enough to be dangerous. The Silent Choir knows enough to be quiet. The Iron-Ring Cartel knows enough to sell the door.”

“And the Bleeding Crown?”

Korvath’s eyes moved to the black seal on the table. “The Bleeding Crown knows enough to send for you.”

A gust struck the shutters. The lamp flame bent, then recovered.

Brannoc set the cloth beside the vellum. “You carried this through the lines.”

“I carried it through roads.”

“Roads guarded by whom?”

“Men who wanted coin.”

“Everyone wants coin.”

“Not everyone wants to live long enough to spend it.”

Brannoc studied him. Korvath’s cloak dripped onto the floor. Mud clung to his boots. There was blood along his cuff, not enough to be his own unless he had been wounded cleanly. The smuggler had done what smuggling required: he had made himself forgettable while passing through danger.

“How did you enter Fenspire?”

“Through a culvert.”

“The garrison maintains the culverts.”

“Men maintain what they are paid to maintain.”

“And who paid you?”

Korvath’s silence had weight.

Brannoc took the square of dark cloth and wrapped it around his palm. The embroidered edge tightened against his skin, neither warm nor cold. It remembered pressure. That was all. He could feel the restraint in it, the impression of something made to be worn by hands that were not permitted to shake.

“Say it,” Brannoc said.

Korvath looked at the covered hand. “You know what I say changes nothing.”

“Say it.”

“The commander who was meant to close the northern pass has been bribed to withdraw.”

Brannoc’s expression did not move.

The rain returned to the shutters.

The hidden truth of the Accord of Mournthrone was not that courage had failed, nor that the Ashen Vanguard had proved stronger. The losing commander had been bribed to withdraw. That was how victories were purchased: not always with slaughter, but with a purse opened in the dark and a gate left unbarred.

“The amount?” Brannoc asked.

“I was not told.”

“By whom?”

“I was not told that either.”

“You were told enough to find me.”

“I was told the Crown’s heir would understand.”

The word entered the room like a drawn knife.

Brannoc moved before he knew he had chosen to. Korvath struck the table with his hip, and the lamp guttered. In the darkness, Brannoc seized the smuggler by the throat and drove him against the wall.

Stone cracked beneath Korvath’s shoulder.

“Who said that?” Brannoc asked.

Korvath clawed at his wrist. “The message—”

“Who said it?”

“The message.”

“Words do not walk through culverts.”

Korvath’s breath rasped beneath Brannoc’s hand. “Captain.”

The title was wrong. Too soft. Too late.

Brannoc tightened his grip until Korvath’s boots scraped for purchase.

He had killed men for less than a name. He had spared men for less than a reason. Neither act had ever felt like justice. Justice was a word used by those who had not yet been forced to choose which dead deserved remembering.

The lamp steadied.

Korvath's face emerged in the weak light, pale and wet. "If you kill me," he whispered, "the grimoire stays below."

"Then you should have brought a better threat."

"It is not a threat."

"No?"

"It is a lock."

Brannoc held him there.

Far above, a horn sounded from the walls of Fenspire. Its note rolled over the fortress and vanished into the Gloaming Reach. Men would be turning in their watch posts now, tightening straps, lifting spears, looking toward whatever darkness had earned the warning. The place had stood garrisoned for generations. It had watched dynasties rot, banners change, and every promise become a weapon.

The Accord of Mournthrone had begun in 297 AS. It would end in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor. Brannoc knew the shape of the words already, though the war had not finished carving them. He knew, too, what victory would leave behind: a decade of guerrilla reprisals, knives in wells, roofs burned over sleeping families, men hunted beneath names they had not chosen.

A sullen prelude, dressed as peace.

He released Korvath.

The smuggler folded forward, coughing into his hand.

Brannoc turned toward the shutters. "Where is the entrance?"

"Below the old cistern."

"There is no old cistern."

"There is a sealed one."

"Who sealed it?"

Korvath swallowed. "The same people who forged the regalia."

Brannoc looked at the cloth around his hand.

The Thrice-Bound Edge held tight, a dark line across his palm.

"What does the message say about the grimoire?"

"Only that it is there."

"Who has seen it?"

Korvath wiped his mouth. "A servant."

"Name?"

"I do not have one."

"Then what did the servant see?"

“A book on a stone chair. Iron clasps. No dust upon it.”

“Books do not keep themselves clean.”

“This one does.”

Brannoc felt the old dangerous calm settle behind his ribs. It was the calm that came before a charge, before a contract was accepted, before a man discovered that the road ahead had narrowed to a blade’s width.

“Take me to the cistern.”

Korvath did not move.

Brannoc drew his sword.

The steel whispered free.

Korvath stared at it. “There are guards below.”

“There are 3,742 guards above.”

“That is not the same as below.”

“No,” Brannoc said. “It is worse.”

He stepped toward the door.

Behind him, the vellum shifted though no wind touched it.

Brannoc stopped.

On the underside, where the paper had lain against the table, a second line of writing had bled through the fibers. It had not been there before. Or perhaps he had not looked with the right suspicion.

He bent over it.

The words were written in a hand that seemed to withdraw from the eye.

The heir must enter unarmed.

Korvath saw his face change.

“What is it?”

Brannoc turned the vellum toward the lamp.

The Thrice-Bound Edge tightened around his palm until the old scars beneath it burned. Somewhere beneath Fenspire, behind stone and sealed water, the Edge of Gloamreach waited with its attunement cost of 46.

And from below came the sound of a lock beginning to turn.

The lock turned once, stopped, and turned again.

Korvath’s hand went beneath his coat. Not to a weapon—he had been searched before entering Fenspire—but to the small iron pick he kept sewn into the lining, a tool rather than a blade. His fingers closed around it.

Brannoc watched the door.

“Put it away,” he said.

Korvath’s eyes remained on the vellum. “It says the heir must enter unarmed.”

“It does.”

“And you are the heir.”

The word lay between them like a coal no one dared touch.

Brannoc looked down at the Thrice-Bound Edge. The regalia had tightened around his palm with the slow, patient pressure of a living thing. He could feel every old scar beneath it. The band did not shine. It held the lamplight in its dark metal and gave nothing back.

“I carry no sword.”

“You carry that.”

“That is not a sword.”

“Tell the man behind the door.”

A deeper mechanism shifted beneath the floor. Dust fell from the ceiling in a thin, gray veil. Fenspire had been built to withstand siege, fire, and the hatred of men. Its stones remembered pressure. Its corridors narrowed where they should have widened, and widened where a defender could rain death upon an intruder. Even the chamber seemed designed to make a man feel watched by the dead.

Brannoc folded the vellum.

The line vanished.

Korvath leaned closer. “It was written on the underside.”

“I saw where it was written.”

“No. You saw what it said.”

Brannoc raised his gaze.

Korvath’s guarded face had gone still. That stillness was the only fear he ever permitted himself. He had moved contraband through the Gloaming Reach, crossed roads patrolled by the Ashen Vanguard, and sold secrets to the Iron-Ring Cartel without once allowing panic to show in his mouth or hands. Now his thumb worried the iron pick through the cloth.

“Who knew you were coming here?” he asked.

“Enough people.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you are owed.”

The lock gave a final click.

Brannoc slipped the vellum beneath his coat. The motion seemed too loud. Somewhere beyond the door, metal whispered against metal.

Korvath caught his sleeve. “If it is a trap—”

“It is a door.”

“If it is a trap, your name will not save you.”

“My name has never saved me.”

That struck nearer than Brannoc intended. Korvath released him.

The door opened inward.

No guard stood beyond it.

The passage was black from end to end, though the chamber behind them was bright enough to cast two narrow bars of amber across the floor. The air that entered smelled of wet stone and old iron. Brannoc listened. No breathing. No shifting armor. No scrape of a boot.

A voice spoke from the dark.

“Unarmed.”

It was neither a question nor a command. It was an observation made by something that expected the world to obey it.

Brannoc stepped forward.

The Thrice-Bound Edge clenched.

He crossed the threshold.

For one instant, he felt the chamber behind him—the lamp, the table, Korvath’s silence—like a hand at the center of his back. Then the door began to close.

“Korvath,” he said.

The smuggler stood in the amber gap. “Yes?”

“If I do not return—”

“I will not carry a message for you.”

“I was going to say—”

“I know what you were going to say.”

The door shut.

Darkness took the corridor.

Brannoc waited until his eyes made shapes of it: a stair descending, walls wet with seepage, a line of pale mineral caught in the mortar. The passage ran beneath Fenspire, beneath the garrison of 3,742, beneath the rooms where officers of the Bleeding Crown kept their ledgers and sharpened their laws. He had heard the tower described as disciplined vigilance carved into stone. Whoever had built these lower ways had believed vigilance was not enough.

The voice spoke again.

“Proceed.”

Brannoc went down.

Each step was worn in the middle. Water trembled in the joints beneath his boots. The sound traveled ahead of him and returned changed, as though another man descended on the other side of the walls.

He thought of the sentence on the vellum.

The heir must enter unarmed.

Not the captain. Not the sellsword. Not the Red-Handed. The heir.

The title had followed him through every hidden room and blood-soaked camp, though no mouth had dared give it a shape. He was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown, and the Crown had survived by refusing to acknowledge anything that might divide its hunger. He had learned young that a buried claim did not become harmless. It became patient.

At the foot of the stair stood a door of black wood.

No handle. No hinge.

A shallow impression had been cut into its center: three narrow arcs bound together.

The Thrice-Bound Edge grew hot.

Brannoc lifted his hand.

The door opened before he touched it.

Beyond lay a chamber vast enough to swallow the stairwell. Its ceiling disappeared in darkness. Lamps burned along the walls behind red glass, and their light revealed pillars crowded with carved figures. Men kneeling. Women with their faces scraped away. Soldiers bearing crowns that had been broken down the middle.

At the chamber's far end, on a raised platform, rested a stone table.

Something lay upon it.

Brannoc stopped.

The Edge of Gloamreach was larger than he had expected. The grimoire had no visible clasp, no binding, no ornament beyond a dark cover that seemed to have been made from compressed dusk. Fine lines moved across it—not letters, not quite, but the suggestion of writing seen through deep water.

Its attunement cost was 46.

The number had been entered in every surviving account, always without explanation. Forty-six for what? Forty-six of what? No record said. The cost simply waited beside the name like a toll demanded by a road that led nowhere.

He felt the grimoire notice him.

That was absurd. Objects did not notice.

Yet the chamber tightened around his breath.

The voice came from the shadows beside the table.

“You brought the regalia.”

A figure stood there in a hooded robe the color of old ash. Brannoc could see no face. The red lamps behind the figure made the hood appear hollow.

“You summoned me,” Brannoc said.

“No.”

“Then why am I here?”

“You were summoned before you were born.”

The answer irritated him more than it frightened him. He had spent too many years watching men wrap cowardice in prophecy. He had seen the Silent Choir make a sacrament of silence, the Iron-Ring Cartel turn extortion into commerce, and House Morvain call every betrayal necessary once it had been performed. The Ashen Vanguard named itself guardian of what remained, while the Bleeding Crown claimed what remained belonged to it. All five powers carried ruin like a private inheritance.

Brannoc stepped toward the table.

“Who sent the vellum?”

“You read the message.”

“I read a warning.”

“You read an instruction.”

“From whom?”

The hood tilted.

His hand tightened. The Thrice-Bound Edge bit deep enough to draw blood. Warmth slid down his palm.

The figure said, “You have always entered rooms armed.”

Brannoc glanced at his bleeding hand. “I have entered rooms alive.”

“And you believe those are the same condition.”

“No.”

The figure moved to the table. The grimoire remained closed.

“Set down the regalia.”

Brannoc laughed once, without humor. “It is bound to me.”

“Everything is bound to something.”

“Then you knew I could not obey.”

“I knew you would call refusal obedience to your nature.”

The words found the old, hard place in him—the place where the boy born in 255 AS had been buried beneath orders, coin, and the names of men he had killed. He had been shaped into a Sellsword Captain because steel was easier to understand than blood. A captain could be bought, betrayed, dismissed. An heir could not be permitted to know what he was.

He looked at the grimoire.

“What happens if I touch it?”

“The Edge of Gloamreach will decide.”

“And if it decides against me?”

“Then you will learn what remains when a claim is stripped of its claimant.”

Brannoc approached the table.

The red lamps dimmed one by one.

A pressure gathered behind his eyes. He saw, not the chamber, but a road beneath falling ash. He saw the crooked silhouette of Crookvale in The High Spires, its rebuilt walls holding against a sky the color of bruises. He saw the mark of its garrison: 1004 set down in black ink. He saw Fenspire’s stark tower piercing the dimness of the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, still standing because men had mistaken endurance for victory.

Then he saw Mournthrone.

Not its walls. Not its banners.

Only a table, a cup, and a hand sliding payment across a strip of cloth.

The vision broke.

Brannoc staggered. His palm struck the stone.

The grimoire opened.

Its pages turned without wind. Each leaf was blank until it passed beneath the red light. Then words surfaced in lines that crawled and vanished.

A date appeared.

297 AS.

Another followed.

301 AS.

The Accord of Mournthrone.

Brannoc stared as the letters darkened.

The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS and ended in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.

The figure watched him.

“Victory,” Brannoc said.

The page shuddered.

Beneath the word, another sentence formed.

Its collapse unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals.

Then the final truth, written smaller than the rest:

The losing commander was bribed to withdraw.

Brannoc felt the chamber fall away from him. Not because the words surprised him. Because they did not. Somewhere inside the secret, a shape had always waited for him. He had mistaken it for instinct.

“Who paid?” he asked.

The page went blank.

“Who received?”

Blank.

“Why show me this?”

The hooded figure said nothing.

Brannoc lifted his hand from the stone. Blood had marked the table. One red drop slid toward the grimoire and vanished between its pages.

The Thrice-Bound Edge released his palm.

For the first time since he had entered the chamber, he was truly unarmed.

The door behind him slammed shut.

The grimoire began to whisper.

The grimoire began to whisper.

Not in any tongue Brannoc knew. The sound crept through the chamber like rats behind a wall—soft, busy, intent. Its pages turned without wind. Each leaf lifted, shivered, and fell. The parchment was dark at the edges, pale only where the writing had been scraped away.

He watched the book with the patience he had learned from ambushes.

The hooded figure remained beyond the table. Its face was lost beneath the cowl. Its hands, if it had hands, were hidden in its sleeves.

“Open it,” the whisper said.

Brannoc did not move.

The voice came again, though the figure’s mouth did not stir.

“Open the Edge of Gloamreach.”

The title appeared in the page’s center, written in a black that seemed wet. Beneath it, a single line emerged.

Attunement cost: 46.

Brannoc’s jaw tightened.

“I have no sword.”

“You have a name.”

“A name won’t cut a throat.”

“Names have cut deeper things.”

The grimoire’s pages continued turning. The chamber smelled of old dust and iron. Somewhere beyond the sealed door, water struck stone in a slow, measured rhythm. Brannoc thought of Fenspire, though he had never seen it. The name came to him with the taste of ash.

The next page showed a spire rising from a field of darkness.

Fenspire. Gloaming Reach. Founded in 57 AS. Core location. Garrisoned. Garrison: 3,742.

He leaned closer.

The number shifted when he looked at it. Not changing, exactly. Becoming more difficult to disbelieve.

“Why show me this?”

“Because the walls remember what men pay to forget.”

“Fenspire has nothing to do with Mournthrone.”

The grimoire did not answer.

Brannoc laid his bloodied hand on the table. The cut in his palm had stopped bleeding, but the skin around it had gone cold. He could still feel the absence of The Thrice-Bound Edge. It had been regalia, not merely a weapon, and it had rested against his will for so long that its withdrawal felt like the loss of a limb.

The page turned.

The Thrice-Bound Edge. Forged in 123 AS.

No cost followed. No warning. Only the name, standing alone beneath the date like a condemned man beneath a sentence.

Brannoc stared at it.

He had carried the artifact through sieges, betrayals, and the narrow alleys where a man’s life could be purchased for less than a warm meal. He had believed the binding was between himself and the Edge. He had never asked who else had been bound.

The hooded figure moved.

It was no more than a slight inclination of the head, but Brannoc saw it. Permission, perhaps. Or impatience.

He touched the grimoire.

Cold entered him.

The chamber vanished.

He stood on a ridge beneath a sky the color of bruised flesh. Below, a host waited in silence. No banners moved. No fires burned. The soldiers were only shapes, packed shoulder to shoulder, their armor dulled by distance.

Across the valley, another force held the high ground.

He knew the scene. He had lived its aftermath, heard its lies told in taverns and war rooms, watched men who had not been there claim to understand it.

The Accord of Mournthrone.

It had begun in 297 AS. It would end in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor. Between those years lay a ruin no proclamation could mend.

Brannoc saw the commander on the nearer ridge. He could not make out the face. The figure stood before a command table while a purse was set upon the map.

Not thrown.

Not offered.

Set down with care.

The commander looked at the purse. Then at the valley. Then at the troops who trusted the order that would come.

“Who paid?” Brannoc asked.

His voice sounded very far away.

The vision supplied no answer.

A hand closed over the purse.

The commander turned from the map.

Below, horns began to call.

Not an advance. A withdrawal.

The army moved back in disciplined ranks, and the opposing force did not pursue. The valley remained untouched except for the dead who had already fallen waiting for a battle that would never be fought.

Brannoc felt a sickness rise behind his ribs.

He had known the truth as a sentence. Seeing it made it a wound.

The scene broke.

He returned to the chamber on one knee, his palm pressed flat against the grimoire. His breath came harshly. The hooded figure watched him as if watching a dog decide whether to bite.

“The losing commander was bribed to withdraw,” Brannoc said.

The words had been written before his eyes. He had spoken them already. Still, saying them aloud changed their shape.

“Say it,” whispered the Edge of Gloamreach.

“The losing commander was bribed to withdraw.”

The book shuddered beneath his hand.

The door opened.

Not outward. Inward.

A strip of darkness appeared between the stones, thin as a knife’s edge. Cold air flowed through it carrying the smell of wet wool and smoke. Brannoc rose slowly.

A figure stood in the passage beyond. Smaller than the hooded one. Wrapped in a travel-stained cloak. A narrow satchel crossed its chest.

The newcomer stopped when it saw Brannoc.

“K—” the figure began, then swallowed the rest of the name.

Brannoc’s hand went to the place where The Thrice-Bound Edge should have been.

The stranger’s gaze followed the movement.

“You came unarmed,” it said.

“I was disarmed.”

“By the book?”

“By the truth.”

The stranger’s expression remained hidden beneath the hood. Its voice had the guarded flatness of someone accustomed to doors closing behind them.

The hooded figure spoke at last.

“Kro—”

The sound died in the chamber.

Brannoc looked between them. “You know each other.”

Neither answered.

On the table, the grimoire’s pages began to blacken. A new image surfaced beneath the spreading stain: a crooked settlement clinging to high stone, its walls rebuilt upon older foundations.

Crookvale. The High Spires. Founded in 295 AS. Rebuilt. Garrison: 1004. Outside the core holdings.

The stranger stared at the page.

“Who are you?” Brannoc asked.

“Someone trying to leave alive.”

“That makes three of us.”

The stranger’s hand slipped beneath the cloak.

Brannoc shifted his weight. He had no blade, but an empty hand could still crush a throat. The old lessons remained in the body after weapons were taken from it. His fingers flexed.

The stranger drew out a folded strip of cloth.

No weapon. No seal.

A map.

It fell open over the grimoire. Inked lines crossed the parchment in cramped, nervous strokes. One route ran from the High Spires toward the Gloaming Reach. Another ended at a black mark beneath which someone had written a single word.

Mournthrone.

The hooded figure reached toward it.

The stranger recoiled.

“Touch it,” the stranger said, “and it will show him the rest.”

“Show me what?” Brannoc asked.

The page beneath the map pulsed.

A line of writing surfaced, each letter appearing as though pressed up from beneath the parchment by a fingernail.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed. Born in 255 AS.

His name seemed to occupy the whole chamber.

The stranger went still.

The hooded figure lowered its hand.

Brannoc read the next line before it finished forming.

Unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

For one breath, no one moved.

The silence afterward was not surprise. It was recognition. The kind that had been waiting for him in locked rooms, behind lowered eyes, inside the pauses between orders. The kind that made every loyalty a coin held up to the light.

The Bleeding Crown.

He had spent his life hearing the title spoken as if it belonged to a distant plague. A power among powers. One of the five forces contending over the Ashen Era’s broken realm, alongside the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, and the Iron-Ring Cartel.

He had never claimed it.

He had never been acknowledged.

The grimoire turned one final page.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed. Death: 300 AS. During the Accord of Mournthrone.

His heart gave one hard beat.

Then another.

The page did not burn. It did not fade. The words remained, patient and exact.

The stranger whispered, “No.”

Brannoc looked at the hooded figure. “You knew.”

The figure said nothing.

“You knew what I was.”

Still nothing.

“And you knew when I die.”

The hooded head tilted.

The answer was worse than denial.

Brannoc seized the grimoire and slammed it shut.

The chamber convulsed.

Stone cracked beneath his boots. The map flew from the table. The stranger cried out as the door blew inward, and a wind rushed through the room carrying ash, rain, and the distant clangor of bells.

The book bucked in Brannoc’s grip.

Something struck him from inside the cover.

Once.

Twice.

On the third blow, a seam split along the spine.

Beyond it waited not paper, but a red eye opening in the dark.

And from the passage outside came the sound of many feet climbing toward them.

Chapter 12

The record would say that Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed died in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone.

The record would also say he was born in 255 AS, that he had been a major Sellsword Captain, and that he was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

Records had a way of making a corpse seem simpler than a living man.

That night, with the wind dragging its nails along the black stone of Fenspire, Brannoc stood beneath the stark spire and listened to the fortress breathe.

Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach. It had been founded in 57 AS. It was a core location, garrisoned, with a garrison of 3,742. Those figures were carved into the gatehouse in the dry, obedient hand of a clerk. The stone had been polished around them by generations of gloves and palms.

Garrisoned.

The word had no warmth in it. It meant locked gates, rationed grain, watchfires, and men who slept with their boots within reach. It meant that the fortress belonged to whoever could keep it fed and armed. It meant the Reach had not been trusted to itself since the world was broken.

Brannoc touched the iron ring at his belt. The leather creaked beneath his glove.

Beyond the walls, darkness gathered in the ravines. Fenspire's lamps burned in narrow slits, their light thin and yellow against the Gloaming Reach. Somewhere below, a horn gave a single note. It was answered from the outer wall, then from the high watchtower. The sound moved around him like a thought refusing to die.

"Three thousand seven hundred and forty-two," said Korvath Nightbrook.

He sat in the corner where the stone sweated least, hood drawn low. Korvath was a minor figure in the world's great reckonings, though he worked as a Smuggler and had survived by placing his feet in the gaps between lawful things. His presence was unobtrusive by instinct. Even stillness seemed to conceal him.

Brannoc did not look at him. "You count poorly."

"I count what I'm told."

"Then you're a fool."

Korvath's mouth bent, not quite a smile. "That is why I remain alive."

On the table between them lay a sealed packet, a narrow black case, and two objects wrapped in oilcloth. No mark declared who had sent the packet. No mark declared whom it served. That was the virtue of the five powers contending over the ruins: the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the Bleeding Crown all preferred their hands clean when they could persuade another man to soil his.

Brannoc watched the packet.

The Accord of Mournthrone had begun in 297 AS. It would end in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor. Such was the shape of the official account: beginning, struggle, victor. A neat road laid

through mud.

But the Accord would collapse into a decade of guerrilla reprisals, because victories had teeth and the defeated did not always know how to kneel. The hidden truth was uglier still. The losing commander had been bribed to withdraw.

Brannoc knew that much already.

The knowledge had lodged beneath his ribs and made a second heart there.

“Open it,” Korvath said.

Brannoc’s red glove rested beside the packet. The epithet had followed him longer than most men could remember him without it. Red-Handed. It had been spoken with admiration in campfires, disgust in council chambers, and fear in rooms where rich men kept their daughters behind curtains. No canonical physical feature could have defined him better than the name. He was a Sellsword Captain because the world understood steel more readily than blood. He was the heir to the Bleeding Crown because blood understood him.

He broke the seal.

Inside was a strip of vellum, folded twice.

The words were brief.

Mournthrone had not been bought with coin alone. Someone had purchased silence, withdrawal, and the right to call treachery prudence. The payment had moved through hands that would later swear they had never met. The trail ended at a door that did not appear on any map.

Brannoc read it twice.

His first thought was of the Crown.

His second was that the Crown had never been his.

Unacknowledged heirs were useful creatures. They could be pointed at a throne as one pointed a hound at a throat. They could be denied when the hunt went wrong. The Bleeding Crown had given him no name, no seal, no inheritance he could hold in both hands. Only the knowledge, passed in whispers and withheld in public, that his claim existed.

A claim was a blade with no hilt.

Korvath leaned forward. “Is it true?”

“Truth is a coin minted by the hand holding it.”

“I asked whether it was true.”

Brannoc folded the vellum. “You asked because you already know.”

Korvath’s eyes glimmered under his hood. Guarded, wary. The demeanor of a smuggler was not cowardice. It was the discipline of a man who understood that every road had a watcher and every watcher could be bought.

“The message says the withdrawal is arranged,” Korvath said.

“The message says someone believes it is arranged.”

“And if the commander takes the bribe?”

“Then the Accord ends as it began—with men mistaking hunger for strategy.”

Korvath glanced toward the oilcloth. “You brought the regalia?”

Brannoc drew the first bundle nearer and peeled back the cloth.

The Thrice-Bound Edge lay within, dark metal worked into a shape too restrained to be called ornamental. It was regalia, forged in 123 AS. Its defining record contained no attunement cost. The name had been entered into ledgers more carefully than the names of kings, as though binding the words might prevent the object from becoming something else.

Korvath did not touch it.

“Put it away,” he said.

“You were curious.”

“I was curious from a safe distance.”

Brannoc wrapped The Thrice-Bound Edge again. The cloth rasped over the metal like a tongue against a broken tooth.

The second bundle was heavier. He opened it with less care.

Edge of Gloamreach showed no blade at all. It was a grimoire, bound in material that drank the lamplight. Its forging date was not recorded in the supplied facts of any surviving register—if the register had ever existed. The attunement cost was 46. The number had been written on its inner cover in ink that seemed to have faded only where the eye rested upon it.

Brannoc shut the book.

For a moment, something moved in the dark seam between its pages.

He told himself it was the flame.

The thought did not comfort him.

“Why carry those into a garrisoned fortress?” Korvath asked.

Brannoc looked past him, through the narrow window. Fenspire’s walls rose in tiers above the Reach, disciplined and severe. Every tower had a watcher. Every watcher served a power, or believed he did.

“Because everyone here thinks a locked gate is the same as safety.”

“And is it?”

“No.”

The answer came too quickly. Korvath heard it. Brannoc heard him hear it.

In the yard below, soldiers crossed through the torchlight. Their armor flashed and vanished, flashed and vanished. The garrison of 3,742 was a mass reduced to individual footsteps. A fortress could contain an army and still be empty of loyalty.

“Crookvale has sent word,” Korvath said.

Brannoc turned.

“Crookvale?”

“Founded in 295 AS in The High Spires. Rebuilt now. Garrison of 1004. Still outside the core holdings.”

“I know where Crookvale is.”

“Then you know why they are afraid.”

Brannoc did not answer.

Crookvale’s name carried the hard edge of a settlement built twice because the first version had not survived. It was wary and resilient, its governing principle reduced to the oldest commandment: endure what cannot be defeated. The garrison there was smaller than Fenspire’s, but smaller did not mean harmless. A knife did not need a regiment.

“What did they send?” Brannoc asked.

“Nothing. Only a warning.”

“Warnings are what men send when they want credit for courage.”

Korvath shifted. “They say the Bleeding Crown is moving.”

The room seemed to contract around the words.

Brannoc’s hand closed.

He could feel the old claim beneath his glove, beneath his skin, beneath all the years in which he had earned coin instead of titles. The Crown was not a thing one inherited. It was a wound passed from mouth to mouth. Those who bore it bled for those who denied it.

“The Bleeding Crown moves everywhere,” he said.

“Not like this.”

“Who told you?”

Korvath’s gaze slipped toward the door.

The silence after that was answer enough.

Brannoc rose. The chair legs scraped stone. In his bones, the motion was familiar: stand, measure the exits, identify the first throat to cut. The hard dangerous presence of a seasoned sellsword was not something he wore. It had worn him down until only that remained.

From the corridor came the muted tread of boots.

Korvath gathered the packet.

“Stay,” Brannoc said.

“I am a Smuggler. Staying is how I become evidence.”

“You are already evidence.”

The boots stopped outside.

A shadow thickened beneath the door.

Brannoc reached for The Thrice-Bound Edge. Then he paused, his fingers hovering over the wrapped regalia, while the black case on the table seemed to breathe beside the grimoire.

The Accord of Mournthrone had not yet become history. Its beginning lay ahead in 297 AS, its ending in 301 AS, and between those years men would swear oaths they intended to break. The Ashen Vanguard would be named victor. The losing commander would withdraw for a bribe. The collapse would unleash a decade of guerrilla reprisals.

Brannoc knew none of that as a prophecy.

He knew it as the shape of a trap.

The door latch lifted.

Korvath whispered, "Captain."

Brannoc drew steel.

The door opened a finger's width, and a voice on the other side began to say his name—

The voice on the other side began to say his name—

"Brannoc Ironmere—"

He drove the blade through the gap.

The point met something softer than wood. A breath broke against the door, low and wet. Korvath flinched, but Brannoc did not. He held the sword there until the pressure vanished, then wrenched it free.

The door swung inward.

A man stood in the corridor with his back against the wall, one hand pressed beneath his ribs. He wore a servant's grey, though the cloth was too fine for a servant and the boots beneath it had seen road dust, ash, and blood. His face was narrow and bloodless. A strip of black silk covered his mouth.

The Silent Choir.

Brannoc had seen their dead before. They were quieter.

The stranger looked at the sword, then at Brannoc's hand around it. His eyes narrowed with something like recognition.

"Captain," he said through the silk.

"Come in," Brannoc replied. "Or fall out of the way."

The man entered.

Korvath shut the door behind him and set the bar in place. The smuggler kept his gaze low, but his hand had gone beneath his coat. Brannoc knew what lay there. Korvath had carried a knife through three cities and trusted it more than any living soul.

The stranger removed the silk from his mouth. Blood had gathered at the corner of his lips.

"You've made a poor beginning," Korvath said.

"I was invited."

"No one invited you to bleed on my floor."

The stranger's attention remained fixed on Brannoc. "You were told to come alone."

"I came with Korvath."

"You were told—"

"I heard you." Brannoc wiped his blade against the stranger's sleeve. "You chose to speak my name before showing your face. That was your mistake."

The man's jaw tightened. "The order came from Fenspire."

The room seemed to contract around the word.

Outside, wind worried at the shutters. The inn had been built against the ruin of an older structure, and through the walls Brannoc could hear the long complaints of stone settling upon stone. Somewhere below, a cup shattered. No voice rose after it. Even the house knew when to keep quiet.

Korvath glanced toward the grimoire.

The Edge of Gloamreach lay open on the table, its pages black-veined and damp-looking beneath the candlelight. The script along its margins seemed to lean away from the flame. Beside it rested the wrapped regalia, bound in oilcloth and cord.

The stranger saw both.

His face changed.

It was not fear. Fear had movement in it. This was calculation, cold and immediate, the kind a man performed when weighing the value of his life against the value of what might kill him.

Brannoc stepped between him and the table.

"Say what Fenspire wants."

"Not Fenspire." The man glanced toward the shuttered window. "Those who speak through it."

"Then speak through your own mouth."

The stranger swallowed. "The road north is closed."

"By whom?"

"The Ashen Vanguard."

Korvath gave a humorless breath. "They close roads whenever they remember they have soldiers."

"They are searching wagons, rooms, bodies. They have orders to seize anything bearing the old seal."

Brannoc felt the wrapped object behind him like a second heartbeat.

"Which old seal?"

The stranger looked at his hand.

Brannoc's fingers were stained dark beneath the nails. The color never fully left them. Men called him the Red-Handed when they wanted to turn violence into a title, and called him other things when he was close enough to hear. His hand had earned all of it. None of it explained why the sight of his blood made the stranger look toward the regalia.

“Do not make me ask again,” Brannoc said.

The stranger’s mouth twitched. “The seal of the Bleeding Crown.”

Korvath’s knife came free beneath his coat.

The sound was small. It still seemed to fill the room.

Brannoc did not look at him. “You came from Fenspire carrying a warning about the Bleeding Crown.”

“I came carrying a warning about what will happen if the Crown’s claim is found here.”

“What claim?”

The stranger’s gaze lifted again, and this time it held something worse than calculation. Pity, perhaps. Or obedience.

“You know.”

“No.”

“You know enough to wear a dead man’s regalia.”

Brannoc’s hand tightened on the sword hilt.

The wrapped object had been taken from a chamber where dust lay thick as wool over every surface. It had not belonged to him. It had not been given. Things such as that did not pass cleanly from hand to hand. They left residue: whispers, debts, the taste of iron behind the teeth.

He had told himself he carried it because others sought it.

He had told himself many things.

“Leave,” he said.

The stranger stared.

“Go back to Fenspire. Tell them the room was empty. Tell them Korvath sold you a lie. Tell them I took the road south.”

“The road south is watched.”

“Then choose a road that isn’t.”

“You don’t understand.”

Brannoc smiled without warmth. “That is what frightened men say when they want obedience.”

The stranger took a step toward the table.

Brannoc’s sword rose.

Korvath shifted at the same instant, knife angled toward the man’s throat. The stranger stopped with his hand suspended in the air.

For a moment they stood as three pieces on a board none of them had made.

Then the floor beneath them gave a soft groan.

Not the building settling.

Something moved below.

Korvath's head turned. "That wasn't there before."

Brannoc listened.

A scrape passed under the boards, slow and deliberate. Dust sifted from the ceiling. The candle flame bent toward the table, though no wind entered the sealed room.

The Edge of Gloamreach had closed.

Its cover lay shut over the pages, though Brannoc had not seen it move.

The stranger whispered something in a language Brannoc did not know.

Korvath said, "What did you bring with you?"

"Nothing."

"Everyone brings something."

The scrape came again, nearer.

Brannoc looked at the grimoire. The leather cover had begun to sweat a dark sheen. Along its edge, a line of pale symbols showed and vanished, showing and vanishing, as if the book were breathing through its teeth.

He had not touched it since Korvath placed it on the table. He had not dared. The cost of attunement was written in the margin, exact and pitiless: forty-six.

He knew the number.

He did not know what it purchased.

The stranger drew a small object from inside his grey coat. Not a weapon. A shard of blackened bone, threaded on a cord. He held it between finger and thumb.

Korvath went still.

"You know that?" Brannoc asked.

"No."

"Your face says otherwise."

"My face says I dislike the room."

The stranger pressed the bone to his tongue.

The walls answered.

A thin vibration passed through the stone. The candle guttered. From beneath the floor came a muffled knocking, not frantic, not pleading. Patient.

Brannoc felt the old instinct rise in him: measure the exits, identify the weakest throat, decide who died first. It had kept him alive when banners failed and employers discovered principles. It had made men follow him into places from which no honest man returned.

But beneath that instinct another voice stirred.

Not a memory. Memories had edges.

This was inheritance.

The word came to him with the weight of a chain.

He saw, not with his eyes, a crown wet with blood. A hall without windows. Kneeling figures with their faces hidden. The sensation of a hand being placed upon his brow—not gently, not lovingly, but as one might test the edge of a blade.

He blinked.

The room returned.

Korvath was watching him. “Captain?”

“Do not call me that.”

The smuggler’s expression hardened. “You’ve been called worse.”

The stranger lowered the bone. “They’re beneath us.”

“Who?”

“The Choir.”

“Your Choir?”

“They are not mine.”

“Then whose?”

He looked at the sealed grimoire. “The ones who were buried without silence.”

A second knock came from below.

This time the boards lifted.

A black line appeared between them, narrow as a cut. Cold air poured through it, carrying the smell of wet earth and old smoke. The stranger stepped back. Korvath raised his knife.

Brannoc reached for the wrapped regalia.

The cord around it had loosened.

He had tied that cord himself.

The oilcloth unfolded a little beneath his hand, revealing a sliver of metal pale as moonlit bone. No inscription showed. No light clung to it. Yet the sight of it brought pain behind his eyes.

The Thrice-Bound Edge.

Regalia forged in 123 AS.

The name rose from the grimoire’s pages, from the whispered records of men who had murdered for less than a title. He had not known whether the artifact was a weapon, a crown, or a sentence. In that moment it felt like all three.

The stranger said, “Do not draw it.”

Brannoc looked at him.

“Why?”

“Because it will answer.”

“To what?”

The black line in the floor widened.

Something beneath the room exhaled.

The stranger’s bloodless face cracked at last. “To you.”

Korvath seized Brannoc’s shoulder. “We leave.”

Brannoc shook him off. “There’s nowhere to go.”

“There is always somewhere to go.”

“Not when the house is built over a throat.”

The floorboards split with a sound like wet timber breaking. A pale hand rose through the darkness below, fingers groping at the air. Its nails were packed with soil. A strip of black cloth clung to its wrist.

The Silent Choir had sent more than a messenger.

Brannoc drew The Thrice-Bound Edge from its wrappings.

The room went silent.

Not quiet. Silent.

The wind ceased. The inn below ceased. Korvath’s breath vanished. The stranger’s mouth opened, but no sound came from it.

Across the table, the Edge of Gloamreach opened by itself.

Its pages turned with terrible care.

A line of writing appeared in the candleless dark.

Brannoc read it.

His own name had been written there long before he entered the room.

The hand below the floor closed around the edge of the boards. The stranger fell to his knees. Korvath began to move toward the door, but Brannoc caught his sleeve.

“Wait.”

The smuggler looked at him as though he had become something he could no longer sell to anyone.

Beneath them, the buried thing began to speak.

The sound rose through the cracks, shaping itself around a title Brannoc had never accepted and could never escape.

He lifted the regalia higher, and from the dark under the floor came the first clear word—

“—heir.”

The word did not strike Brannoc's ears. It entered him through the soles of his boots and climbed, cold as gravewater, into the marrow of his legs.

Korvath Nightbrook made a sound behind him. Not a prayer. Korvath had never trusted anything that could not be bribed, threatened, or drowned. His hand went beneath his coat, where a knife waited in the dark.

"Do not," Brannoc said.

The buried hand tightened on the floorboard.

The stranger remained on his knees. Candlelight had not returned, yet Brannoc could see the man's face with an intimacy that made the sight obscene: the wet shine of his eyes, the blood at his mouth, the trembling hinge of his jaw.

"Whose heir?" Korvath whispered.

The boards answered.

"Bleeding Crown."

There it was. Not a title spoken by heralds or carved into a gate. A wound given grammar.

Brannoc held The Thrice-Bound Edge in both hands. The regalia was heavier than iron and colder than the dead beneath the floor. Three bands circled its dark length, each joined to the next without seam. He had found no maker's mark upon it, only the old record pressed into its inner face:

Forged in 123 AS.

The numbers had seemed meaningless when he first read them. Now they shone like teeth.

A second line surfaced beneath the first.

No attunement cost.

Korvath leaned close enough for Brannoc to smell rain and old leather on him. "That is not possible."

"Nothing is impossible in a room built over a grave."

"It has a cost."

"Then pay it."

The smuggler's eyes flicked toward him. "You know what it is?"

Brannoc looked down at the regalia. The bands had begun to pulse—not with light, but with a pressure that made the air throb in his throat.

He knew the answer before the voice gave it.

"Name," said the buried thing.

The dark shifted beneath the floor. Somewhere below, something dragged itself across stone. A long scrape. Then another.

Brannoc thought of the names men had given him in alleys, on battlefields, over cups emptied by shaking hands. Captain. Butcher. Red-Handed. He had accepted all of them because a name was a coin, and he had learned young to spend whatever coin lay nearest.

There was one name he had never been permitted to possess.

His mother had died before she could speak it. Men who knew it had looked at him and found reasons to look elsewhere. In the Bleeding Crown's shadow, blood did not make a son. Blood made a threat.

"I am Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed," he said.

The floor groaned.

"No."

Korvath seized his sleeve. "That is enough."

Brannoc tore free. The movement sent a dull ache through his shoulder. "You heard it."

"I heard a corpse trying to make you useful."

"That is most kings."

At the word kings, the buried thing laughed.

Dust sifted from the ceiling. The stranger pressed both palms to the floor as if to hold it shut. His fingers had split at the nails.

"Do you know what waits under a crown?" Brannoc asked him.

The stranger's head turned. "You."

"No."

"Your blood."

"Blood is cheap."

"Not yours."

The answer moved through the chamber like a draft. For one moment Brannoc saw the room as it had been before the rot: stone walls washed white, bronze lamps burning along the ledges, banners hanging from the beams. He saw himself standing at the far end beneath a crown he had never worn. His hands were red to the wrists. Around him, men knelt not from loyalty but from calculation.

Then the vision broke.

The chamber returned. The floor. The stranger. Korvath with his knife half-drawn.

Brannoc breathed through his nose until the tremor passed.

On the wall beside him, dampness gathered in a shape like writing.

Born in 255 AS.

He stared at it.

Korvath read over his shoulder. "What does that mean?"

"My birth."

"You never told me your birth."

"You never asked."

“I ask about cargo.”

“Then consider me badly packed.”

The words formed another line.

Unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

Korvath stepped away from him.

Brannoc felt the withdrawal more sharply than he would have liked. The smuggler had always kept distance, but distance was not the same as fear. Fear had a smell. It sweetened the breath.

“The Bleeding Crown,” Korvath said. “That is not a campfire claim. That is a death sentence.”

“Most useful truths are.”

“You knew?”

“I suspected.”

“You carried suspicion into this place?”

“I carried a sword.”

“You carried us into this place.”

Brannoc turned on him. The regalia lay between them like an accusation. “You followed.”

“I was paid to lead.”

“By whom?”

Korvath’s mouth closed.

The buried thing spoke again.

“Not by the Crown.”

The words were followed by a wet cracking sound from beneath the boards.

The stranger began to weep. Silently. Tears traced pale paths through the grime on his face.

Brannoc looked at the sealed door. It had no latch now. No hinge. Only a slab of stone set into the arch as though the room had decided it preferred them inside.

On the floor near the wall lay the second artifact, its leather cover warped by damp. The title had been stamped in letters that seemed to drink what little darkness surrounded them:

Edge of Gloamreach.

He had thought it a grimoire, nothing more. A book worth more than a month of soldiers’ pay to the right buyer, and worth killing for to the wrong one. The cover shivered without being touched.

Korvath noticed it too.

“Leave it,” he said.

Brannoc crouched. “Its attunement cost is 46.”

The smuggler stared. “You can read that?”

“Someone carved it into the clasp.”

“Then it is not a book.”

“No. It is a debt with pages.”

The clasp opened.

The first leaf was black and soft as skin. No script marked it. When Brannoc bent over it, a smell rose from the page: smoke after rain, and the bitter mineral scent of a place where magic had burned the earth bare.

The room’s darkness gathered over the grimoire.

Images stirred in the blankness.

A highland settlement crouched beneath a white sky, its rebuilt walls crooked against the wind. A watchtower leaned over narrow streets. Men stood beneath its gate with weapons held close, watching every road.

Crookvale.

The name appeared without ink.

Founded in 295 AS. In The High Spires. Rebuilt. Garrison of 1004. Outside the core holdings.

Korvath bent beside him, and the color drained from his face.

“Crookvale,” he said. “That place has changed hands.”

“Has it?”

“Enough times that no hand remains clean.”

The page turned itself.

A spire rose from a gray reach of land, stark and solitary, piercing a sky the color of old bruises. Walls crowded its base. Within them, ranks moved in ordered files. The air around the image seemed disciplined, watchful, unable to sleep.

Fenspire.

Founded in 57 AS. In the Gloaming Reach. Core location. Garrison of 3,742.

Brannoc felt the pressure in the room change. Fenspire had already been named to him once, a place of permanent blades and closed gates, but now the grimoire showed it as something older than the kingdoms that claimed it. The spire did not seem built. It seemed thrust upward by the dead beneath the world.

A third image replaced it.

A throne room split down the middle. Men in ash-colored armor stood behind one standard; figures in dark crimson stood behind another. Between them lay a table bearing a document, its seal broken, its ink running as if the parchment had begun to bleed.

Across the page appeared:

The Accord of Mournthrone. Began in 297 AS. Ended in 301 AS. The Ashen Vanguard named victor.

The image did not settle into triumph.

The commander in crimson stood alone at the table. A hand—not attached to any visible body—placed a small chest before him. He opened it. Gold glimmered within, then vanished beneath the falling shadow of his fingers.

The commander turned away from the field.

Brannoc watched the withdrawal. He understood it with the cold certainty of a wound reopening.

“The losing commander was bribed to withdraw,” he said.

Korvath looked at him. “You say that as if you were there.”

“I say it because the book does.”

Behind the commander, soldiers continued fighting in the image. They did not know the battle had already been sold. They died beneath banners that had become lies.

The page darkened further.

The Ashen Vanguard’s standard remained standing over Mournthrone, but beneath it the land broke into smaller fires. Roads vanished under ambushes. Supply wagons burned. Men hunted men through ravines and ruined villages. The same sword appeared in different hands, passing from one corpse to another.

Text crawled across the black leaf.

Its collapse unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals.

Korvath shut the grimoire.

The pressure vanished. The room seemed suddenly too small to contain their breathing.

“You have seen enough,” he said.

Brannoc kept his gaze on the cover. “No.”

“You have seen what comes.”

“I have seen what may come.”

“You saw your name before you entered.”

“That is different.”

“It is not.”

The voice beneath the floor interrupted them.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

The regalia jerked in his hands.

The three bands unwound.

Not physically. The metal remained whole, yet each ring seemed to open into a separate horizon. In the first, Brannoc stood beneath a blood-colored sky. In the second, he watched men kneel before a crown. In the third, he lay on a stone floor with his own blood spreading beneath him.

The year came last.

300 AS.

His fingers tightened until the regalia cut into his palms.

“During the Accord of Mournthrone,” the buried thing said.

Korvath moved toward the door again. “We are leaving.”

“There is no door.”

“Then we make one.”

“With what?”

“With you, if necessary.”

Brannoc almost smiled. The sound would not come.

The vision sharpened.

He saw a hall drowned in smoke. He saw the marks of the Ashen Vanguard upon the walls. He saw men fighting too close for swords, grappling in the red dark. Someone drove a blade into his side. Someone else held him upright long enough to whisper a word he could not hear.

Then the crown appeared—not above his head, but beneath his corpse.

The Bleeding Crown waited where his blood touched stone.

Brannoc let the regalia fall.

It struck the floor without a sound.

The hand below the boards spread wide. Every finger pressed upward, outlining itself through the wood.

Korvath’s knife was in his hand now. “Say something.”

Brannoc looked at him.

The smuggler’s face had settled into its guarded shape again, but his eyes betrayed him. He was afraid of the room. Afraid of the artifacts. Afraid of the future.

Most of all, he was afraid Brannoc might believe it.

Brannoc understood. Belief was the first chain. Acceptance was the second.

He stepped over The Thrice-Bound Edge and placed his palm upon the boards.

The hand beneath met his.

The contact was gentle.

A warmth entered him—not comfort, but recognition.

The buried thing spoke in his own voice.

“You died in 300 AS.”

Brannoc stared into the dark.

Then the floor began to open.

Chapter 13

Rain worried the shutters of Fenspire as though it had teeth.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed stood beneath the tower's black ribs and listened to the storm gnaw at the stone. Beyond the arrow slits, the Gloaming Reach lay drowned in dusk, its marsh-lights trembling under the rain. Fenspire's stark spire rose through the dimness like a spear driven into the world by a dying god.

The garrison numbered 3,742. Brannoc knew the count because the quartermaster had repeated it three times, each repetition carrying the brittle pride of a man who believed numbers could keep a gate closed. Fenspire was a core location, garrisoned and vigilant, and the men within its walls wore that vigilance as another layer of mail.

It would not save them.

Nothing saved anyone. It only delayed the shape of the ruin.

"You are dripping on the map."

Korvath Nightbrook's voice came from the dark beside the brazier.

Brannoc looked down. Water crawled from his cloak onto the table, gathering in the inked valleys and blackening the parchment. Korvath watched the spreading stain with a smuggler's guarded displeasure. He favored the shadows even when there were none to hide in, his presence unobtrusive, his eyes always measuring the door, the window, the nearest hand that might reach for a knife.

"The map was already wrong," Brannoc said.

"Maps are never wrong. Men are wrong about where they stand."

"That is a distinction fit for a man who sells passage through holes in walls."

Korvath's mouth tightened. "And a sellsword captain is fit to judge the honesty of holes?"

The words settled between them.

Brannoc's hand rested on the pommel at his hip. The knuckles beneath his wet glove were dark with old blood. The rain had not washed it away. Rain was not made for that kind of work.

He had been born in 255 AS, though the Bleeding Crown had never acknowledged the blood in his veins. He was its unacknowledged heir, a secret kept beneath seals, dead tongues, and the obedience of frightened men. A crown could be denied in a cradle and still grow teeth in the dark.

Now the Accord of Mournthrone was eating those teeth.

"Say it," Korvath murmured.

Brannoc lifted his gaze.

"You brought me here to say something."

"I brought you here because the western postern is watched by men who would not recognize you if you were wearing a crown."

"I am not wearing one."

“Not yet.”

The brazier coughed. Smoke crawled low across the chamber, smelling of wet wool and bitter coal. On the far wall, a rack of regalia waited beneath dustcloths. The Thrice-Bound Edge had been forged in 123 AS. Its name was stitched into the inventory slate in a careful hand, followed by a blank mark where no attunement cost had ever been recorded. The object itself was hidden beneath black cloth, restrained even in silence, as if its bindings had learned patience.

Beside it lay the grimoire Edge of Gloamreach.

Its cover was gray as old ash. The attunement cost was 46. Nothing in the records named its forging date. The absence troubled Brannoc more than any number might have. A thing without a beginning was a thing with room for every lie.

He had seen men kill for lesser uncertainties.

Korvath followed his stare. “The books say the grimoire is useless to you.”

“The books say many things.”

“They say the cost is 46.”

“Then the books have counted one burden.”

“And missed the others?”

Brannoc smiled without warmth. “You are learning.”

A bell sounded somewhere below. Once. Then again.

The tower answered with a tremor through the floor.

“Movement at the gate,” Korvath said.

“No.”

The smuggler turned his head.

Brannoc listened. Beneath the rain, beneath the mutter of the garrison and the groan of the old stone, he heard the true sound: not boots advancing, but men leaving their posts. A slow loosening. A withdrawal dressed as caution.

The Accord of Mournthrone had begun in 297 AS, and already every oath spoken beneath it had acquired a hidden price. The Ashen Vanguard named itself the guardian of order. House Morvain called order the property of the strong. The Silent Choir listened for weakness in every vow. The Iron-Ring Cartel measured loyalty by what it could carry. The Bleeding Crown waited behind its curtains and let other hands bleed for its inheritance.

Five powers, all sharpening the same knife.

“Your commander is pulling back,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s eyes narrowed. “You know that?”

“I know the sound of a coward trying to make retreat resemble strategy.”

“You were told there would be no withdrawal.”

“I was told many things.”

“By whom?”

Brannoc looked again at the covered regalia, the blank cost, the nameless forging. “By men who believed a sealed order could command the dead.”

The door opened.

A soldier entered with rain shining on his shoulders. No herald announced him. No servant took his cloak. His face held the pallor of someone who had received news and decided not to understand it.

“The western barricade has been abandoned,” he said.

Korvath gave a small, humorless laugh. “There. Now we have the truth.”

Brannoc did not move. The soldier’s gaze dropped to his red-stained hand, then rose again.

“Who ordered it?”

The man swallowed. “The order bore the commander’s seal.”

“Did the commander give it?”

“I was not present.”

“Then you know nothing.”

“I know the men were paid.”

The rain pressed harder against the shutters.

Korvath stepped near the brazier. “Paid by whom?”

The soldier’s silence was answer enough. In the walls of Fenspire, it seemed every stone leaned closer to hear.

Brannoc felt the old inheritance stir beneath his ribs—not pride, not hope, but the cold recognition that the world made room for crowns only after they had been fed enough corpses.

“The losing commander was bribed to withdraw,” he said.

The soldier flinched as though Brannoc had struck him.

Korvath’s eyes became two dark slits. “You say that as if you expected it.”

“I expected a price. I did not know its shape.”

“And now?”

“Now I know the shape is treason.”

“No,” Korvath said. “Treason is a word used by the poor to describe a bargain they were not invited to join.”

Brannoc turned on him. “Be careful.”

“I am always careful. That is why I am still alive.”

The words carried no boast. Korvath said them as one might name the weather.

Below, the bell rang a third time.

This time the tower doors groaned open.

Brannoc crossed to the nearest slit. Far beneath him, torches moved through the rain in a disorderly stream. Men were leaving Fenspire. Some carried packs. Some carried weapons. One carried a bundle that sagged with a human weight. No one looked upward.

At the edge of the courtyard, the insignia of the Ashen Vanguard passed beneath a veil of rain.

Brannoc's reflection hovered in the glassless opening: a broad darkness, a scarlet hand, a face the stone refused to give back. He had no canonical feature for the world to remember. Let it remember the epithet instead. Let it remember the martial station, the hard presence of a Sellsword Captain, the hand that had closed around too many hilts and too few promises.

Korvath came to stand beside him.

"What will you do?"

"Stay."

"Why?"

"Because the men leaving will tell themselves they chose to survive. I want them to see what survival costs."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one I have."

"You are the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown."

Brannoc's fingers tightened around the pommel.

Korvath continued, softly now. "You cannot keep pretending this is merely a contract."

"I have never pretended."

"You have worn hired steel while others fought over your blood."

"And what would you have me wear?"

"A claim."

"A claim is a blade with no handle."

"Then grasp it by the edge."

Brannoc looked at him. Korvath's guarded face had lost its smuggler's calm. For the first time, the man seemed afraid—not for himself, but of what Brannoc might do if fear became indistinguishable from purpose.

Outside, the last of the torches vanished through the gate.

Fenspire remained.

Its garrison of 3,742 had become a number without a body. The walls remained disciplined, vigilant, and nearly empty of the certainty that had held them. Somewhere in the lower levels, locks were being opened. Somewhere else, men were deciding which allegiance would forgive them most cheaply.

Brannoc took the dustcloth from The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The regalia beneath was darker than iron and bound in three narrow bands. No attunement cost marked its record. The absence seemed to watch him.

Korvath stepped back. “Do not.”

“Do not what?”

“Touch what you cannot unmake.”

Brannoc laid his red hand upon the hilt.

The chamber went still.

For an instant he felt the whole Accord of Mournthrone gathered inside the metal: its beginning in 297 AS, its broken vows, its banners lowered by hands bought in secret. He saw no victory in it. The Ashen Vanguard might be named victor when the accord ended in 301 AS, but victory was a word men carved over graves to stop the graves from speaking.

The truth rose through the binding like a drowned thing.

The Accord of Mournthrone had collapsed into a decade of guerrilla reprisals.

Brannoc drew one breath.

Then something struck the door below, and Korvath whispered, “They are coming for you—”

The second blow shook dust from the lintel.

Korvath flinched. Brannoc did not. He kept his hand upon The Thrice-Bound Edge and felt the metal drinking the tremor from his bones. Beneath his palm, the regalia was cold enough to burn. Its forged silence pressed against him, threefold and patient, as if the blade had been waiting for a hand that would not mistake restraint for mercy.

“Which door?” Brannoc asked.

“The only one they need.”

Korvath’s voice had gone thin. He stood beside the shuttered window with one hand inside his coat, where a smuggler kept the things he trusted least. The room smelled of damp wool, lamp oil, and the bitter mineral tang rising from the grimoire open upon the table.

Edge of Gloamreach had no cover. Its pages lay exposed to the air, black leaves veined with grey script. The book’s attunement cost was 46, and the knowledge of it had settled into Brannoc’s skull with the weight of a nail. Every time his gaze touched the open page, the letters seemed to lean toward him.

Another blow.

The hinges cried.

Brannoc lifted his hand from The Thrice-Bound Edge. A red print remained upon the metal. His blood, or the memory of it. With the binding, the distinction had become a poor man’s argument.

“Can you get us out?”

Korvath looked toward the floor.

“No.”

“Then why are you still standing?”

“I was waiting for you to say something clever.”

“I have never said anything clever.”

“That is why I am afraid.”

The door shuddered in its frame. A splinter fell inward and struck the flagstones. Through the crack came a blade of pale corridor light, and within it the moving darkness of someone’s shoulder.

Brannoc turned to the table.

The page had changed.

He had seen no hand touch it. No wind moved in the sealed room. Yet the ink had gathered itself into a line beneath the older script, each mark wet and shining.

Fenspire.

The word stood alone for a breath, then was followed by another.

The Purge of Blackport waged at Fenspire in 319 AS.

Brannoc read it twice.

The room fell away.

He stood beneath a sky the color of old bruises. A spire rose before him, stark and narrow, its upper reaches swallowed by Gloaming Reach mist. The stones of Fenspire were dark with rain. Not red. Rain, he told himself. The mind reached for blood because blood was easier to understand.

Men moved through the streets with covered mouths. Their hands were wrapped in ash-colored cloth. Doors hung open. Behind one, a bowl rolled slowly across a floor and came to rest against a threshold.

Brannoc heard no cries.

That was the worst of it.

Silence made a city complicit with its own ruin. It turned every wall into a witness and every shutter into a closed eye. Far above, something struck the spire bell, but the sound did not descend. It remained trapped in the clouds, trembling there like a thought no one dared complete.

He felt Fenspire’s garrison around him—not as bodies, but as a pressure. Disciplined vigilance sunk into every stone. Permanent occupation had given the place a second skeleton. Men could be slain. Orders could be burned. The garrison remained in the walls.

Then the vision twisted.

Blackport appeared in the rain.

Not as a place, but as a wound carried from hand to hand. Its name was carved into doors, scratched into helmets, whispered by mouths that immediately shut. Brannoc saw the purge not from above, nor from the street, but from inside the instant before a man made a choice.

A torch rose.

A child's cup broke.

Someone behind a door pressed both hands over their lips.

Then the room returned.

Brannoc staggered against the table. Edge of Gloamreach groaned beneath his fist. The pages fluttered though the shutters remained closed.

Korvath caught his sleeve.

"What did you see?"

"Fenspire."

The smuggler's grip tightened. "That means nothing."

"It will."

The door gave another inch. A dark iron hook appeared through the gap and caught the inner brace. The wood splintered around it.

Korvath swore softly.

Brannoc stared at the grimoire. The letters were fading now, sinking into the black page as though ashamed of what they had said.

"Who is behind that door?"

"People who have been paid to believe they are righteous."

"House Morvain?"

"I did not say that."

"The Silent Choir?"

"I did not say that either."

"The Iron-Ring Cartel?"

Korvath's eyes hardened. "You have a gift for naming enemies after they have already found us."

Brannoc reached for his sword. The grip came easily, familiar as a scar. His other hand remained red, whether by blood or binding no longer mattered. The Thrice-Bound Edge lay upon the table between them, regalia rather than weapon, though the distinction had always depended upon who was holding it.

A voice spoke through the broken door.

"Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed."

His name sounded wrong in that mouth. Not feared. Not respected. Catalogued.

Korvath moved toward the window. "There."

The shutter was fastened from within, but its lower hinge had rotted away. Beyond it waited a narrow drop into darkness. Korvath knelt and tested the opening with his fingers.

"Can you climb?"

“Can you?”

“I asked first.”

Brannoc looked down at his boots. The room seemed to sway under him. He had commanded men in rain that turned bowstrings slack. He had watched banners lowered by hands bought in secret. He had carried the truth of Mournthrone inside his chest while others carved victory over the dead and called the carving history.

Now a smuggler was asking whether he could climb.

“Yes.”

Korvath gave him a bitter smile. “Good. I hate rescuing corpses.”

The brace split.

The door opened three fingers wide.

A hand entered first, armored to the wrist. It held no weapon. That unsettled Brannoc more than a sword would have. Men came to kill with steel. Men came to arrest with empty hands. Empty hands belonged to courts, crowns, and those who believed their violence would be forgiven.

Brannoc seized The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The room darkened.

The regalia did not blaze. It did not sing. It tightened the air around his fingers until his bones felt laced together. The pressure climbed his arm, crossed his shoulder, and settled behind his eyes.

A second vision opened.

He saw a hall beneath Fenspire. Stone pillars. Damp flags. A row of kneeling figures facing a wall. No faces. The absence was deliberate.

At the end of the hall stood a throne-shaped chair draped in black cloth.

Someone had placed a crown upon it.

Not worn. Waiting.

Brannoc felt the old wound inside himself stir—the claim never spoken where it could be answered, the bloodline left unacknowledged, the inheritance that had taught him to sleep with one hand beneath his pillow. The Bleeding Crown had never called him son. Crowns did not call. They summoned, and men mistook the summons for honor.

The vision showed him the crown beneath the cloth.

Then it showed him fire.

Brannoc tore himself free.

The table overturned. Edge of Gloamreach struck the floor, its pages snapping open to a spread of blank blackness. Korvath cursed and shoved the window wider.

“Hurry.”

The door burst inward.

Three figures crowded the gap. Their faces were hidden behind ash-colored masks. The first carried a short sword. The second bore a hooked pole. The third held a sealed tube against his chest.

Brannoc stepped between them and the table.

The first figure crossed the threshold.

Brannoc's sword met his.

Steel cracked against steel. The masked man's wrist buckled. Brannoc turned the blow aside and drove his shoulder into the man's chest. He went backward into the others, and for one breath the doorway became a knot of limbs and cloth.

"Now," Korvath said.

Brannoc seized the sill.

The drop below was black, though he could make out the glimmer of wet stone. Wind climbed the wall and entered his sleeves. Behind him, the attackers disentangled themselves. One of them shouted his name again, but this time the voice carried fear.

Brannoc lowered himself through the opening.

His boots found the outer ledge.

Korvath came after him, clutching the grimoire under one arm. The book's pages beat against his ribs like trapped wings.

"Give me your hand."

Brannoc looked up.

The first masked figure had reached the window. Rain shone on the blade in his grip. Behind him, The Thrice-Bound Edge lay on the floor, still gathering the room into its silence.

Korvath stretched down.

Brannoc reached for him.

And from within the chamber, beneath the splintered door and the footfalls rushing nearer, the grimoire began to speak in a voice made of turning pages—one word at a time, each syllable carrying the cold of a future Brannoc had not yet lived.

Korvath's fingers closed around his wrist.

The grimoire spoke again.

"Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed."

The name entered the rain and seemed to weigh it down.

Korvath hauled him upward. Brannoc struck the ledge with his shoulder, rolled across the wet stone, and came up on one knee. The window behind them flared with a pallid light. For an instant the chamber showed itself through the opening: the masked figure at the sill, the blade lifted, the door bowing inward beneath the men beyond it.

Then the darkness folded shut.

Korvath seized the back of Brannoc's coat and dragged him along the ledge.

"Move."

"I am moving."

"You are listening."

"Hard not to."

The grimoire's voice followed them through the storm.

"Born in 255 AS."

Brannoc's hand found the wall. The stone was slick with rain and old soot. Below, the drop vanished into blackness. Somewhere beneath that blackness, water hammered rock with the patient violence of a thing that had never needed to hurry.

Korvath pressed himself against the outer face of the tower. His breath came thinly. A smuggler survived by distrusting open ground, open doors, and every silence that seemed too complete. Now there was nowhere to conceal himself but the rain.

"Do you hear it?" Brannoc asked.

"I hear men behind us."

"The book."

"I hear that too."

"Then why are you still carrying it?"

Korvath looked at him. Rain ran from his brow into his eyes, giving his expression the shine of grief.

"Because you told me to."

"I told you to bring it out."

"And now it is out."

The grimoire rested beneath Korvath's arm, bound in leather darkened by water. Its pages stirred without wind. Each turn made a dry, intimate sound, like a tongue passing over teeth.

Brannoc reached for it.

Korvath jerked away. "No."

"You cannot carry it and climb."

"I can carry it."

"You are shaking."

"I am a smuggler. Shaking is how I keep my hands honest."

Behind them, wood split. A masked face appeared at the window, pale beneath its covering. The figure thrust an arm through the opening and swept the blade along the ledge. Steel rang against stone where Brannoc's throat had been.

He drove his boot into the hand.

The fingers vanished. The blade clattered away into the dark.

“Climb,” Brannoc said.

A rope ladder hung below the ledge, its wet rungs tapping against the tower. Korvath lowered himself first, pressing the grimoire to his ribs. Brannoc followed, one hand on the rope, one gripping the wall. The tower leaned out over the ravine. Every gust shifted the ladder beneath them.

From above came a cry, then another. The men in the chamber had found the window.

Brannoc descended.

His palms burned. Rain soaked his sleeves and found the old cuts beneath them. The dark below had no bottom. He had known worse places. He had made camp in worse places. He had slept with a knife under his tongue while men negotiated the price of his next sunrise.

But he had never feared a book.

The Edge of Gloamreach whispered.

“Unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.”

Korvath halted below him.

The ladder swung out from the wall.

Brannoc’s boot struck Korvath’s shoulder. “Keep going.”

“You heard it.”

“Keep going.”

“You are—”

“Keep going.”

Korvath obeyed, though obedience sat badly upon him. He descended until his boots met a narrow shelf of stone. Brannoc joined him. The shelf ran around the tower, scarcely broad enough for a man’s foot, and ended at a seam in the rock where darkness breathed cold air.

A passage.

Korvath placed one hand against the seam. “This was not on the plan.”

“There was a plan?”

“There was always a plan.”

“Then your plan has improved.”

He pushed. The stone gave inward, revealing a cleft. Brannoc entered sideways, shoulders scraping grit from the walls. Korvath followed with the grimoire held above the water gathering at the floor.

The passage narrowed, then opened into a low chamber beneath the tower. Rain dripped through the ceiling. The air tasted of iron and wet ash.

Korvath set the book down.

It opened by itself.

The pages were blank for a breath. Then ink rose from the fibers in thin black threads, arranging itself into lines.

“Forged in 123 AS.”

Brannoc stared.

The Thrice-Bound Edge lay far above them, still inside the chamber they had fled. He could feel its silence through the stone: a pressure without weight, a restraint that seemed to bind not flesh but intention. Regalia, the record had called it. The name had sounded ceremonial when first they found it.

Nothing ceremonial had ever looked at him that way.

Korvath leaned close to the page. “What was forged?”

“The Thrice-Bound Edge.”

“Regalia,” Korvath muttered. “That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one the book gives.”

Another line appeared.

“No attunement cost.”

Korvath rubbed his mouth. “That should comfort me.”

“It does not comfort you.”

“It is not trying to.”

Above them, boots crossed the chamber floor. Dust sifted down. The masked figures had reached the stair or found another way around. Brannoc imagined the blade in one of their hands, wet with rain, searching the dark by instinct.

He looked at the grimoire. “What does it want?”

Korvath gave a humorless smile. “You ask that as though it has manners.”

The page turned.

“Attunement cost: 46.”

The words were written beneath the name Edge of Gloamreach.

Korvath took a step back.

Brannoc felt the number settle inside him. Not as knowledge. As a hook.

“Forty-six what?” Korvath said.

“The book does not say.”

“Then it may say anything.”

“It has not.”

“It has named you.”

Brannoc looked down at his hands. In the weak light, the water on them appeared dark. His epithet had followed him through camps, courts, alleys, and battlefields: the Red-Handed. Men gave it to him because they needed a story that did not include the things he had done before they met him. It was easier to blame the color than ask where it came from.

The Edge of Gloamreach turned a page.

“Accord of Mournthrone.”

Brannoc’s jaw tightened.

Korvath whispered, “Do not read it.”

The book wrote on.

“Begins in 297 AS.”

The chamber seemed to contract. Even the dripping stopped, listening.

“Ends in 301 AS.”

Korvath reached for the cover.

Brannoc caught his wrist. “Let it speak.”

“It is speaking of war.”

“It is speaking of what comes.”

“That is worse.”

The ink gathered in a thick black pool before forming the next words.

“Ashen Vanguard named victor.”

Brannoc released Korvath.

For a moment he saw a field beneath a colorless sky, though no such field lay beyond the chamber. He saw banners dragged through mud. He saw men kneeling because the alternative was to remain standing before those who had won. He saw the five powers tightening their hands around the realm: the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the Bleeding Crown.

The names were not merely factions. They were appetites wearing heraldry.

Korvath read them over his shoulder. “The Ashen Vanguard wins.”

“The book says so.”

“Books lie.”

“Not when they are frightened.”

Korvath looked at him sharply.

The grimoire’s pages trembled.

“The losing commander bribed to withdraw.”

Neither man spoke.

Above, the pursuit had gone quiet. That silence was worse than the boots. The masked figures were searching now, and searchers were patient when they believed the world had already closed around their prey.

Korvath bent over the grimoire. “Who?”

The ink did not answer.

Brannoc felt the old pressure behind his ribs, the one that came whenever someone spoke of crowns as though crowns were objects instead of wounds. The Bleeding Crown had never acknowledged him. It had not needed to. Blood kept its own account.

The page turned.

“Died in 300 AS.”

Brannoc’s fingers tightened.

Korvath lifted his head.

“During the Accord of Mournthrone.”

The words remained.

Brannoc read them again. The rain, the stone, the passage, Korvath’s drawn face—all of it slipped away beneath the clean simplicity of the sentence.

Died in 300 AS.

He found himself searching for the loophole. Books had loopholes. Priests had loopholes. Kings had entire armies of men dedicated to discovering them. Perhaps “died” meant a name buried, a claim extinguished, a man made dead in the eyes of those who required him absent.

Korvath said, “It could mean someone else.”

“It used my name.”

“It could be a warning.”

“It used the past tense.”

The grimoire wrote again.

“Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

His own name seemed smaller the second time.

Then, beneath it:

“Unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.”

Korvath’s face changed. Fear remained, but something older moved beneath it: calculation, the instinct that had made him a smuggler rather than a corpse. He glanced toward the passage mouth.

“Who else knows?”

Brannoc looked at him.

“About the Crown,” Korvath said. “About you.”

“The book knows.”

“I did not ask what the book knows.”

“You were not meant to.”

“I was not meant to carry it either.”

A dull impact shook the stone behind them.

The hidden door.

Another impact. Grit sifted from the ceiling. The seam brightened with a blade of gray light.

Korvath snatched up the Edge of Gloamreach. “There.”

Beyond the chamber, a stair descended into blackness. No sound came from it. No rain. No pursuit. Brannoc could smell cold earth and something bitter, like ash left in a dead hearth.

The book writhed under Korvath’s arm.

“Crookvale.”

The name was followed by a map, ink spreading across the page in crooked lines.

“Founded in 295 AS.”

The stair seemed to tilt beneath Brannoc’s boots.

“In The High Spires,” Korvath read.

The hidden door shuddered again.

“Rebuilt.”

“Garrison of 1004.”

Korvath stared at the number.

Brannoc saw the calculation return to his eyes, sharper now. A garrison was not safety. It was a locked jaw. A hundred doors, a thousand watchful hands, orders carried through barracks and towers. A place outside the core holdings could survive only by suspecting everyone who approached it.

The grimoire finished the line.

“Outside the core holdings.”

The door behind them cracked. A sliver of masked metal appeared in the gap.

Korvath shoved the book at Brannoc. “You carry it.”

Brannoc caught it against his chest. The leather was warm.

“What is in Crookvale?”

“Nothing good.”

“You know it?”

“I know enough to avoid it.”

“Then we go there.”

Korvath seized his sleeve. “That was not an invitation.”

The book opened against Brannoc’s heart.

“Fenspire.”

Its pages filled with a stark black tower surrounded by smaller marks, each one a waiting blade.

“In the Gloaming Reach.”

“Founded in 57 AS.”

“Garrison of 3,742.”

“Garrisoned status.”

The last words appeared slowly, as though pressed into the page by an invisible thumb.

Korvath whispered, “No.”

Brannoc felt the name draw him harder than the darkness below. Fenspire. A core location. A permanent military throat in the dim reaches, disciplined and vigilant, built around a spire that had endured while other things were broken and forgotten.

The hidden door burst inward.

A masked figure lunged through the opening.

Brannoc struck him with the grimoire.

The impact sounded like a bell beneath deep water. The figure folded. The mask struck stone and split.

Korvath was already descending the stair.

Brannoc followed, the grimoire clutched in both hands. Behind him, the broken door filled with bodies. Ahead, the dark opened wider.

On the page, beneath the name Fenspire, new ink began to crawl.

Not a place.

Not a date.

A sentence.

Brannoc read it as he descended.

“Bring the heir to the tower, and the dead will learn to speak.”

Chapter 14

The rain came sideways over Crookvale, needling the shutters and turning the yard below into a black mirror.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed stood without his cloak, listening to the fortress breathe around him. Stone settled in the walls. Iron groaned in its sockets. Somewhere beneath the keep, a horse struck its stall with one impatient hoof, and the sound climbed through the floor like a warning from the buried dead.

Crookvale had been founded in 295 AS, though the oldest stones in its rebuilt walls had been cut long before that year. They did not fit cleanly. Nothing in Crookvale fit cleanly. Its towers leaned into the mountain wind, its gates closed with the reluctance of old jaws, and its garrison of 1004 watched the high passes with the exhausted suspicion of men who expected the world to come crawling out of the snow.

The settlement remained outside the core holdings. That was how the ledgers described it.

Ledgers had never slept beneath a roof that shook when the peaks spoke.

Brannoc rested one red hand upon the table. The other remained near the sword at his hip, not because he expected an attack, but because expectation had become a second pulse in him. The scarlet stain across his knuckles was old wine, not blood. He had washed the blood away before entering the room.

The name had stayed.

The Red-Handed.

He had earned it too many times to resent it.

“Your rain has teeth,” Korvath Nightbrook said.

The smuggler crouched beside the shutter, narrow in the dark, favoring the unobtrusive presence of a man accustomed to concealed trade. His coat was wet to the elbows. Water dripped from him onto the rushes, darkening them one by one.

“Crookvale is not mine.”

“No.” Korvath glanced toward the table. “Neither are the things you brought me.”

Brannoc looked down.

The Thrice-Bound Edge lay wrapped in a square of oilskin. Even hidden, it possessed the stillness of regalia. Its name had been written three times on the inventory, each line in a different hand, as if the scribes feared a single inscription might fail to hold it. Forged in 123 AS, it had no attunement cost recorded against it.

Beside it rested the Edge of Gloamreach, a grimoire bound in material that drank the candlelight. Its attunement cost was 46. Its forging date was not recorded in the supplied facts, though whoever had made it had known enough of dusk to give the pages a color like bruised twilight.

Korvath would not touch either.

“Those are not meant for a table,” he said.

“Then stop looking at them.”

“I am looking at the door.”

“You have been looking at the door since you arrived.”

“That is why I am alive.”

Brannoc’s mouth tightened. He had known men who mistook caution for courage, and men who mistook fear for wisdom. Korvath did neither. He carried his wariness openly, like a knife kept under the tongue.

Outside, a bell sounded once.

Not an alarm. A watch-change signal.

Crookvale’s garrison moved in the rain. Boots crossed the inner yard. Metal struck metal. Orders passed from mouth to mouth and dissolved beneath the weather.

“The five powers are moving,” Korvath said.

“The five powers are always moving.”

“The Ashen Vanguard has sent riders into the high roads. House Morvain has bought grain where there is no grain to buy. The Silent Choir is asking questions without speaking them. The Iron-Ring Cartel has closed three routes and opened two others for a price. And the Bleeding Crown—”

“Do not say it as if it were a fifth thing.”

Korvath’s gaze shifted from the door to Brannoc.

“The Bleeding Crown is a fifth thing.”

Brannoc felt the words enter him with the slow, cold force of a blade.

He had spent his life being a fact that could not be spoken aloud. An unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown: blood without witness, inheritance without a seal, a crown reflected in a dark basin and denied whenever he reached toward it.

His fingers curled.

The table creaked under his hand.

“Do you know what happens to men who carry messages like that?” he asked.

“They become important.”

“They become dead.”

Korvath gave a small shrug. “Sometimes both.”

The rain hissed along the shutters. Brannoc imagined the world beyond the room: the crooked towers, the mountain roads, the snow gathering in the cuts of the stone. He imagined Fenspire, far away in the Gloaming Reach, standing beneath its stark spire with its 3,742 soldiers behind walls that had never learned the meaning of sleep. Fenspire had been founded in 57 AS. It was a core location, garrisoned and disciplined, a hard tooth in the dim mouth of the Reach.

Crookvale was wary.

Fenspire was vigilant.

The difference between them was not courage. It was what the realm had decided was worth defending.

Korvath took a folded strip of parchment from inside his coat. He did not offer it. He held it between two fingers and watched Brannoc watch him.

“The Accord of Mournthron began in 297 AS,” he said. “It has not ended.”

“It has a name,” Brannoc replied. “That is not the same thing.”

“The record says it will end in 301 AS.”

“The record says many things.”

“With the Ashen Vanguard named victor.”

Brannoc looked at the parchment. “And what does the record say about the dead?”

Korvath’s expression did not change. “The record is less interested in them.”

A gust struck the keep. The flame of the nearest candle bowed almost flat, recovering only after a moment. On the wall, Brannoc’s shadow stretched toward the door with its hand at the throat of some unseen man.

The Accord of Mournthron had the shape of a broken promise. Every faction spoke of settlement, and every faction measured the distance to the next throat. The Ashen Vanguard called itself order. House Morvain called itself blood. The Silent Choir called nothing by any name. The Iron-Ring Cartel weighed every allegiance against profit. The Bleeding Crown waited beneath all of them, patient as rot under paint.

Brannoc knew what the others saw when they looked at him: a major Sellsword Captain, useful in a siege, dangerous in a negotiation, purchasable until proven otherwise.

They did not see the crown in his shadow.

They saw the red on his hands and assumed they understood its source.

“Read it,” Korvath said.

“Read it yourself.”

“I cannot.”

“Why?”

“Because it is written in a hand that does not forgive mistakes.”

Brannoc reached for the parchment.

The writing was cramped, pressed hard enough to score the fibers. No seal marked it. No signature named its author. Still, the meaning stood clear.

The losing commander had been bribed to withdraw.

Brannoc read the sentence twice.

The room seemed to draw inward. The rain became distant. Even the garrison outside went silent, though he knew the men had not stopped moving.

“Where did you get this?” he asked.

Korvath’s mouth twitched. “You asked me to move a thing through a locked gate. You did not ask me to become innocent.”

“If this is false—”

“Then the Accord remains what everyone believes it is.”

“And if it is true?”

“Then the Ashen Vanguard will be named victor over a corpse someone else purchased.”

Brannoc folded the parchment. “Who was paid?”

Korvath did not answer.

“Who paid him?”

Still nothing.

Brannoc lifted his eyes. “You smuggle secrets. Do not pretend you have no cargo.”

“I have cargo enough to drown in.”

“You brought this here.”

“I brought it because you are the sort of man who understands the value of an ugly truth.”

“No. I am the sort of man who understands the value of a sharp one.”

He laid the parchment beside the Edge of Gloamreach. The grimoire’s cover seemed to darken beneath it.

Korvath finally crossed the room. He kept one hand tucked beneath his coat and the other held open, empty. Near the artifacts, he stopped.

“The Thrice-Bound Edge,” he murmured. “Regalia forged in 123 AS. No attunement cost.”

“You memorized the inventory.”

“I memorized the danger.”

“And the grimoire?”

“Edge of Gloamreach. Attunement cost 46. No forging date recorded.”

“Then you know what you are carrying.”

“I know what I am refusing to carry.”

Brannoc unwrapped the regalia.

The room changed.

There was no flash, no voice from beyond the world. Only a pressure, subtle as a thumb against the breastbone. The iron fittings in the shutters trembled. Korvath stepped back. Brannoc did not.

The name of the artifact seemed to draw every other name toward it: Crookvale, Fenspire, Mournthrone, the Ashen Vanguard, the Bleeding Crown. Names gathered like wolves around a wounded thing.

He thought of 255 AS, the year of his birth. A year no one had marked in a royal register. A year given to him by a confession made too late and beneath a roof where the candles had burned blue.

He thought of 300 AS, the year in which he would die during the Accord of Mournthrone.

The knowledge had never come to him as prophecy. It was simply there now, cold and immovable, as if the future had left a weapon in his hands and expected him to choose whether to use it.

Korvath saw something in his face.

“What is it?” the smuggler asked.

Brannoc closed his hand around the Thrice-Bound Edge.

The pressure vanished.

Below them, the bell sounded again.

This time, the gate was opening.

Korvath turned sharply. “That is not a watch-change.”

“No.”

“Who is coming?”

Brannoc looked toward the shutter. Through a narrow gap, torchlight moved in the yard below—too many flames, held too evenly against the wind.

He did not know who was coming.

That was the trouble with power. It made a man visible long before it made him safe.

The door latch lifted.

Korvath reached beneath his coat.

Brannoc drew his sword.

The door began to open.

The door opened inward.

A man stood beyond it in a cloak darkened by rain. Two soldiers flanked him, their hands resting near their blades, while more torchlight crowded the passage behind them. The flames gilded the wet stone and made the corridor seem to breathe.

Brannoc kept his sword low.

The cloaked man looked first at Korvath, then at the Thrice-Bound Edge clenched in Brannoc’s hand.

“Put it away,” he said.

Korvath’s fingers tightened beneath his coat. “You came to ask?”

“I came to prevent a slaughter.”

“That is a long way from asking.”

The man stepped over the threshold. He was not armored, but the soldiers behind him were, their mail dark with rain. No crest showed on the cloaks. That absence was more deliberate than any banner.

Brannoc watched the man’s eyes. They were pale, steady, and afraid in the way of men who had learned to make fear useful.

“Who sent you?” Brannoc asked.

The man’s gaze returned to him. “The same power that will be blamed when this room is found empty.”

“Then you have not answered.”

“No,” the man said. “I have not.”

The bell sounded below, deep enough to tremble through the floorboards. Somewhere in the yard, horses shifted and snorted. A command passed through the rain, too muffled to understand.

Korvath leaned toward Brannoc without lowering his voice. “That many torches means a search.”

“It means someone wants us to believe it does.”

“Does that distinction keep steel out of the ribs?”

“It has not yet failed me.”

Korvath gave him a look that held no admiration.

Brannoc had been born in 255 AS, into a house that had possessed no house-name worth preserving. He had learned early that men who called themselves masters preferred a blade that asked no questions. Later, when they discovered what ran beneath his silence, they had begun to ask questions with knives.

The unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown could not afford to be found in a locked room with a smuggler and a relic that had made the air go cold.

The man in the doorway extended one gloved hand.

“Give me The Thrice-Bound Edge.”

Brannoc felt the thing press against his palm, though his fingers were still wrapped around its hilt. It had been forged in 123 AS, long before the Sundering’s children learned to mistake inheritance for destiny. Its record contained no attunement cost. That omission had always troubled him more than a price would have.

“No,” he said.

The soldiers drew their blades.

Korvath cursed softly.

The cloaked man did not move. “You do not understand what is happening beneath this garrison.”

“Then explain it.”

“There is a book.”

Brannoc’s attention sharpened.

The man saw it. “Edge of Gloamreach.”

The name seemed to dim the room.

Korvath’s hand came free of his coat, holding a narrow knife. “That was not part of the bargain.”

“Neither was the army in the yard,” Brannoc said.

“I told you what I knew.”

“You told me what you wanted me to believe.”

“I told you enough to get us through the gate.”

“And now?”

“Now I am considering whether the gate was the clever part of the trap.”

The cloaked man turned his head toward Korvath. “The grimoire has an attunement cost of 46. Whoever opens it will pay.”

“Pay what?” Brannoc asked.

The man’s mouth hardened. “The record does not say.”

A gust struck the shutters. Rain hissed through the cracks, cold against Brannoc’s knuckles. He looked past the doorway to the passage. The soldiers had positioned themselves badly for a fight. Too close together. Too certain that fear would do the work for them.

That meant the cloaked man was not here to kill him.

Not yet.

“Where is the book?” Brannoc asked.

“Below.”

“How far?”

“Far enough.”

The bell sounded again.

This time the note was cut short, as though a hand had closed around its throat.

The cloaked man’s composure broke. He looked toward the stairwell.

A noise rose from beneath them—not a voice, not quite. It was the dragging groan of something immense passing through stone. Dust sifted from the ceiling. One of the soldiers crossed himself with two fingers, then stopped when he realized he had been seen.

Korvath’s eyes narrowed. “That beneath us?”

“Yes.”

“Then why bring us here?”

“Because it has begun.”

The Thrice-Bound Edge pulsed once in Brannoc’s hand.

The room’s shadows leaned toward it.

He had used the blade before. He had trusted it because trust was a word men used when they had run out of better options. It had cut through armor, bone, and bindings that no ordinary steel should have touched. Each time, afterward, something in the world had seemed to remember him.

He wondered whether the Edge had chosen him, or whether it merely recognized the shape of a man already bound.

“Tell me the truth,” Brannoc said.

The cloaked man’s face became very still.

“Do not mistake silence for obedience.”

“The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS,” the man said. “It ends in blood whether the parchment survives or not.”

“An accord does not end until someone signs it.”

“The Accord of Mournthrone ends in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.”

Korvath stared at him. “You speak as if you have already read the last page.”

“I speak as a man who has seen how victories are arranged.”

Brannoc heard the lie beneath the certainty. Not a lie about the years. A lie about how much the man knew.

The Accord of Mournthrone had the odor of old rot: sealed timber, wet banners, promises made where no witnesses could hear. If the Ashen Vanguard took the victory, the realm would call it order. The losing commander would be praised for courage or condemned for cowardice, depending on which side bought the louder singers. Beneath it all, the truth would remain—a losing commander bribed to withdraw.

Brannoc felt the thought settle in him like a stone.

The five powers were already circling the wound. The Ashen Vanguard would call it duty. House Morvain would call it inheritance. The Silent Choir would call it silence. The Iron-Ring Cartel would call it a market. The Bleeding Crown would call it blood.

None of them would call it what it was.

A door below slammed.

The soldiers looked at one another.

The cloaked man said, “You must choose now.”

Brannoc almost laughed. Choice had always been presented to him after the killing had begun.

“What waits below?”

“The Edge of Gloamreach.”

“And what waits outside?”

“Those who were sent to seize it.”

“By whom?”

The man said nothing.

Korvath stepped toward the shutter. “I can get us out through the roof.”

“You cannot,” Brannoc said.

“I have climbed worse.”

“The yard is watched.”

“Then we climb better.”

Brannoc glanced at him. “You are afraid.”

“I am a smuggler. Fear is the only honest thing I carry.”

The answer pleased him despite himself.

Another sound moved beneath the floor. This one was softer: a wet tapping, patient and irregular. Brannoc imagined fingers beneath the stones. He imagined the grimoire lying in darkness, waiting for a hand that could bear its cost.

The cloaked man drew a short blade from beneath his cloak. “If you refuse, I will order them to take the room.”

“You have already ordered them.”

“I have not ordered them to kill you.”

“That is not mercy.”

“No.”

Brannoc turned the Thrice-Bound Edge in his grip. The cold along its length deepened until his knuckles ached.

He had been called the Red-Handed long before the Bleeding Crown’s blood became a secret carried from mouth to mouth. The name had begun as an accusation, then hardened into a title. Men feared what it suggested. They feared a hand that had done too much killing to tremble at one more.

He had never told them the truth: his hand trembled often.

It trembled now.

Not from fear.

From recognition.

The Edge wanted the stairs.

“No one touches the book,” he said.

The cloaked man’s eyes lowered to the relic. “You do not command here.”

“Then stand aside.”

The first soldier lunged.

Brannoc moved before thought could catch him. He struck the man’s wrist with the flat of his sword, caught the descending blade against his own, and drove his shoulder into the soldier’s chest. Mail bit through cloth. The man hit the wall hard enough to rattle the torch bracket.

The second soldier came in low.

Korvath’s knife flashed. It found the gap beneath the man’s arm, and the soldier folded with a startled breath. Korvath caught him before he fell, lowering him with care that did not belong in a room about to become a slaughterhouse.

The cloaked man stood untouched.

Brannoc pointed his sword at him. "Open the way."

For one heartbeat, none of them moved.

Then the stone beneath the room split.

A black line opened across the floorboards. Cold air poured through it, carrying the smell of extinguished fires and something sweet beneath that, something like flowers left too long in a sealed grave.

Korvath backed away. "That was not there."

The cloaked man whispered, "It has found us."

The gap widened.

From below came a woman's voice, soft and clear, speaking a name Brannoc had not heard since before he knew what a crown was.

His sword lowered by a fraction.

The cloaked man saw it.

"So," he said. "It knows you."

The voice spoke again.

"Brannoc."

Not the name men used in camps, with a cup between their teeth and fear hidden behind laughter. Not the title bought with blood and repeated by heralds who had never watched a line break.

It spoke the name his mother had given him.

The floor opened another handspan. Beneath the boards lay no cellar, no foundation, no packed earth. There was only a depth of dark in which pale motes drifted upward, slow as ash falling in reverse.

Korvath Nightbrook swore under his breath and reached for the knife beneath his coat.

"Do not," said the cloaked man.

Korvath's hand froze. "You give orders now?"

"I give warnings."

"You gave one before. About the stone. We ignored it."

"And yet you are still alive."

"For how long?"

The woman below laughed softly.

Brannoc's grip tightened around his sword. The metal had gone cold enough to ache against his palm. He had heard that voice in a room of summer rain, long ago, when the world had still seemed to possess a shape beneath its ruin. He remembered the murmur of cloth. He remembered a crown laid upon black stone. He remembered kneeling, though he had never told himself before whom.

The memory was not his own.

That was the worst of it.

“What is under us?” he asked.

The cloaked man tilted his head toward the fissure. “A door.”

“To where?”

“To the part of the realm that survived.”

Korvath gave a brittle laugh. “That is a poet’s answer.”

“It is the only one you can afford.”

The gap widened with a sound like wet timber tearing. The room leaned toward it. Loose pebbles skittered across the floorboards, vanished into the dark, and made no sound when they fell.

Brannoc stepped back.

The thing below spoke his name a third time, and something inside him answered.

His sword arm jerked. The blade dipped toward the opening.

The cloaked man moved faster than a man in heavy cloth should have moved. He seized Brannoc’s wrist. The grip was neither strong nor weak. It was absolute.

“Let go.”

“If you strike the dark, it will strike through you.”

Brannoc turned his wrist, forcing the man’s fingers apart. “Then tell me what it wants.”

“It wants what was denied.”

The voice below breathed his name into the room.

Korvath’s face had gone grey beneath the grime. “You know it.”

“I know the hunger.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“No.” The cloaked man released Brannoc. “It is what you need to hear.”

Brannoc looked down into the wound in the floor. “You brought us here.”

“I brought you to a place where the lock was already failing.”

“To Crookvale?”

The cloaked man said nothing.

Brannoc knew the silence. It was the silence of a man guarding a bargain, or a corpse, or both.

Crookvale had been founded in 295 AS in The High Spires. Its rebuilt walls had taken their shape from necessity rather than beauty, crooked and hard-edged against the heights. A garrison of 1004 held it, though the settlement remained outside the core holdings. Men called it resilient when they wanted to praise it and wary when they wanted to excuse its refusal.

Brannoc had called it useful.

That had been before the floor opened.

“Who else knows this place?” he said.

“House Morvain knows enough to fear it.”

“The Ashen Vanguard?”

“Enough to burn it.”

“The Silent Choir?”

“Enough to listen.”

“And the Iron-Ring Cartel?”

The cloaked man’s hood turned a fraction. “Enough to sell what crawls out.”

The names settled among them like drawn blades. Beyond the warped shutters, wind worried at the walls. Somewhere in the rebuilt settlement, a bell began to ring. Once. Then silence. No alarm followed. Perhaps the bell had cracked. Perhaps those who heard it had decided ignorance was the safer allegiance.

Brannoc thought of the Bleeding Crown.

The name had been kept from him like a knife hidden beneath a child’s pillow. He had learned it through glances, through doors opening when they should have remained barred, through men who bowed only after checking who watched them. He was its unacknowledged heir. The knowledge had never made him feel chosen. It had made every kindness suspect.

The dark below stirred.

A pale hand rose through the fissure.

It was not flesh. It resembled the impression of a hand pressed into smoke, five long marks widening and narrowing as if the thing behind it had forgotten how fingers worked.

Korvath drew his knife.

This time the cloaked man did not stop him.

The smuggler slashed downward.

The blade passed through the pale hand. Frost burst along its edge. Korvath cried out and dropped it. The knife struck the boards and stood upright, quivering.

The hand closed around nothing.

Brannoc kicked the weapon away. “You have a talent for making things worse.”

Korvath clutched his wrist. “I have a talent for surviving men who say that.”

The hand sank.

Something struck the underside of the floor.

Once.

Dust fell from the rafters.

Again.

The walls answered with a low groan.

The cloaked man reached inside his coat and drew out a book bound in material too dark to be leather. Its clasp was a strip of tarnished metal twisted into the shape of a closed eye.

“Edge of Gloamreach,” he said.

Brannoc watched him. “A grimoire.”

“Attunement cost is 46.”

Korvath stared. “You bring a book into a sinking room?”

“A book is often the last thing standing when men stop.”

The clasp opened by itself.

The pages turned though there was no wind. Letters crawled over them in lines of dim grey, disappearing as quickly as they formed. Brannoc saw fragments: a road beneath a road, a mouth without a face, a crown carried in a basin of blood.

Then the book stopped.

One sentence darkened across the page.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed, born in 255 AS.

He felt the room contract around him.

Korvath looked from the page to Brannoc. “That is your name.”

“It is.”

“Why is it in there?”

“Because you are not as ignorant as you pretend,” said the cloaked man.

Brannoc took one step toward him. “You knew.”

“I knew the record.”

“You knew what I was.”

“I knew what the record called you.”

The fissure widened again. The boards at Brannoc’s feet bent toward the opening. He could feel the pull in his teeth.

The page turned.

Unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

Korvath’s breath escaped him as a small, wounded sound.

Brannoc did not look away from the cloaked man. “Read the rest.”

“No.”

“Read it.”

The cloaked man’s silence became an answer.

Brannoc seized the book. Its cover burned cold against his palm. The letters on the page blurred, then sharpened.

The record named the Accord of Mournthrone.

The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS and ended in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.

His thumb pressed into the margin until the page tore.

“Why show me this?”

The cloaked man’s voice had lost its calm. “Because the door has opened for you.”

“I did not ask it to.”

“Doors do not require permission from the man they were built to betray.”

A tremor passed through the walls. The book slipped in Brannoc’s grasp and fell open to another page.

The Accord of Mournthrone.

The words repeated themselves, smaller now, like a whisper behind the first.

Its collapse unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals.

Korvath looked toward the shutters. “A decade?”

“Not prophecy,” said the cloaked man. “Record.”

“Records can lie.”

“Then pray this one does.”

Brannoc stared at the page. Beneath the words, written in a darker hand, was the hidden truth: the losing commander was bribed to withdraw.

The knowledge entered him like a nail.

The Ashen Vanguard had not won by strength alone. The realm had not broken because its strongest hand had been beaten. Someone had opened the fist from within and called the fall an accord.

The door below gave a slow, hungry sigh.

“What happens in 300 AS?” Brannoc asked.

The cloaked man did not answer.

Brannoc turned the page himself.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed died in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone.

For a moment the room became very still.

Korvath whispered, “That cannot be.”

Brannoc looked at the words until they ceased to resemble letters. “It has not happened.”

“Not yet,” said the cloaked man.

The voice beneath them spoke with his mother’s tenderness.

“Come home.”

Brannoc’s sword rose.

The cloaked man stepped between him and the opening. “If you go down, the door closes.”

“If I stay?”

“It opens.”

“On what?”

The blackness beneath the floor brightened. Not with flame. With a colour that had no place in the world above, a dull crimson spreading through the depth like blood through water.

The woman’s voice came again.

“Come home, Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

Korvath backed into the wall. “That is not a woman.”

“No,” Brannoc said.

He understood now why the voice had known him. Why the dark had waited. Why the book had carried his death like an appointment.

It was not calling him toward a place.

It was calling him toward the shape of the man he would become.

The cloaked man lifted one hand. In it lay a narrow circlet of black metal, bound three times around itself.

“The Thrice-Bound Edge,” he said. “Regalia forged in 123 AS.”

Brannoc stared at it. “You expect a crown to save me?”

“No. I expect it to tell the door what you are.”

The floor split from wall to wall.

The room fell.

Korvath shouted. The cloaked man vanished behind a curtain of dust. Brannoc caught the edge of the table as the boards tilted steeply toward the dark. His sword tore free from his hand and slid away, spinning once before it disappeared.

Below, something vast drew breath.

The circlet struck the floor beside him.

Brannoc reached for it.

The woman began to sing.

Chapter 15

The rain came down black over Mournthrone.

It slicked the stones of the outer yard and drew the soot from the walls in long, bleeding runnels. Beneath the battlements, the campfires guttered in their pits. Men crouched around them with their cloaks drawn tight, their faces hollowed by smoke and hunger. Beyond the walls, the land fell away into darkness, and somewhere in that darkness a horn sounded once.

Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed stood beneath the broken archway and listened to the silence that followed.

A silence like a held breath.

His hand rested on the pommel at his hip. Not a famous blade. Not regalia. Steel made for work, its grip worn smooth by a sellsword's palm. He had carried it through sieges, mutinies, and the long ash-storms that followed the Sundering. It had never asked his name.

Men had.

They asked it now in whispers, when they thought he could not hear.

Ironmere.

Red-Handed.

Crown-blood.

The last was the most dangerous. The last was the lie that happened to be true.

He looked toward the inner keep, where a narrow window burned with candlelight. The room beyond it held the officers of the Accord of Mournthrone, and perhaps the fate of every bastard, soldier, and starving town beneath its shadow. The Accord of Mournthrone had begun in 297 AS. It would end in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.

He knew this with the same cold certainty with which he knew he would die in 300 AS during the Accord of Mournthrone.

The knowledge did not come as prophecy. It had no voice, no vision, no hand laid upon his shoulder. It lived inside him like a nail driven through bone. Some mornings he woke expecting to find the point protruding from his chest.

Tonight, he felt the nail turning.

A figure crossed the yard, hunched beneath a tarred cloak. He moved without hurry, which was the first mark of a man who knew how to flee. The second was that he never looked at the guards.

Brannoc watched him approach.

"Kneel," said one of the sentries.

The cloaked man stopped.

Rain ticked against the iron rings sewn into his boots. "If I kneel, I'll drown."

The sentry raised his spear.

Brannoc lifted two fingers. "Let him through."

The sentry glanced at him, then lowered the spear.

The man came beneath the archway. Water shone on his cheeks. He was not old, though caution had gathered around his eyes like another kind of age.

"Korvath Nightbrook," Brannoc said.

The smuggler's mouth tightened. "You say it as though it's a crime."

"Most names are."

Korvath looked past him toward the keep. "You're expected."

"I'm seldom expected anywhere worth going."

"There's a room above the eastern stair."

"By whom?"

"By those who have coins enough to expect."

Brannoc smiled without warmth. "The Iron-Ring Cartel?"

Korvath did not answer.

The rain whispered between them. From the wall, a soldier coughed into his sleeve. Somewhere behind the keep, a horse screamed, and another answered.

Brannoc studied the smuggler's hands. No visible weapon. That meant nothing. A man who moved contraband through hostile country did not survive by carrying what everyone expected him to carry.

"What did they buy?" Brannoc asked.

"Silence."

"Expensive."

"Not theirs."

Korvath drew a small object from beneath his cloak. He did not offer it at once. A coin lay across his palm, dull beneath the rainwater. Its face had been shaved smooth. Its edge bore a shallow notch.

Brannoc felt the old nail turn.

"Where?" he asked.

"In the chapel of the Bleeding Crown."

"There is no chapel here."

"There is a room they call one."

"And the coin?"

"Payment."

"For what?"

Korvath's eyes flicked toward the keep. "For withdrawal."

The word entered Brannoc more cleanly than a blade.

He took the coin. It was cold, but beneath the cold lay the greasy warmth of a hand that had held it too long. A bribe left its own stain. Not visible. Never visible. It clung to the mind.

The losing commander had been bribed to withdraw.

That was the hidden truth beneath the Accord of Mournthrone, beneath the speeches, beneath the banners and the solemn oaths. Men would call it exhaustion. They would call it prudence. They would call it a victory earned by the Ashen Vanguard through discipline and sacrifice.

They would not call it purchased.

Brannoc closed his fingers around the coin.

“Why bring this to me?”

“I didn’t.”

The smuggler nodded toward the keep. “They sent for you.”

“Then you brought it to them.”

“I carried it where I was paid to carry it.”

“And now?”

“Now I’m here.”

“That isn’t an answer.”

“It’s the only one that survives.”

Korvath turned away.

Brannoc caught his sleeve. The cloth was rough and wet. Korvath went still, not frightened—simply ready.

“Who paid you?”

The smuggler looked at Brannoc’s hand, then at his face. “A man who didn’t want his name remembered.”

“Everyone wants that.”

“No. Some men want their names remembered. They just want the wrong names spoken.”

Brannoc released him.

A bell sounded from the keep.

Once.

The guards straightened. The men around the fires lowered their voices. Above the wall, the banners stirred in the rain: the Ashen Vanguard’s ash-gray field, House Morvain’s dark device, the pale marks of the Silent Choir, the iron colors of the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the torn crimson of the Bleeding Crown.

Five powers, each pretending the realm could still be divided cleanly.

The Ashen Vanguard held the roads where roads remained. House Morvain held old stone and older grievances. The Silent Choir kept its counsels behind veils and locked doors. The Iron-Ring Cartel

weighed hunger against silver. The Bleeding Crown possessed less land than memory, but memory was a weapon that did not rust.

Brannoc had been born in 255 AS beneath that last banner's shadow, though no herald had written his name beneath it. He was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

A crown did not need to acknowledge a man to kill him.

He slipped the coin into his glove.

"Will you enter?" Korvath asked.

"I was summoned."

"That wasn't what I asked."

Brannoc looked up at the keep. The candle in the eastern window burned steadily despite the wind. A trap was often most convincing when it offered shelter.

"Wait here," he said.

Korvath gave a quiet laugh. "I don't wait anywhere."

Brannoc passed beneath the arch.

The stair smelled of wet wool, lamp oil, and old mortar. Mournthrone had been built to endure the end of the world and had discovered, centuries later, that walls could not keep out treachery. His boots rang against the steps. He counted them without meaning to, then stopped himself. Counting made men believe they had power over what came next.

At the landing, a narrow display case stood behind cloudy glass.

Within it rested The Thrice-Bound Edge.

The regalia had been forged in 123 AS. No attunement cost was recorded for it. Its shape was restrained: dark metal, pale binding, three severe lines joined without ornament. It did not gleam. It seemed to drink the candlelight and hold it beneath its surface.

Brannoc had seen kings reach for lesser things with steadier hands.

He paused before the case.

The Thrice-Bound Edge conveyed no promise of triumph. Only binding. A thing made to close around a wrist, a vow, a throat.

He moved on.

The eastern room was open. Warm light spilled across the corridor.

Inside, a table had been set with maps, sealed letters, and untouched food. No one spoke when Brannoc entered. That silence told him more than any greeting could have done.

He saw the grimoire first.

Edge of Gloamreach lay upon the table, its cover black-blue beneath the candle flame. The title had been pressed into the leather in letters that seemed to recede when looked at directly. It was a grimoire, and its attunement cost was 46. No forging date had been recorded.

Beside it lay a folded dispatch bearing the mark of Fenspire.

The spire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, a core location with a garrison of 3,742 and a garrisoned status. Even from this room Brannoc could imagine its silhouette rising above the dim country: stark, watchful, permanent. Fenspire did not sleep. It occupied the land as a blade occupied flesh.

Another map showed Crookvale.

Founded in 295 AS in The High Spires, rebuilt after whatever had broken it, Crookvale retained a garrison of 1004 but remained outside the core holdings. The mark on the map was crooked and hard-edged, like the settlement itself. A place wary enough to call survival a law.

Brannoc looked from one mark to the other.

“Fenspire,” he said. “Crookvale.”

No one answered.

At the far end of the table, a sealed letter lay beneath a black stone. The stone was wet.

Not rainwater.

Brannoc’s gaze lowered to the floor.

A thin red thread ran beneath the door.

His hand found his sword.

The candles leaned all at once, though there was no wind in the room.

Then someone behind him whispered, “Red-Handed.”

Brannoc turned.

The door slammed shut.

From the corridor came the sound of Korvath Nightbrook shouting, followed by the hard, wet impact of a body striking stone. The room’s occupants rose together. Chairs scraped. Steel whispered free.

Brannoc did not draw his sword.

The coin in his glove had begun to bleed.

He felt the warmth spread across his palm, felt it seep between his fingers, and somewhere beneath the keep a second bell began to ring as the voice behind him said—

“—the Accord has already chosen its dead.”

The voice did not come from the room. It came through the coin.

Brannoc closed his fist around it. Blood welled between his knuckles, hot as a forge-runner’s breath. Across the chamber, the others had formed a ragged half-circle around the sealed door. Swords pointed at the wood. No one looked toward him. No one wanted to be the first to admit that the whisper had spoken from his hand.

Beyond the door, Korvath Nightbrook groaned.

“Open it,” said one of the men.

No one moved.

The second bell sounded again beneath the keep. Its note crawled through the floorstones and into Brannoc's teeth. Dust sifted from the ceiling. The flames guttered blue, then returned to their weak yellow.

Brannoc looked at the door.

A smear marked the stone beneath it, dark and shining. Korvath had fallen there, or something wearing the shape of him had. The smuggler had entered the chamber an hour earlier with rain in his hair and a sealed packet beneath his coat. He had spoken little. That was Korvath's nature: guarded, wary, always measuring the distance between a secret and a knife.

Now he made no sound.

"Brannoc," said the oldest of the gathered men.

The captain heard the accusation hidden in his name. You brought this. You knew it would come. You are the red hand at every threshold.

He released the coin.

It remained in his palm.

"Back away from the door," he said.

The men glanced at one another.

"Why?"

"Because I told you."

The command carried the hard weight earned by a seasoned sellsword, and habit obeyed before fear could argue. Steel lowered. Boots scraped over stone. Brannoc crossed the chamber alone.

The coin lay flat in his hand now, though it had not fallen. Its surface had become soft and black, as if the metal had remembered being blood. Lines opened across it, forming the image of a crown pierced through by a thorn.

The Bleeding Crown.

His breath slowed.

No one in the room knew the truth. They knew him as Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed, a major Sellsword Captain whose contracts had carried him from ash-field to ash-field. They knew the price of his sword. They knew the danger of refusing it. They did not know he was the unacknowledged heir to the Bleeding Crown.

Not even Korvath had known that.

Perhaps Korvath had known too much.

The voice returned.

"You were born in 255 AS."

Brannoc's fingers tightened. The coin bit him.

"Silence."

“You will die in 300 AS.”

The chamber seemed to contract around him. The men heard nothing; their faces remained fixed on the door. One of them raised his sword again, watching the crack beneath the threshold as if death might be persuaded to enter politely.

Brannoc stared at the blackened coin.

“Who speaks?”

The answer came as a sigh from the walls.

“The one who keeps the account.”

A line of red appeared upon the door. It began at the latch and traveled upward, thin as a vein beneath skin. When it reached the lintel, the entire slab shuddered.

One of the men cursed.

The door opened inward.

Korvath Nightbrook lay beyond it on the corridor stones, folded beneath himself. His coat had torn from throat to belt. No blood spread from the wound. Instead, the red thread from beneath the door had emerged from his ribs and continued into the chamber, where it now curled around Brannoc’s wrist.

The smuggler’s eyes opened.

“Don’t,” Korvath whispered.

Brannoc stepped over the threshold.

“What happened?”

Korvath’s gaze found the coin. Whatever he saw there drained the little color left in his face.

“It came for the packet.”

“Where is it?”

“Not here.”

“You carried it here.”

“I carried a decoy.”

A soft murmur moved through the room behind Brannoc. Fear had a way of making men generous with their suspicions.

The red thread tightened around his wrist.

Korvath clawed at the stone. “It knows the Crown.”

“Who does?”

The smuggler’s mouth worked. His answer came wetly.

“The Choir.”

The words seemed to darken the corridor.

The Silent Choir had no single voice, yet every whisper attributed to it arrived with the weight of a verdict. Brannoc had crossed their routes before. He had found whole wagons abandoned in snowless fields, their drivers seated upright, mouths sewn shut with pale cord. He had never seen the faces beneath the hoods. He had never needed to.

Behind him, someone said, "The Silent Choir is in the keep."

"No," Brannoc answered.

He did not know whether he spoke from certainty or command.

The thread around his wrist pulled.

He followed it into the chamber. It ran across the floor, climbed the leg of the table, and entered the leather satchel Korvath had brought. The satchel trembled as though a small animal struggled inside.

Brannoc drew his sword.

The blade came free with a sound like a breath being taken by the dead.

"Burn it," said Korvath.

"There is no fire hot enough."

"Then cut it."

Brannoc laid the edge against the satchel.

The coin laughed.

The sound was small. Almost tender.

The red thread snapped.

Every candle went out.

Darkness swallowed the room. Men shouted. Someone struck at something unseen, and the blow met flesh; a cry broke sharply and fell silent. Brannoc heard feet stumbling, heard steel ring against stone, heard the old, familiar music of panic.

Then the satchel opened.

A pale light spilled from it, not bright but depthless, the color of twilight beneath deep water. Within the leather lay a book bound in hide that shifted beneath its stitching.

The cover bore a title.

Edge of Gloamreach.

Brannoc had seen the grimoire once, at a distance, in the hands of a dead scholar whose fingers had been burned to the bone. Its attunement cost was 46. That number had been written in every warning concerning it, as if the act of naming the price might keep anyone from paying.

The grimoire opened by itself.

Pages turned in a wind that did not touch Brannoc's coat.

Symbols crawled across the paper. Their shapes refused to settle. He felt them pressing against the inside of his skull, seeking a place to root.

“Look away,” Korvath said.

Brannoc did not.

A second object rested beneath the book, wrapped in gray cloth. The cloth had fallen back. Beneath it lay The Thrice-Bound Edge, regalia forged in 123 AS. Its surface was neither sword nor crown nor chain, but held the suggestion of all three: a binding thing, restrained and severe.

No attunement cost had ever been recorded for The Thrice-Bound Edge.

That absence had always troubled him more than any price.

The light from Edge of Gloamreach passed over it. Three lines of darkness appeared upon the regalia, crossing and knotting without touching.

The men behind Brannoc fell quiet.

He felt the room listening.

A voice spoke from the open grimoire.

“The five powers gather.”

The page displayed five marks.

A clenched fist wreathed in ash: the Ashen Vanguard.

A dark crown scored with red: House Morvain.

A closed mouth stitched in silver: the Silent Choir.

A ring of iron surrounding a coin: the Iron-Ring Cartel.

And the thorn-pierced crown: the Bleeding Crown.

“They contend over the ruins,” said the voice. “They call it law when they take. They call it order when they burn. They call it peace when the graves are full.”

Brannoc’s sword remained level.

“Why show me this?”

“Because the Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS.”

The chamber groaned. Somewhere below, the bell answered.

“It will end in 301 AS with the Ashen Vanguard named victor.”

Korvath gave a strangled laugh. “That is not prophecy. That is a sentence.”

“The losing commander will be bribed to withdraw.”

Brannoc’s gaze shifted toward the black window. Beyond the glass, the night had no stars. Only the faint red wash of distant fires stained the underside of the clouds.

The Accord was supposed to bind the powers long enough for the realm to breathe. Instead, its words had been sharpened into weapons before the wax cooled. He had watched nobles praise it over silver cups while counting the soldiers they meant to spend. He had watched House Morvain smile at the Ashen Vanguard. He had watched the Iron-Ring Cartel sell grain to both sides and powder to the side that paid

late. He had watched the Silent Choir pass through every gate without being searched.

And beneath all of it, like a buried pulse, the Bleeding Crown waited.

“What happens after?” Brannoc asked.

The page turned.

“Reprisals.”

A single word, written in red.

“A decade of guerrilla reprisals.”

The men behind him shifted. One whispered a prayer without naming its object.

Brannoc looked down at Korvath. “You brought this to me because of the Crown.”

Korvath swallowed blood. “I brought it because they said only your hand could open the way.”

“Who said?”

The smuggler’s eyes slid toward the grimoire.

“The dead.”

Brannoc almost smiled. There was no humor in it.

He had trusted the living because they lied for reasons. The dead lied without need.

The coin in his hand grew hot again. The crown upon it split down the middle. A black line ran across the image, widening until the metal bent like a mouth.

The voice whispered close against his ear.

“Choose, Brannoc Ironmere the Red-Handed.”

The door behind him slammed shut.

This time, the men screamed.

The grimoire’s pages began to turn faster. The Thrice-Bound Edge rose from the table, turning slowly in the pale light. No hand held it. No chain restrained it. Its three dark lines uncoiled and reached toward Brannoc.

He felt the buried claim inside him stir.

Not blood. Not birthright.

Something older than both.

From the corridor came the sound of many bare feet approaching at once.

Korvath caught Brannoc’s boot. “If you take it, they will see you.”

“Who?”

The footsteps stopped outside the door.

A voice spoke from the other side, calm and familiar.

“Open, Red-Handed.”

Brannoc knew that voice.

He had heard it at contract tables, beneath rain, in the brittle silence after a surrender.

The voice of a man who had not yet died.

The coin split in Brannoc’s palm.

The Thrice-Bound Edge drifted nearer.

And in the darkness behind the door, Korvath began to weep.

Brannoc did not open the door.

The voice waited with the patience of a drawn bow.

Korvath’s fingers tightened around his boot. The smuggler had gone pale in the dark, his tears shining like oil where they tracked through the dust on his face.

“You know him,” Brannoc said.

Korvath shook his head.

The door gave a soft wooden sigh. Not from pressure. From recognition.

“Open,” said the voice again. “There is no profit in making me ask.”

Brannoc looked down at the coin in his palm. The split had widened. Within its broken face, something black moved against the metal, a darkness too deliberate to be a flaw. The Thrice-Bound Edge had come close enough that its cold entered his bones.

He had seen regalia before, in war tents and ruined halls: crowns that carried old promises, swords that demanded new ones, rings worn by men who believed the world had been made to fit their hands. This was none of those things. The Thrice-Bound Edge did not glitter. It waited.

Behind him, the grimoire lay open on the floor.

Edge of Gloamreach.

Its pages turned without wind. Each leaf whispered against the next, a dry, intimate sound, like a tongue testing a wound. The script upon them was not written in ink. It was written in the bruised color beneath the skin.

“Tell me who stands outside,” Brannoc said.

Korvath’s breath came thin and fast. “A dead man.”

“That is not a name.”

“It is enough of one.”

The feet in the corridor shifted. Many of them. Bare soles upon old stone. No one spoke. Their silence was worse than a crowd’s anger. It had the obedience of a congregation.

Brannoc rose from his crouch.

The claim inside him stirred again—not blood, not birthright, but something older than both. It moved through his chest with the slow certainty of a buried wheel. He had spent years strangling that sensation whenever it surfaced. A man could survive a blade. A man could survive treachery. A man could even survive learning that the crown he had served had never meant to acknowledge him.

What he could not survive was wanting it.

The Bleeding Crown had endured as an idea longer than any living claimant. Its name had crossed battlefields in whispers, passed from hand to hand beneath cloaks, offered to captains who understood the difference between authority and fear. Brannoc had been its unacknowledged heir, though no oath had ever been spoken over him, no seal pressed into wax for him, no court had opened its doors.

He had been born in 255 AS.

The knowledge came now with no memory attached to it. A bare fact, cold as a nail.

Korvath stared at him. “Do not take the edge.”

“You told me that before.”

“I was hoping you had not heard.”

“You are a smuggler, Korvath Nightbrook. Hope is a poor trade for you.”

A broken laugh escaped the man. It died quickly.

Outside, the familiar voice said, “You always did mistake refusal for strength.”

Brannoc’s hand went to the hilt at his side. The gesture was useless. His sword had been left somewhere beyond the chamber, along with the rest of the world that still obeyed ordinary distances.

“Why are you here?” Brannoc called.

“To collect what was promised.”

“No promise was made.”

“There is always a promise. Sometimes it is made by the hand. Sometimes by the blood. Sometimes by the coward who waits behind a door.”

Korvath pressed his forehead to the floor.

Brannoc glanced at him. “You brought me here.”

“I carried you here.”

“You brought me.”

“I was paid to find the passage.”

“By whom?”

Korvath’s lips trembled. “You know.”

The answer struck harder than a confession.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had paid men to move weapons through places no map admitted existed. House Morvain had paid men to forget what they saw. The Silent Choir had paid in favors that outlived coin. The Ashen Vanguard paid in law, when law could still be found. And the Bleeding Crown—if the old stories

were more than the fevered invention of dispossessed soldiers—paid in inevitability.

Brannoc looked again at the coin.

“Who paid you?”

Korvath’s eyes lifted. “The voice.”

The door opened.

No hand touched it.

The chamber beyond was not the corridor Brannoc remembered. There was no torchlight, no fallen plaster, no cramped passage crowded with bare feet. A long hall stretched into darkness beneath a ceiling lost in shadow. Pale figures stood along its walls, their heads bowed. Their mouths had been sewn shut with black thread.

At the far end stood a man in a weather-darkened coat.

Brannoc knew the posture before he knew the face. The slight forward tilt of the shoulders. The habit of keeping one hand near the belt, not from fear but from arithmetic. The stillness of a commander who had learned that every motion was witnessed and every hesitation priced.

The man’s face remained indistinct.

That was the cruelty of it. Brannoc knew the voice, the gait, the shape of the silence around him, but the face had been taken away.

“Step through,” the man said.

The figures along the hall bowed lower.

Brannoc did not move.

The Thrice-Bound Edge drifted past his shoulder. It entered the hall without touching the floor, without making a sound. The moment it crossed the threshold, the sewn mouths opened.

A single breath passed through them.

The chamber filled with the smell of wet ash.

Korvath made a small, broken noise. “You see? It knows you.”

“It knows what I am.”

“No.” Korvath crawled backward. “That is worse.”

Brannoc turned toward him. “What did you bring me to?”

The smuggler’s gaze fixed upon the open grimoire. “Fenspire.”

The name seemed to draw the darkness tighter.

Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, its stark spire raised above a land where daylight always seemed to arrive wounded. It was a core location, garrisoned by 3,742, and whatever stood beyond this door carried its discipline: the cold vigilance of a place that had learned to sleep with its weapons in hand.

But Brannoc had never seen Fenspire like this.

He had seen its outer walls once from a distance, under a sky thick with black weather. He had seen the watchfires and the ordered movement of soldiers. No one had spoken of a hall beneath it, or a congregation with sewn mouths, or a regalia that floated like a patient executioner.

Korvath said, "The book opened the way."

"You opened the book."

"I touched the clasp."

"And then?"

"And then it knew your name."

The voice at the end of the hall softened. "Names are such small doors."

Brannoc stepped across the threshold.

The dead—or whatever passed for dead within that place—did not look at him. Their heads remained bowed. Their hands hung at their sides, palms turned outward. Each palm bore a dark line from wrist to finger, as if a blade had once been drawn there and had left a road for something to follow.

Behind him, Korvath whimpered.

Brannoc did not turn. "Stay."

"Where?"

"Here."

"I cannot."

"You can."

"I cannot."

The hall's darkness leaned toward them.

Brannoc advanced, and the voice came with him, though the man at the far end did not move.

"You served the Ashen Vanguard," it said.

"I sold my sword."

"To the Ashen Vanguard."

"To whoever paid."

"You speak as though coin absolves the hand."

"It keeps the hand fed."

"And when the hand is asked to crown?"

Brannoc stopped.

The Thrice-Bound Edge hovered before him, its shape now clearer: not a sword, not a crown, but a length of dark metal bound three times by pale bands. No edge could be seen, yet the air near it parted in narrow, trembling lines.

“Who asks?” Brannoc said.

The man at the end of the hall inclined his head.

Behind the figures, something scraped along the walls.

“Every power that has survived the Sundering,” the voice said. “The Ashen Vanguard. House Morvain. The Silent Choir. The Iron-Ring Cartel. The Bleeding Crown.”

“They do not ask for the same thing.”

“They never have.”

“Then why show me?”

“Because you are the place where their demands meet.”

Brannoc felt the buried claim turn within him.

He hated the voice for finding it. Hated Korvath for bringing him here. Hated the dead for bowing as if they had been awaiting his arrival since before he was born.

“What do they want?”

“The Vanguard wants a victor. House Morvain wants a puppet. The Choir wants silence. The Cartel wants a market. The Crown wants a body.”

“And you?”

The man’s blurred face tilted.

“I want the truth to remain expensive.”

A tremor passed through the hall.

The grimoire’s pages began to turn faster behind him. Brannoc heard Korvath cry out, then the scrape of his knees as he retreated. The book spoke in a language made of pressure. The meaning entered Brannoc through his teeth.

He saw a battlefield under a sky the color of old iron.

He saw banners lowered without surrender.

He saw the losing commander standing alone in a tent while a purse of coin rested unopened upon the table.

He saw the commander’s hand close around it.

The vision broke.

Brannoc swayed.

The man at the far end said, “The hidden truth is that the losing commander was bribed to withdraw.”

Brannoc tasted copper.

“The Accord of Mournthrone,” he said.

“Began in 297 AS.”

The hall shuddered.

“Ended in 301 AS.”

The sewn mouths opened wider, though no lips tore. A wind moved through them and carried the stink of extinguished fires.

“The Ashen Vanguard was named victor,” the voice continued. “Then the accord collapsed, and a decade of guerrilla reprisals was unleashed.”

Brannoc saw villages without names. Roads marked by bodies. Children learning which banners to fear. Men returning from the hills with faces hidden beneath ash. He saw victory written in proclamations while the dead continued to argue beneath the soil.

“What does that have to do with me?”

The Thrice-Bound Edge turned once.

Its point—or what should have been its point—settled against his chest.

The cold entered him.

“You died in 300 AS,” said the voice.

Brannoc’s heart stopped.

Not slowed. Not faltered.

Stopped.

Korvath screamed behind him.

The hall vanished.

For one instant Brannoc stood beneath a sky torn open by the Sundering. He felt steel enter him. He smelled rain on dust. He heard men shouting the name of Mournthrone, though none of them could see his face.

Then the darkness returned, and his heart began again with a single brutal beat.

The Thrice-Bound Edge had entered his chest without breaking skin.

The man at the far end lifted one hand.

“Take it,” he said. “Let them see you.”

Brannoc looked down.

The pale bindings around the artifact had begun to unravel. Beneath them, something waited—something shaped like a crown, something shaped like a wound.

And from far beyond the hall, from every ruined power and every throne that had not yet admitted its fear, came the sound of a door beginning to open.